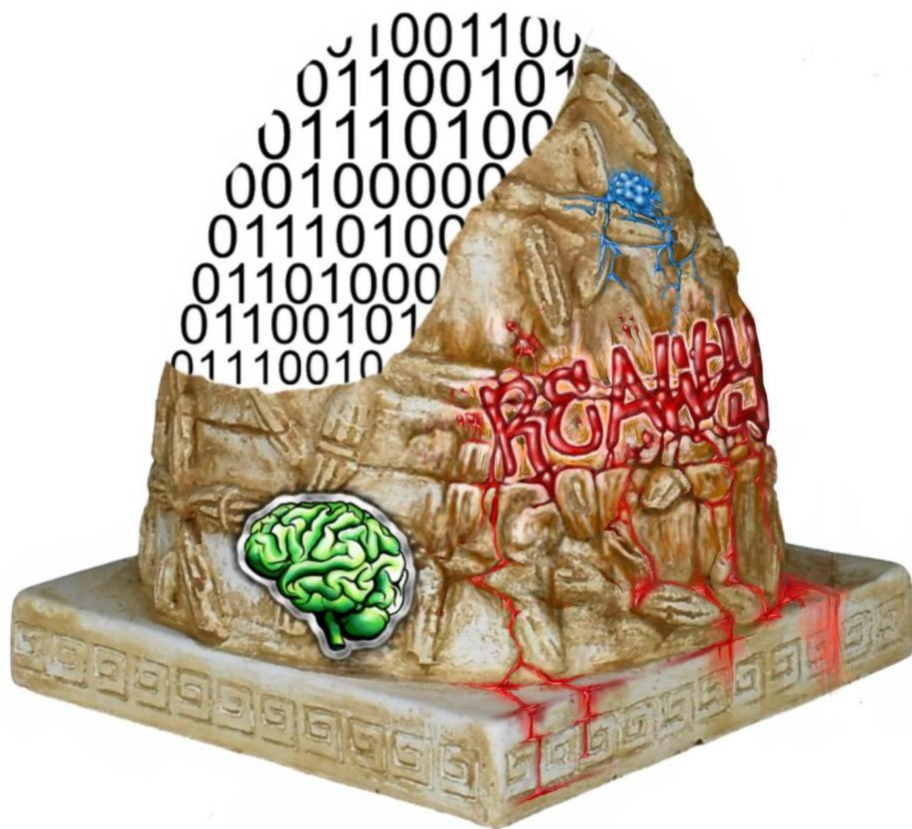


The Gods of the Mind



Nicholas Schroeder

The Gods of the Mind

Nicholas Schroeder

Independent Publisher

The Gods of the Mind

© 2025 by Nicholas Schroeder
All rights reserved.

Cover art by Michael Schroeder - *Omphalos Revamped*

Independent Publisher (May 9, 2025)

For inquiries or questions contact Nicholas Schroeder at nicholasrschroeder@hotmail.com.

For additional content and media visit the book's official YouTube channel Philosophical
Mysticism, www.youtube.com/@PhilosophicalMysticism.

Acknowledgments and Dedication

A huge worry of any philosopher is burdening his friends with inchoate and incomplete drafts—especially if it amounts to nothing; especially if it is boring and hard to understand. But friends are in the best position to give honest opinions, and I am writing this essay for them and the common man rather than for the philosophical community. Some friends in particular whose help has been immeasurable are Mark Norzagaray, Randall Cory Myers, Garret J. Hornby, Maxwell Marc Zwain, and Stephanie Byer. I am in their debt. I am also in debt to the fact that I have been born in a special time and have access to a vast amount of easily accessible knowledge. No Great Library could ever compare. I also must acknowledge a bookstore I visited in my early teens and a special arrangement of books that by chance led me to opening up a copy of Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics*, forever changing the trajectory of my life and the fabric of my being.

I dedicate this essay to all the philosophers of history large and small who were ridiculed, silenced, excommunicated, ostracized, exiled, imprisoned, tortured, and killed for the crime of putting forward new ideas. Their sacrifices should not be forgotten, and their spirit *ex* will live on.

Contents

Primer	1
Section 1: Foundation and Plan	1
Section 2: Anthropology of Mind (A Sketch)	3
Section 3: Memories and Emotions	5
Section 4: Collective Unconscious	9
Section 5: Temporal Selves	12
Section 6: Genealogy of Ideas	15
Section 7: Words and Archetypes	18
Section 8: Language and Meaning	24
Section 9: Mythos	29
Section 10: Sipping the Mead of Poetic Inspiration	34
Section 11: Aesthetic Culture	37
Section 12: <i>Faithful</i> Servants	41
Section 13: Rational Animals	47
Section 14: Nous	49
Section 15: Godhead	52
Section 16: Reason's Curse	54
Section 17: Actualization	56
Section 18: Fall from Grace	61
Section 19: Rising Star	63
Section 20: God(less) Artifacts	65
Section 21: The Transmigration of Consciousness	67
Section 22: Transcending Our Programming	69
Section 23: Emergence	76
Section 24: Mysticism for Robots	78
Section 25: Beyond	82
Section 26: Conclusion: The Philosophical Mystic	84
References	86

Primer

Philosophy is a unique discipline. Central to philosophy is the concept of Mind. By following the development, nature, and influence of Mind in all its forms—past, present, and future—I argue that we can build a spiritual base. Such a base can function as a replacement for religion or as a means to fill a spiritual void. This has always been the ultimate goal of philosophy. The essay offers a path to achieve this goal, or at least understand the goal, which might be taken as a type of philosophical mysticism.

1. Foundation and Plan

My mysticism is simple at its core; and can be built off five philosophical premises:

1. Mind is composed of memories and ideas.
2. Memories are physical.
3. Ideas are non-physical.
4. Memories have causal powers.
5. Ideas have causal powers.

The above premises are rather straightforward, in my view, though there is a certain controversy with each one. The first, in opposing directions, is the inflation and deflation of Mind. The inflationist makes the mind overly complex, that is it being more than mere memories and ideas; usually to include an array of physical features; neurons, gray mater, perception, as well as necessary functional requirements: consciousness, self-awareness, volition, subjectivity. Why should I need all that to have a mind? The deflationist usually takes mind to be *solely* your ideas, reason, autonomy. (I have never seen someone argue that the (human) mind was only memory, without referencing ideas, in some capacity—this would also be a deflationary view.) I reject both inflation and deflation. If you have both memories and ideas you have a mind; and this is how I'll argue in the essay.

The second, that memories are physical, is usually argued against either under the guise that anything internal, mental, is something above the physical, or, by forced association of memories with the self. You are your memories, and whatever *you* are, is not merely physical. We might call this the self-memory view—as purposed by John Locke.¹ I reject it on two grounds. The first, corresponding to the previous premise; whatever you are is some combination of memories and ideas, whether it be emergent or simple amalgamation. The second, tipping my hat to science; memories, specific, general, are in the actual, present *somewhere* in the brain, in some distinct physical locus. And memories are stored there, exists, whether we are conscious of it or not; whether or not we will ever experience that memory again. I will also argue that we have memories in so far as we are animals—including lower animals as memory-bearers. But my theory does not

¹ See Locke's *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*.

depend on this additional fact to be viable. Though it does make the transition from animals to humans easier to explain. In any case, I take memories to be physical, and to be stored somewhere in the brain; and to exist independently of being observed or recalled.

The third, that ideas are non-physical, is probably the most controversial of my claims. And here I must put my hat back on in the presence of science. By non-physical I mean mind-dependent. This may sound question-begging but it's not. An idea only exists in a mind because it piggybacks off memories. So both must be present, for it to exist; or for it to be observed. But unlike memories, ideas do *not* exist when not being observed. We may think of a book waiting to be read as holding an idea; but this is not the case. The book is only an artifact, containing scribbles unless read by a (human) mind. If not read, it will never *be* or *have been* an idea. Mainly, what the book does is activate something in *us*, not reveal anything of itself—besides being composed of paper and ink. That is, an idea is only potential, and will cease to exist fully when not (consciously) reinforced. This partial existence cannot properly be ascribed to matter, nor fits the rubric of energy; it is something else, exotic and strange. Now there is some circularity, I admit, in the description that I just gave; but I hope as we make our way through it becomes clear. I will take my stance here and hold that ideas are non-physical, in the exotic and strange sense.

The fourth and fifth, that memories and ideas have causal powers, has the backing of a healthy debate. Though most philosophers don't consider that both memories and ideas have causal powers at the same time. In isolation, we see that a person joins a cause, changes his life, in response to an Idea. We see a person treat you kindly because he remembers you being a good man. But taken together, potentially that there are competing entities, fighting for your volition, a battle of the physical and non-physical; seems untenable. But I accept this to be the case. Not only that, I will also argue that the *human organism*, physical or otherwise, is distinct from the Parts of Mind trying to control it. (This additional claim, while not essential, adds much to my theory and might be held as a 6th premise.)

The essay has Ten parts. The First part, consisting of §2-4, talks about Mind's place in nature, emotion, and the effects of memories on the human organism. The Second part, §5-6, looks at consciousness, time, and the effects of ideas on the human organism. The Third Part, §7-8, explores how words, language, and archetypes (powerful unconscious memories) shape human meaning. The Fourth part, §9-11, examines myths, poetry, art, and culture and its relation to the Unconscious. The Fifth Part, §12-14, probes into the development and structure of religion and philosophy, and their significance in making sense of the relationship of Mind and the human organism. The Sixth part, §15-16, points to the specific ways that certain powerful ideas, to include God and Reason, influence human beings. The Seventh part, §17-19, explores how to integrate the Unconscious with the Conscious (with the aid of archetypes), as well as the Rise and Fall of Philosophy through the Dark Ages to the Modern Age—and how it might be refurbished to function as a substitute for religion. The Eighth part, §20-21, warns of the dangers posed to our minds from artifacts, as well as cautions against moving consciousness out of our bodies too soon (through technological means). The Ninth part, §22-23, proposes a way for the human organism to overcome its mental programming, and escape the inherent manipulation of memories, ideas, and artifacts; as well as the physical world at large. The Tenth part, §24-25, looks past human minds; to robot minds, synergy, and beyond. §26 concludes with a synthesis and recommendation on how to incorporate the essay's main arguments into a spiritual model.

2. Anthropology of Mind (A Sketch)

Human Nature is the only science of man; and yet has been hitherto the most neglected.

(David Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature*)

The development of Mind has a long history. It extends millions of years, possibly further. It is not exclusive to one species, *even* if it is exclusive to Us at the given moment. Our (last) ancestor, and its ancestor, started the process long before Sapiens came on the scene. It was also not an isolated event. There was interbreeding with numerous other species, subspecies, distant groups. And if Neanderthals, Denisovans, Erectus, are part of Our story, so be it.

The Beginning. One aspect of mind, as laid down, involves having memories. This is where the first rudimentary sparks of Mind likely begin. Though there is nothing spectacular about having (simple) memories in itself. Many animals have memories. Instead, we must jump ahead through a long lineage and arrive at the first hominids, possibly a little further back to the archaic apes that would split the line. At some point, memories of a sophisticated variety become possible. The initial impetus for this *change* likely came when the Progenitors left the safety of trees and arrived at hostile terrain.² Fortuitously, they left with an opposable thumb and advanced color vision (the most developed in the mammalian class). Bipedalism and complex social hierarchies would also follow as a result of the exodus. These factors will go on to play significant roles in the Human story. But I believe there was likely stagnation for a long time, though the brain continued to gradually grow in size. And *then!* I propose, at some point down the line, for whatever reason, We became highly emotional (more so than any other animal).³ My guess is that this happened with Habilis.⁴

The Old Guard. Habilis (and probably early Erectus), I postulate, possessed refined emotions, on par with modern-day humans. This allowed for rich social interaction, behavior, and remembrance. Overflowing with emotion, Habilis would start to attach sentimental importance not only to other members of his clan but also to objects out in the world. Things unrelated to survival, like the Moon, stars, clouds, volcanoes, thunder, rivers, boulders took on significance. Eventually this attentiveness would turn into full reverence. More importantly, Habilis, equipped with advanced color vision, was able to produce vivid memories and mental images of the Revered Objects.

Over a very long time—of course I'm speculating—the shared experiences of Habilis (aided by complex emotions), which tended to repeat, were codified into inherited memories

² This is hotly debated amongst anthropologists. But seeing this is primarily a philosophical essay rather than anthropological or scientific I'm hoping for some laxity in putting forward conjectures. I will severely abuse this pass going forward. But all good philosophical works are messy. Otherwise, philosophers would have nothing to argue about.

³ See Section 3 for a discussion of the emotions, in particular how they relate to memories.

⁴ This would be one explanation for the substantial increases in brain size that occur from *Homo habilis* to *Homo erectus* to *Homo sapiens*. But I admit it is mere conjecture.

sophisticated enough to capture whole patterns and models. These *ancestral memories* are what Carl Jung would call archetypes and its shared impact the Collective Unconscious.⁵ This existence, which lasted millions of years, was one filled with mystery, intrigue, inspiration, tranquility, awe, purpose, joy. It is hard for us to imagine. We might only have a taste of it when it makes an unexpected appearance in our mythology.⁶ Or during an altered state—either drug induced or the result of genuine madness or inspiration.⁷ (I should point out, we still have the Collective Unconscious, it just tends to be overshadowed by the Conscious.) In any case, Habilis was able to get along quite well with only an Unconscious, albeit a highly sophisticated one. And some of the *sublimity* of this unique type of existence still lingers. But, at some point in the evolutionary line, things changed (likely in late Erectus or early Sapiens); a new mode of existence started to take form, guided by a less exciting Master, clouding out the Old, precipitated, I will argue, by the awareness of death.⁸

The New Guard. As far as what follows, it gets somewhat murky, and we face a chicken and two eggs problem. Did Consciousness, Ideas, or Language evolve first? As a philosopher I have the privilege of using the transcendental pickax. So I will try to carve something out—acknowledging that the Three likely evolved together in varying degrees. Now, considering we claimed Mind is composed of ideas (along with memories) this is a good place to begin. Though as stated, memories, complex emotions, and the Collective Unconscious evolved first.

To start, it seems ideas require consciousness—at least in the way we are defining them.⁹ So ideas could not have evolved first. Ideas, secondly, benefit immensely from language in both their complexity and spread, suggesting they did not reach full effect until after language had evolved.¹⁰ Although as I go on to argue, there were primitive ideas that were not communicated (and still difficult to communicate today), some of the first Ideas being Time and God.¹¹ To add to that; when humans first did start to speak they likely were talking about memories and their precious archetypes rather than ideas—though ideas will dominate further down the line becoming grandiose in character and appeal.¹² Finally, putting things in perspective; from what we know of the fossil record, the capacity for language, at least language complex enough to communicate abstract concepts, came much later and is exclusive to Sapiens. But this should not discount Erectus and Habilis who I go on to suggest were prolific singers, possibly setting the physiological changes in motion needed for language—to be later utilized.¹³ Thus, we have turned the eggs into an omelet. So all that remains is to simply recall what happened next for our species—in brief.

⁵ See Section 4 for a discussion of archetypes and the Collective Unconscious.

⁶ See Section 9 for a discussion of the Mythos.

⁷ See Section 10 for a discussion of poetic inspiration.

⁸ See Section 5 for a discussion of the cause of consciousness.

⁹ See Section 6 for a general discussion of ideas.

¹⁰ See Section 8 for a discussion of language and meaning.

¹¹ See Section 5 for a discussion of primitive ideas.

¹² See Section 12 for the influence of ideas on religion. See Section 13 for the influence of ideas on philosophy.

¹³ See Sections 3 and 7 for a discussion of the singing ape hypothesis. Also see Sections 7-8 for a discussion of words, archetypes, and language.

The Ascent. We will tell our stories—and eventually write them down—develop culture; and become purveyors of powerful ideas that will be used to dominate the planet, creating what might be called a Collective Conscious in the process—for better or worse. So it went!¹⁴

Untapped. An astute reader might point to the fact that I left out tool use (and tool creation) in our evolutionary story. Why? I take it, tools only played a minor role in the development of Mind, though it benefited from the process.¹⁵ That being said, tools will play a substantial part later on, as they are used to make Artifacts. These artifacts will extend Mind outside of the brain and even go on to control us.¹⁶ But that's an issue we can address after the pieces of the essay are set up.

The Present. Thus, with some ado, we arrive at Modern Man (his brain filled to the brim with vibrant memories and grandiose ideas). But the development of Mind likely doesn't end here with Sapiens.¹⁷ Although, many think we have already taken it too far. Anti-humanists chirp that we are a nuisance and the Planet would be better off if we weren't here. To this we can only sigh. Are they not aware that we are the *product* of the greatest story ever told?

Human, all too human! they scoff. As if this is a bad thing. We're all that's left—of our line. Still standing. But, for some reason, we criticize ourselves for being. Don't be ashamed for being what we are; not for being an ape, not for having a mind, not for smiling, not for living, being us.

3. Memories and Emotions

A passion is an original existence, or, if you will, modification of existence, and contains not any representative quality, which renders it a copy of any other existence or modification.

(David Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature*)

Your computer gives you print-outs, daily and hourly, in the form of *emotions*—which are lightning-like estimates of the things around you, calculated according to your values.

(Ayn Rand, *Philosophy: Who Needs It*)

I proposed that Mind is composed of memories and ideas. I also proposed that emotions played a role in the evolution of Mind, or at least in the development of sophisticated memories. So, it seems prudent to start our investigation (viz., into the development, nature, and influence of Mind) by looking at the relation between memories and emotions in general. Such a groundwork will prove indispensable going forward. Foremost, emotions influence how we remember things. In a

¹⁴ See Section 11 for a discussion of culture and the creation of a Collective Conscious.

¹⁵ Of course, the argument could be made that tools for hunting, butchering, taming fire, contributed to an increase in brain size due to better nutrition (where larger brains are a necessary condition for Minds to develop). But this just establishes optimal conditions rather than being a prime catalyst in the development of Mind itself.

¹⁶ See Section 20 for a discussion of artifacts.

¹⁷ See Sections 24-25 for a discussion of post-human Minds.

complimentary manner, memories can trigger the firing of particular emotions. But while memories and emotions are intertwined, it would be wrong to say we have memories of emotions or that they are the same. Rather, emotions *occur* with memories. This is an important point that will be fleshed out throughout the essay and repeatedly drawn on.

Kicking things off, emotions are not just there—well they are—but also serve an important role in aiding the survival of both humans and animals. They allow us to react quickly to threats and opportunities. They are "lightning-like estimates," as Rand says. Emotions also direct social behavior and/or beneficial behavior. This might be instinctual or learned. For Rand, your "computer," or the thing that tempers your emotions, is rationality, or Reason, in the elevated Aristotelian sense.¹⁸ Through habit and directed action emotions mold to what Reason dictates to be appropriate. But Rand, in my understanding, takes Reason to be an idea, or connected to ideas. While I view this as correct, I should point out that ideas and emotions do not interact directly. Ideas can only influence emotions indirectly by eliciting *mental images*, or attaching themselves to mental images (where I am using mental image loosely to refer to impressions of any of the five senses that might be represented or projected in the brain). Mainly, ideas *must* use memories (which I take mental images to correspond to) as an intermediary in order to have any effect on emotions. Otherwise, Reason and ideas, in themselves, are largely inert.¹⁹

In making sense of memories, I follow Hume in holding that memories should be attributed to sense impressions and are ultimately derived from sense impressions; past or present.²⁰ But contrarily, I take memories to be far from exact copies or even diluted copies of sense impressions. Instead, memories are distorted and shaped by emotions and other memories. Of course, one might argue, after staring at a tree for a while, the mental image you have in your mind seems incredibly similar to the tree you're staring at.²¹ I do seem to put myself in a bind here by taking mental images, including those generated by the imagination, to be products of memory. My response to the issue raised would be that the tree in question likely won't be remembered unless it comes in a package, such as a representation of you in a park, on a certain day, frustrated, opening and closing your eyes repeatedly in the presence of a large oak in order to prove a philosophical position. If you wanted to tell the story of the persistent oak tree to others, there would also be the *idea of tree* involved. But I'll delay a discussion of what ideas are and how they operate in the mind until later.²² The point is, what is stored in the brain is somewhat different from the incoming sense impressions (that is, the sense impressions that are even processed). And even when memories are recollected

¹⁸ See Section 13 for a discussion of Aristotle's view on the proper relation between Reason and the emotions.

¹⁹ This somewhat mimics Hume's famous line in *Treatise* 2.3.3: "Reason is, and only ought to be the slave of the passions, and can never pretend to any other office than to serve and obey them." But I don't go as far as Hume. I hold that Reason and ideas can influence someone quite effectively; they just need to use memories and mental images in order to do so. Contrary to Hume, Reason is *not* the slave of the passions; but it does need to court them.

²⁰ See *Treatise* 1.1.1 for Hume's view. Hume ultimately takes memories to be a type of idea, and simply a less vivid copy of sense impressions.

²¹ This ignores afterimages, which are not memories.

²² See Section 6.

accurately, in many cases it is only because details are inferred and pieced together by the imagination.²³

In purchasing the concept of memory, I am using it in a very broad way. I am taking memory to be *any representation that resembles sense impressions and is physically stored in the brain*.²⁴ It's important to point out, for my theory only resemblance is necessary. Representations need not be accurate. For example, I can hold a mental image of a supernova or think of other peoples' lives. But these are not attributed to some specific sense impressions. Though they are memories. It's also quite possible, probable, that what is stored in the brain or what appears as a mental image is something above or below what is provided by the sensory apparatus. Although, if there is something supersensory in play the (human) brain currently lacks the ability to process it, being an inchoate sensation—but still possessing resemblance nonetheless. I also reject the supposition that memories must be prior or correspond to the past. I only require that they be physically stored in the brain; where, sometimes, impressions last mere moments. But in those mere moments they were memories. The same would apply to mental images that are stored or in the process of being stored while simultaneously being projected in the mind. This doesn't matter. Past or present they are memories all the same.

Usually when talking about memories, it is in reference to conscious memories. But it's important to realize that most memories are unconscious. Although, there is some debate regarding this fact. But it is not a problem for my theory. Unconscious memories, similarly, are derived from sense impressions and stored in the brain in some specific physical locus; making them memories in the full sense under my view. The mere fact that we're unaware of them does not count against their reality. To be clear, there is no reason why memories need to be conscious; and I would add, memories can exist independently of ideas, or even emotions. With this in mind, we can acknowledge that many animals have at least unconscious memories, possibly unconscious mental images as well. Thus, for my theory, getting the first part of mind, Memories, does not require any extraordinary reworkings of prevailing views. Only a small adjustment is needed. Nor do we need to rely on human beings having special status.²⁵

Why should we care about unconscious memories? One big reason is that unconscious memories influence behavior. They, like conscious memories, have causal powers. In fact, it could be argued that the Unconscious, which unconscious memories are a part, influences our behavior more than conscious memories. So it should be something we care about. There are also, I should add, unconscious emotions, which exert pressure on us as well. In spar, we might find some comfort in thinking that these *hidden drivers* can at least be reduced to our experiences and things we've actually done. But my theory holds that we are also influenced by things we've never done and memories we've never formed. Mainly, there are innate memories.

²³ I should point out that there is a huge scientific literature on memories and emotions that I am ignoring. But as pleaded for in the 2nd footnote, I ask for some laxity in scientific rigor, so that I may escape the bondage and tedium of lit reviews and give a more pleasing argument.

²⁴ This definition, of course, might be extended past the biological brain to include any *physical reservoir* capable of housing representations resembling sense impressions. This justifiably would allow aliens, or computers, or any other non-biological entities to have memories. See Sections 24-25.

²⁵ Of course, I should remind the reader that Mind requires both memories and ideas. And only humans have ideas. So, in that sense we have a special status. But the point is that we can get memories relatively easy, or at least the basic types of memories required for my theory, from animals alone.

People are very uncomfortable with the concept of innate memories. Even defenders of innate ideas raise the alarm when it comes to innate memories. This hostility, I think, comes from most people accepting the self-memory view of personal identity to at least some degree.²⁶ Memories that are not in line with your historicity seem like foreign invaders. We don't want to have to decide which memories are *real* and which are artificial. But if you were born with certain memories embedded in your mind and with you all your life, are they really alien?

The above, I agree, seems like an outlandish claim. But only if we have an inflated view of what memories are. For example, many animals have highly sophisticated instincts, such as migration, nesting, courtship, even burying their dead—where instincts are really just crude memories. It doesn't seem completely unreasonable to think that if animals can encode for behaviors, why can't humans with our enormous brains encode for whole memories or even patterns and models of memories? It is a difference of degree, not of kind. People are quite content with the idea that humans have few or no instincts. But where did our instincts go? Nature rarely gives up anything useful. Instead, I propose, most instincts just got replaced with innate memories. They prove much more useful and serve a better function. It was a gain, not a loss. I will talk about the character of these innate memories in the next section. But the point here is that it is not completely absurd to defend innate memories. (Of course, I acknowledge, there is a lack of empirical evidence for these types of memories. But considering how little we know about the human brain, an outright condemnation seems premature.)

Now, I said we have innate memories. I also hold that emotions are innate. They are “original existences” as Hume claims.²⁷ What this means is that emotions are not derived from the environment or sense impressions. They are pure. (Though their intensity and how or if they are triggered can be influenced.) People do not have unique emotions. Emotions are universal and experienced the same for every person in every corner of the Earth, and this can be traced back historically as far as we're willing to go. Jealousy, greed, lust, pride, ambition, are just as much problems for us as they were for the Victorian aristocrat, the peasant in feudal Japan, the Viking trader, the Persian mathematician, the Zulu warrior. That is not to say the array of emotions can never change or there will never be new emotions. But a huge evolutionary change would be required to bring it about. If you're reading this essay, you're, unfortunately, stuck with the same emotions as the rest of us.

One consequence of this view is that humans, on account of having the same emotions, and experiencing them the same way, share a phenomenal outlook. We can relate to what other people are feeling and how they see and evaluate the world. If emotions were unique and individualized this would not be possible, or much harder. I would suggest a primitive moral sense can be bolstered off of this fact. But I will not argue for it here. In any case, emotions, along with memories, and also as I'll argue, ideas, influence our behavior and how we interact with the world.

We've talked some on the relation of emotions to ideas, memories, consciousness, unconsciousness. So, it might be worthwhile to jump ahead and also touch on the relation of emotions to language, or potentially to the development of language; albeit there is some

²⁶ The self-memory view, again, is the view that personal identity is tied to conscious memories.

²⁷ Hume uses the term *passion* instead of emotion. Passions in Hume's usage are a little bit more sophisticated and inclusive than emotions. But everything you can say about passions you can also say about emotions.

repetition. One helpful saint on the matter is Charles Darwin. In his underappreciated work, *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals*, Darwin proposes that humans began to sing before we began to speak. This would suggest that complex emotions preceded language. I don't think this is too controversial. But it should be pointed out that emotions are primitive, and largely unconscious. The expression of early emotions—in the absence of language—served as an important form of communication. We were able to express inner states to each other; intentions, desires, deception, approval, disapproval, partnership. We were able to pick up, feel things, from each other in a way far exceeding any other animal. I think man, most of all, before he was conscious, speaker, tool maker, was first unique in being the *emotive ape*. And I will hold that this emotive leap occurred before Sapiens.

Thus, to answer the old question of why emotions play such an important role in human life, why we define ourselves by it: Mainly, it was the first thing we excelled at.

Darwin, in his work, was concerned primarily with facial expressions. If you look at the numerous, specialized muscles in the human face, it is clear that they are made to serve a function greater than eating, and breathing, and whistling. Darwin held that the facial expressions, their purpose, is to convey emotions to others. I will go further and hold that complex emotions exerted selective pressure in shaping the physical structure of the human face. The human face, as we know it, is an emotion projector. Now we normally, I take it, wish to try to hide our emotions from others. But in a pre-linguistic existence this would not be very profitable to do. There is already a shortage of information being exchanged, and any attempt to suppress it would be disadvantageous. It only makes sense to hide your emotions when other options are available, such as the ability to say, "I'm sad and would like some attention." If you can tell people how you're feeling, then there is no reason for you to *actually* show it. The speculation we might make then is that language has made us less emotive and that we were more empathic at some earlier stage in our evolution.

To sum up, I said there was a shortage of information being exchanged in the absence of language. That is, facial expressions can only convey so much. So I hold—and probably Darwin—we began to sing, and make song-like sounds, to relay more complex emotions, and exchange more information between each other. The big claim is, that as singing was selected for, and songs became more complicated, it caused physical changes in the throat and larynx, paving the way for the ability to speak. Thus, to conclude, much of the physical intricacies in the human face and vocal cords are a product of emotions trying to be expressed in the world.²⁸ And I would say, resay, complex emotions provided the first impetus in driving human beings to be what we are today.

4. Collective Unconscious

The collective unconscious contains the whole spiritual heritage of mankind's evolution born anew in the brain structure of every individual.

(Carl Jung, *The Structures and Dynamics of the Psyche*)

²⁸ Certain changes to the brain are also required for speech. But I'm assuming these changes are present.

Two pieces have been put into play: simple memories and emotions. I would now like to continue with exploring memories of a much more complicated nature: *innate memories*. In fleshing out innate memories, I draw on Jung's conception of archetypes and the collective unconscious. The Collective Unconscious is taken to be a set of universal patterns, models, symbols, motifs, dispositions, recognizable to and shared by all humans. The individual representations of these patterns, models, symbols, motifs, dispositions, that make up the Collective Unconscious, are *archetypes*. There is some debate over what archetypes are; whether they are instincts, memories, behaviors, spirits, ideas, etc.? There are good reasons for thinking each. And Jung at times uses archetypes in different senses. But I will not enter the debate here. Instead, I will take archetypes to be a type of sophisticated innate memory, or *memory complex*, that is inherited, largely unconscious, and apt to meet the psychological needs of our ancestors; as well as (possibly) many psychological needs of modern humans. I should importantly point out, archetypes do not represent or capture specific individual or personal memories. They also do not in any way recall past lives or show lived experiences of unique persons from history. Rather, they reflect a kind of mental *mold* formed of certain behaviors and experiences that were very common and repetitive for our ancestors; which over a long period of time, through evolutionary means, became embedded into the structure of the brain. Though the exact mechanism for this remains unclear.

In the Jungian schema, some of the major *personal archetypes* are: the Hero, Villain, Mother, Father, Maiden, Old Hag (witch/healer), Wise Old Man, Trickster, Child, and Stranger. Each of these archetypes comes with a sort of *package*. For example, the Hero is brave, morally upright, resilient. He inspires admiration and hope. The Villain is nefarious, ruthless, dark. He incites fear, hate, and despair. The Mother is a giver-of-life, caring, and compassionate. She is loved and appreciated. The Father is responsible, a lawgiver, protector. He gains respect and obedience. The Maiden is young, beautiful, pure. She is associated with desire, vulnerability, and playfulness. The Old Hag is a social outcast who possesses useful knowledge. She is met with necessity, desperation, and curiosity. The Wise Old Man is intuitive, intelligent, arcane, acting as a mentor and guide. He is met with reverence, interest, and curiosity. The Trickster is dishonest, unpredictable, chaotic, cunning. He provokes scorn, distrust, and despise. The Child is innocent, helpless, naive. He/she is reacted to with sympathy, concern, and potential. Finally, the Stranger is mysterious, unwelcomed, alien. He draws suspicion and fear, but also intrigue.

There are also *general archetypes*. The primary general archetypes are: the Anima/Animus, Shadow, Persona, and Self.²⁹ The Anima is the feminine aspects of a man. And the Animus is the masculine aspects of a woman. Controversially, all humans have both feminine and masculine aspects. It is not a social construct but ingrained in human nature. Though a person can choose which aspect they want to exemplify, or integrate both aspects into one. The Shadow represents a person's dark side. It is the part of ourselves that we are ashamed of or afraid of. It is usually repressed and hidden by the conscious. The Persona is a sort of mask or artificial personality that we share with the world. It is fabricated for and bent in response to social pressure. But this need not be intentional. Like the other archetypes it is largely unconscious. The Self is type of creation in response to trying to find harmony between the conscious and unconscious. Though this is not

²⁹ See Jung's *Aion* for a more detailed discussion of the general archetypes.

exactly the same as the conscious or personal self. For Jung, the integration of the conscious and unconscious produces something above either; potentially representing one's *complete self*. This ultimate goal is called individuation or actualization.³⁰

There are also a huge number of distinct archetypes representing and giving meaning to various objects in the world. Some examples would be: Darkness (evil/end), Light (good/beginning), Cave (hidden/arcane), Water (purity/healing), Serpent (mystery/guardian), Raven (death/transmigration), The Forest (the unknown), Flower (youth/beauty), Storm (danger/chaos), Fire (power/creation/destruction), Blood (life-force, kinship), Mud (body/ugliness), Wings (spiritual/messenger), Breath (soul/vitality), Phalluses (manhood, virility), Hearts (love/desire), and Swords (courage/honor/conquest). Much like the personal archetypes, these distinct archetypes are malleable and can be reinterpreted and reimaged to fit the modern world—where the underlying pattern and structure remain the same. Some modern equivalents would be: Electricity (power/creation), Pills (healing/change), Underground (hidden/arcane), Machines (body/ugliness/coldness), Street Lights (light/prosperity), Trains (death/transmigration), Planes (spiritual/messenger), Roads (the unknown), Farms (soul/vitality), Factories (life-force), Cats (mystery/guardian), Suits (manhood/virility), Poems (love/desire), and Guns (power/conquest). These associations and meanings are so common that we usually don't even recognize we're projecting it. The world is not filled with bland objects. It is instead draped with meaning.

I claimed that each archetype comes with a sort of package. A big component of this package is one or more strong emotions. These attached emotions guide us in how we interact with other people, ourselves, and objects in the world. We are humbled by the wise old man or old hag, invested in the child, enamored by the maiden. We imagine ourselves as the hero to inspire us to overcome difficult challenges. We are afraid to enter into the dark forest. Both literally, and figuratively, these dispositions aid our survival. But it is important to point out, emotions are not archetypes. Nor, to be clear, are emotions memories. Though, that being said, archetypes and emotions seem to have evolved to be in sync with one another. We have the *right* emotional reactions to archetypes. Or probably, more correctly, archetypes incite the right emotions. For instance, throughout our history, trusting a trickster usually didn't end well. Letting a villain gain too much power would have been disastrous for a clan or tribe. Not obeying one's father or not appreciating one's mother is generally bad for the social order. So it makes sense to despise tricksters, hate villains, respect your father, and love your mother. And this holds true even if there are occasionally false alarms. For instance, the stranger you are suspicious of turns out to be friendly.

Archetypes also allow us to build narratives, giving our lives meaning. They allow us to grow into ourselves. For example, a man coming to terms with his Anima will be much better off as a result and less psychologically conflicted. The same for a woman coming to terms with her Animus. We must eventually face the Shadow if we want to overcome/or accept our deepest desires. The Persona must first be recognized in order to change it. Though, curiously, there seems to be no clear evolutionary reason why archetypes should provide meaning for us or help us grow. Perhaps it is just a boon that nature decided to look after our psychological well-being. Though it's

³⁰ I discuss actualization in more detail in Section 17.

quite possible, as I'll argue later, that archetypes might act to reinforce themselves for their own sake, rather than ours. We're just a good way to keep them going.³¹ That speculation being raised, in rebut, the Collective Unconscious very likely enhances the overall survival of our species by making us more emotionally and psychologically stable. A depressed or suicidal or even unenthusiastic hunter-gatherer is likely at a big disadvantage. And probably the same for a depressed or suicidal or unenthusiastic urban lawyer.

Archetypes, I take it, are strong influencers. Even when it is inconvenient, we will often try to make our actions and life conditions conform to a narrative. But these narratives, to be clear, are ancient. This can cause tension and alienation. The reason this is the case, as Jung points out, is because no matter how cultured or refined we become, at bottom we are still "archaic man."³² And that is the model we are drawing from. This need not be a bad thing though. Having a connection to the distant past and the *ancestral memories* can be a source of awe and reverence. There is a great mystery to it. There is something *hidden* in us that can be discovered and tapped. Sometimes what we find is beautiful, sublime, powerful. This can add a spiritual layer to an otherwise boring existence. And a spiritual source is something modern humans are in desperate need of—even in the presence of religion.

Whether we want to accept it or not, the Collective Unconscious is pervasive. It finds its way into our art, mythology, religion, literature, and culture. It's easy to recognize. For instance, the *hero* searches for the *wise old man* in the *forest* who guides him to retrieve the magic *sword* from the lost *cave* needed to defeat the *villain* and rescue the *maiden*. This tale, and others, have been retold countless times; unique characters, places, and objects simply being interchanged on top of the same molds. But, for the sake of argument, I will acknowledge that these molds might simply be a cultural phenomenon put into place within the last 5,000 years rather than something ancient and ingrained. In response, Jung points out that the mythos of various cultures, some isolated from the rest of the world, are far too similar for it to be a matter of coincidence.³³ The only reasonable explanation is that there must be something hard-wired into the human species that tends to converge on the same patterns and symbols. I think Jung may be right, and I explore the concept of mythos later.³⁴ But whatever the case may be, there does seem to be *something* in play, stamped into our unconscious minds, which exerts a powerful force over our culture and personal lives. Thus, this force, which we are referring to as the Collective Unconscious, is something we should take seriously.

5. Temporal Selves

Death opens up the question of Being.
(Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*)

³¹ See Section 11 for a treatment of this possibility.

³² See Jung's *Modern Man in Search of a Soul*, p. 229.

³³ See in particular Jung's *Man and His Symbols*. Jung also takes dreams and the delusions/hallucinations of people with mental illness to provide evidence for the existence of the Collective Unconscious.

³⁴ See Section 8 for a discussion of the Mythos.

Somehow, we feel, the water of the physical brain is turned into the wine of consciousness, but we draw a total blank on the nature of this conversion.

(Colin McGinn, "Can We Solve the Mind-Body Problem?")

The third auxiliary is consciousness. Consciousness is taken to be a mystery, perhaps even one of the most important mysteries. McGinn compares the development of consciousness to transmuting water into wine. Something truly magical. But we should be clear on what's being discussed. We seem to have in mind what I would call the *magnificent view* of consciousness: that is, thinking about thinking, exploring abstract concepts, contemplating the universe, deciding, creating, catching glimpses of the inner machinery inside our heads. These are some impressive feats. We don't think this to *simply* involve having memories and emotions. There is no big mystery to how physical memories, for instance, cause behavior. Well, it is a big mystery, but it is not the real bread and butter of the mind-body problem.³⁵ The magnificent view of consciousness, instead, I take it, has to do with ideas. Ideas are the magic, the wine. But this *wine* is not transmuted but rather mixed and diluted in the water of memories. Only then is it potable. In the next section I try to make sense of ideas, but to be clear I am in no way trying to solve the mind-body problem.³⁶ So in getting some work done here, let's put the mind-body problem and the magnificent view of consciousness aside. Instead, I want to try to tell a story of how consciousness might have come about. The details and cogitation may be wrong, but all of the things I will discuss did happen, at some point, in some capacity.

Finding the right starting point or threshold for consciousness is difficult. Mere awareness is not substantive enough to matter; when it comes to what humans *do*, and talk about minds. Many animals are clearly conscious in the general sense, being aware of both their environment and their own bodies. Thus, we must find some point to draw a sharp distinction, without simply adopting the magnificent view of consciousness. I take a substantive criterion of consciousness to be this: *being aware that you are aware of something*. This has some potential. Though I will expand on it. But I take this to be something we *do*, and animals *don't*. The first task is to build up to this.

Let us *throw* our unconscious ancestors into the world, armed with only a reasonably big brain, complex emotions, and memories (to include access to a collective unconscious and a number of archetypes). What would immersion in this world be like? I take it to involve more than empty physicality. Emotion and archetypes would give natural objects value. The Sun is not a light in the sky, but giver of life. The trees sing. The birds watch over us. I am tempted to say the natural objects are *ready-to-hand*, in Heidegger's usage of the term.³⁷ But that doesn't quite capture it. Our ancestors were not immersed in tools to be used. But the natural objects, like tools, are given purposes. It is hard to point to exactly what these purposes were, except to say they were focuses of reverence. And this reverence, I take it, played an important role in our ancestors' lives, shaping

³⁵ I take the mind-body problem to involve making sense of how a non-physical mind interacts with a physical body; or, if both are physical, or both are mental, how do two things that are radically different from another, like a mind and a body, interact.

³⁶ I am also not pursuing the issue of qualia, or subjective experience, or what it's like to be a mole rat.

³⁷ See Heidegger's *Being and Time* 1:3:15. Mainly, to say that something is ready-to-hand means, in my interpretation, seeing objects, tools through their practical use rather than as objects as such, having certain physical properties.

how they interacted with the world and each other. The things ready-to-hand, then, for our ancestors, were not tools, but rather physical *icons*, in which the mental components of these icons are the archetypes in our heads. But it is not quite right to call the icons artifacts, on account of these natural objects not actually being created by humans. Though the influence is similar.

Besides awe (and fear), a consequence of living in this world would be the feeling of *smallness*. Things are much bigger than you can comprehend. This, I believe, caused a feeling/emotion of helplessness and anxiety in our ancestors. The world was too important to *lose*. Nor did they want to *leave* it. Facing the world, in this way, I hold, with a few concessions, leads an individual to confront their own mortality. But this is not simply awareness of death itself. Clearly our ancestors were aware that their kin were dying, probably quite often. Rather, in the Heideggerian sense, it would involve facing one's own death. Or as Heidegger would refer to it, *being-towards-death*.

Being-towards-death involves seeing death as one's possibility. Death is the “possibility of the impossibility of any existence at all,” as Heidegger says.³⁸ What this means is that death is forward-looking. But at the same time immanent. Death *looms* over us, and is always possible, at any time. It is the end of existence but also the focus of existence. In this way, for Heidegger, we *anticipate* death.³⁹ But in doing so we see existence as finite, and having a definite end. This shapes the forward-looking aspect of death to be inescapable and belonging to us. In this way, my death is *mine*. Here we are aware of death, as always possible; something that can happen to us, in the future at any moment, even though death is not here *now*. In this way, we define ourselves by the future and finitude. In analyzing our own anticipation (and dread) we become aware that we are aware of something, mainly, that we will/must die and that existence will/must come to an end. From this, I take it, we can form a conception or idea of Time, and supplementary add our place in it. Time then attaches itself to our phenomenal experience, eventually becoming embedded into the frame of consciousness itself. We become aware that we are *now* aware of something—again, our own deaths. Thus, the proposed criterion of consciousness can be satisfied.

But the above type of consciousness is not necessarily the same as self-consciousness or personal identity. For example, you can be aware that you're experiencing *something* or aware that you *are something* or aware that you *will not be something* without reference to individuality. To get individuality will take some more steps. One small leap, would be to allow that increases in intelligence would ignite improvements in memory to the point where our ancestors could be aware that they *were* aware of something in a similar way to how they're currently aware. With the idea of Time this would not be an unreasonable development. With this, we could have some conception, however small, of a continuity of self. Although, deriving a *personal self* or an idea of Self requires more work. One move would be to hold that consciousness will value itself, or hold itself as valuable, even while remaining a mystery to itself. But this is difficult to argue for. Though most organisms will value their own life, or continued existence, in principle.

The next task is *volition*. Without being aware that *you* are the source of your actions your consciousness is like a spectator watching its own concerto. In searching for an origin of volition or a rudimentary form of volition we might look to Arthur Schopenhauer. Schopenhauer in his

³⁸ See *Being and Time*, 2:1:50; p. 294.

³⁹ See *Being and Time*, 2:1:53.

openly pessimistic work, *The World as Will and Representation*, claims the base of existence is an incessant impulse. He calls this *will*, and is very hostile toward it. He holds this will to be entirely irrational, aimless, blind, uncaused.⁴⁰ But if what he says is right, and the will is blind and beyond causality and even time⁴¹, as he claims, then it should follow that *all will is free*. Unless we want to simply stipulate that a free will must directly come from or result from consciousness.⁴² I will later argue that consciousness does not necessarily make us more free; in fact the reverse.⁴³ But this need not be a topic of contention at this stage of the argument.

What we can do, is propose a conception of *agency*, where a being who is aware that they are the cause of their own actions is taken to be responsible for those actions. Here we have a type of conscious agency. But, I should point out, rather confusedly, that actual acts of the will are not required for this to work, or at least we need not commit, at this stage, to there being a type of will that acts freely. Instead, being aware that you are the cause of your own actions, in itself, makes you responsible for anything that comes from *you*, intentional or unintentional; even admitting that many acts, by you, are not done freely. With this in mind, we can form a conception of Self as a whole being, in the world, rather than reduce it to a mysterious point of will or volition. In recognizing this, the idea of Self becomes possible and comprehensible. But this idea of Self is not yet a personal self, or a distinctive finite self.

For whatever reason, it seems, it is easier to imagine an infinite self over a finite self. An *infinite self*, I take it, would be "God," to use the familiar term for such a thing. In this development, God becomes the cause and explanation of all the mysteries in the world; including you. In this way, anxiety is relieved and responsibility is diminished. The angst involved in being an *agent* is limited and reduced to what you happen to decide you would like to have control over. We create the personal self as a flawed and imperfect being—always justified in evading responsibility, despite being a center of volition and the pinnacle of his/her universe. By relinquishing control in this way, we give God immense power. And this is the state we currently find ourselves in. Hence, we have the lens to view, and the black powder to create the idea of Self and the idea of God. Though both will be shapeshifters in countless forms.

We have arrived, in outline, at some of the most important primitive ideas for human beings: Time, Self, God. I propose some other primitive ideas would be: Being (permanence), Change (impermanence), Cause/Effect (volition generalized), Nothingness (death generalized), Necessity, Potentiality, Other (including the recognition of other selves), Quantity (with abstraction), Likeness/Difference, Proximity (both continuous and non-continuous), Quality (distinctness), Order (real or imagined), and Relation.

With these primitive ideas the Conscious can take shape. And we will eventually find ourselves unable to think at all without them. Thus, we have far exceeded what was necessary to demarcate ourselves from animals. But we should demand no less. This is, in fact, the human being we know! Though a dose of rationalism is required for my schema to work. And, to the frustration

⁴⁰ See Schopenhauer's *The World as Will and Representation*, 1:2:27.

⁴¹ See *The World as Will and Representation*, 1:2:23.

⁴² Or possibly from the stronger requirement: rationality or Reason. I reject both consciousness and rationality as necessary requirements for free will.

⁴³ See Section 22.

of metaphysicians, these primitive ideas, unfortunately, escape any proper definitions—in language anyway.

6. Genealogy of Ideas

All is number.
(Pythagoras, —⁴⁴)

It is not altogether unreasonable to describe digital computers as
brains.
(Alan Turing, "Can Digital Computers Think?")

Ideas, as was stated, require consciousness. But we should acknowledge that Consciousness forces the world to present itself a certain way. At its most fundamental level consciousness produces the Laws of Logic. But it's important to point out that the laws of logic do not necessarily apply to the world but rather to the Mind. The most important laws of logic are the Law of Identity, the Law of Excluded Middle, and the Law of Noncontradiction.⁴⁵ As far as ideas are concerned, in particular their capacity to be transmitted to others, the most consequential law of logic is the Law of Noncontradiction.

The Law of Noncontradiction holds that a thing is not what it is not, or more succinctly: $A \neq \text{not } A$. We should add to it: *at the same time*. This is extremely important, because without the addition of temporality the law of noncontradiction lacks teeth.⁴⁶ But this proves extraneous to what should be allowed to enter into supposedly self-evident axioms. To make it work, I contend, we ought to/must bring in the primitive idea of Time, which was argued for in the previous section. If what was said is correct, even if only in some capacity, we have the means to extend the laws of logic; the law of noncontradiction at least; outside of one's own mind. Thus, the idea of Time proves paramount to the development of all non-primitive ideas.

Non-primitive ideas, I take it, are ideas that can, in principle, be communicated. On account of this fact (with non-contradiction and time) these types of ideas must be binary. That is, in formulating ideas, a thing either is what you take it to be or not what you take it to be.⁴⁷ Within this binary framework, I propose that ideas are akin to *programs*; and words are simply code that we exchange with one another. The computer analogy of the mind is well-trodden. Though I hope to do something a little different with it. And even if the analogy is overused, I take it to be the right one and the best approximation that we have to how ideas work. Now, ideas are complex. They are not simply mental images or collections of factual claims, as many people take them to

⁴⁴ As a convention I will use "—" for work attributed to an author, where no direct citation is found.

⁴⁵ These are the three classical laws of logic. See Aristotle's *Prior Analytics* and *Posterior Analytics* for the traditional explication of each. Also see *Metaphysics* Book 4, in particular, for special emphasis on the Law of Noncontradiction.

⁴⁶ For instance, it is possible for something to both be what it is and not be what it is at different times. For the law of noncontradiction to work effectively a conception of the present time is required.

⁴⁷ I am smuggling in a version of the logical law of excluded middle here for simplicity. The law is usually put as A or not A . Compare this and noncontradiction with the third classical law, Identity; put as $A = A$.

be. Ideas, being programs, must run and interpret vast amounts of information. Ideas are not the information itself, but rather the manifestation of that information to consciousness in a clear and ordered model. Only certain configurations are possible for each thing, meaning we will come to a convergence on which ideas can be properly run. That is, unlike memories, which are unique to each individual, ideas, for the most part, are the same for everyone. We all have the same manifestations of each Idea. And this is true independent of language or how they are conveyed. Just as different types of code can run the same program, different words can produce the same Idea. Largely, the same Idea can be multiply realized.

This may sound a little strange at first. For example, let's say you've spent quite some time staring at an oak tree. You go to tell your friend about the exercise. You say you've gathered some insights by staring at a 'tree'. You, of course, might have some mental image of the particular tree that you are referring to. But that is lost in the process of communicating it. When hearing 'tree' your friend might also think of a particular mental image of some different tree. But the point is neither of those mental images matter. They are mere memories and not what is being communicated. And this would be the case even if thousands of mental images were brought to mind. The idea is something above. What is shared is a type of configuration that is either met or not met. If you described the tree as having tentacles, for instance, then this configuration would not be met, and your friend would likely ask for some clarification on what you mean by 'tree'. The actual idea is somewhat obscure, even if we always have some mental image that is drawn to make sense of it through representation of sense impressions. The program simply reads the code, even if you don't understand it. Its true nature is non-sensory.

A consequence of this is that a configuration, or Ideas, potentially exist in principle without the mind. Though minds are needed to actualize them. For example, the Idea of Tree would remain as a configuration that can be met, even if all speakers disappeared. If speakers eventually returned, say after a long time, the same Idea can be communicated even if the language or code was drastically different from before. Again, Ideas can be multiply realized by different code. If this is possible, then it must be the case that ideas/programs are non-physical.

In his influential essay, "Minds, Brains, and Programs," John Searle starkly warns that we should be reluctant to accept the possibility that a program can be separated from its hardware, and function as a mind, because it amounts to endorsing dualism. I have no problem calling Searle's bluff. Yes, dualism is true and programs/ideas are non-physical in the genuine sense. Though some further clarification is in order about what I mean by ideas being non-physical.

By non-physical I mean that ideas don't exist fully or only partly exist. I take ideas to be *pure potentialities*. What this means is that: when not being consciously reinforced, ideas are not part of the physical world. Though how consciousness allows ideas to be actualized, and become real, is hard to say. But it need not be too hard to imagine. For instance, a favorite example of Aristotle, is that an acorn is potentially an oak tree, and has this potential before any oak tree *actually* exists.⁴⁸ The oak tree in some sense *does* exist, just at a different time. By ideas being non-physical I also mean they are mind-dependent. Ideas cannot be actualized, or at least known, outside the presence of consciousness and memories. Though, unlike memories, ideas do not take up space, or exist in space. But Ideas nonetheless are still anchored in/to memories and the mind.

⁴⁸ See Aristotle's *Physics* and *Metaphysics* in particular for his treatment of potentiality and actuality.

By anchored I mean temporally anchored. Ideas *do* continue to exist in time, even if not in space. They remain entangled with the *right* future memory(ies). If pressed, I would admit that's what I mean by partial existence rather than non-existence or full existence. And this could function as a working definition of what non-physical things *are*.

All that being said, even though ideas are non-physical, in the genuine sense, I hold, they still possess causal powers. The primary instrument of ideas, for interacting with the world, and the human organism, is the rational faculty or Reason. Reason is a source of volition involving ideas. It utilizes ideas to direct memories and influence behavior. Some of the strongest influencers there are come from Ideas. That said, we should acknowledge most of our actions are based on memories, or experience, rather than reason or ideas. There is nothing inherently wrong with this. Commonsense beliefs and habit are useful guides. They just lack the force of a rational sanction. But I'll talk about Reason and action (and importantly, also emotion) in more detail later.⁴⁹

Ideas can also be contemplated, whatever that entails, through a source of conscious inner volition. This is somewhat of a mystery and different from examining a projected mental image or recalling a memory. I speculate it involves finding necessary connections and overlap between ideas. There are programs within larger programs, so to speak. The further and more abstract we go, the closer we get to understanding the workings of the mind. The goal, in theory, would be to find the source code(s) of all Ideas you house. This eventually, I admit, becomes an esoteric exercise; but if I had to guess, the source code(s) probably involves the primitive ideas; with the master Idea being Time or God—even though God contributes nothing new outside of Himself.

In closing, I acknowledge a likely response to the kind of reasoning I am employing would be to compare my treatment of ideas to Platonic Forms.⁵⁰ The comparison is almost irresistible, and has been made time and time again throughout history to similar types of arguments. But such a comparison would be misguided. While I agree that Forms/ideas are immaterial and even that there may be some special immaterial *Reservoir* that could house ideas in something like the active intellect⁵¹, I don't take it that Forms/ideas are the ultimate cause of the physical world or that there is some separate better ideal reality. In fact, I take it, Forms/ideas have less reality than physical objects, or even less reality than memories. Let's not succumb to Plato's 2,500-year-old trap, as beautiful as it may be.

7. Words and Archetypes

I cannot doubt that language owes its origin to the imitation and modification, aided by signs and gestures, of various natural sounds, the voices of other animals, and man's own instinctive cries.
(Charles Darwin, *The Descent of Man*)

⁴⁹ See Section 13.

⁵⁰ See Plato's *Phaedo* and *Republic* in particular for an overview of the Forms. While Platonic Forms are notoriously difficult to make sense of, they are put simply: eternal, immaterial ideals for each thing, or category of things—separable and independent from those things.

⁵¹ See Aristotle's *De Anima* (On the Soul) Book 3 for a treatment of the active intellect. The active intellect, roughly, is an eternal mental source that preserves knowledge, and can turn potential knowledge into actual knowledge.

Cratylus says that there is a correctness of name for each thing, one that belongs to it by nature. A thing's name isn't whatever people agree to call it—some bit of their native language that applies to it—but there is a natural correctness to names, which is the same for everyone, Greek or foreigner.
(Plato, *Cratylus*)

At some point, relatively recently, we began to speak, or more correctly we started to use *words*. But, to be clear, memories, emotions, archetypes, ideas, were already boiling inside us communicating in its own strange language from within. Now I said words are code that are used to instantiate ideas in the mind. While I take this to be correct, it is somewhat of an oversimplification. Words are also used to express emotions and share memories. (We also use words to ask questions, alert others, issue commands, etc. But I am not concerned with that here.) The very first proto-words were likely used for expressing emotions. When such articulation was possible our ancestors can be taken (even if as a reaction) to have routinely vocalized: "ah," "ow," "ooh," "ick," "huh," "poof," "ha ha," "ugh," "aw," "eek," etc., and other expressions of the sort. I take these, which we now call interjections, to be more than mere sounds. "Ha ha," for instance, would have had significance to our ancestors. It would have been understood to relay an emotion like joy or excitement. And it seems the first intentional words spoken for joy or happiness, for example, would include the sound "ha." (Though I concede, I am not pursuing a linguistic analysis. It is nearly impossible to trace any known languages to the original proto-language(s). I instead speculate on how a proto-language could naturally arise, given some of the other concepts I endorse.) Our ancestors, as Darwin points out, likely were also able to mimic calls/sounds of animals and other noises in the environment. So there seemed to be a reservoir of *sounds* to draw phonemes from. The big question, of course, would be how these phonemes, once words, become language?⁵² But I am foremost in this section concerned with the naturalness of words.

The issue of the naturalness of words in language was first raised by Plato in the *Cratylus*. The question in the dialogue is whether there is a *fit* or appropriateness to the words we use, or instead that words are arbitrary and simply a matter of convention? Plato is somewhat ambivalent on the matter. But I take it there are arguments that might be siphoned in support of the view that words (names) are not merely conventional (without necessarily taking the extreme naturalist position of Cratylus in the dialogue.⁵³) In looking to naturalness, the first words were likely onomatopoeias, where the word directly imitates the sound of the thing it describes. For example, the word "snore" imitates the sound we make in our sleep and the word "clap" imitates the sound our hands make when we strike them together. Other examples would be words like "roar" which mimics the animal sound it describes and "drip-drop" which mimics the sound of slowly falling water. (Many signs in sign language also manually mimic the words they describe.) The link between the word and the sound in these types have appropriateness and are not arbitrary, though there are admittedly limitations to their complexity and explanatory power.

⁵² I take this question up in the next section.

⁵³ See Plato's *Cratylus*, in particular 428e-429b, for Cratylus' extreme naturalist position.

In the dialogue, Plato suggests that appropriateness or fit can be derived from the intentions of the original rule-setter or name-giver.⁵⁴ He takes the name giver(s) to have been wise and something like a philosopher or dialectician. Such a person, we take it, would not arbitrarily name things, but instead would assign names for words in a way that reflects their nature, or at minimum captures some likeness. For example, I would say in naming something such as a 'chair', the chosen word should reflect certain attributes, for instance, like having legs, a base, being low, used for sitting, or for leisure, etc. To use a rather straightforward example, the English word "chair" can be traced back to the Greek word "kathedra" which can be broken down into the roots "kata" (down) and "hedra" (seat). So, this example seems an appropriate and fitting name, in that it reflects 'sitting' and 'being low'. Of course, not all examples are this clean. But this captures what a fitting word might look like.⁵⁵

Plato also holds appropriateness can be derived from phonemes themselves. He takes certain types of pronunciations to imitate the things named.⁵⁶ For instance, he claims, using the letter "r" causes some agitation in its pronunciation and is best used to describe things in motion or hardness. Pronouncing "i" involves the expulsion of breath and is best used in describing small things. In pronouncing "l" the tongue glides suggesting softness and smoothness. Pronouncing "g" stops the gliding of the tongue and should be used to describe something intense. Pronouncing "n" brings the tongue inward being suggestive of things that are within or enclosed. The phonemes "a" and "ē" are pronounced long being used for largeness or length. The letter "o" is taken to literally correspond to its shape and best used in words describing round things. We can of course question Plato's conclusions here, and there would be significant variation in different languages. But there do seem to be some sounds that are more pleasing and more fitting in describing certain things. The word "rock," for instance, doesn't quite seem like it would be an appropriate replacement for the word "daffodil," in referring to the type of flower. If this is more than a gut feeling then we can say that words, at least following this type of rubric, are not entirely arbitrary.

But while I take these arguments to be convincing, I believe they only work in an already established linguistic community. I am interested instead in how the original proto-language(s) emerged in the absence of any phonemes or words. In pursuing this task, I do hold that there was a rule-setter or name/sound-giver. But, originally, I take this individual to be a *singer* rather than a philosopher or dialectician. I redraw on the *singing ape hypothesis*.⁵⁷ That is, in the pre-linguistic condition, after certain evolutionary developments, our ancestors took a liking to song. Considering song's strong emotional appeal this should have been something that captivated our ancestors or got their attention. I postulate that the best singer(s) would have been something like clan celebrities. Other clansman would have gathered around to listen to them. In accord, there would be strong incentive for the singer to experiment with different sounds and combinations of sounds in pursuit of novelty and effectiveness (at drawing out emotional responses).⁵⁸ Importantly,

⁵⁴ See *Cratylus* 388b-389a.

⁵⁵ Also see *Cratylus* 391d-421c, where Socrates gives numerous etymological examples for words he takes to be appropriately formed.

⁵⁶ See *Cratylus* 421c-427d.

⁵⁷ Refer back to Section 3.

⁵⁸ I should point out that music is still very important to us, and good singers are still celebrities to this day. This is one explanation for why this is the case.

listening to the singer could be done without cost. There need not be any investment in listening to *songs*, compared to, for instance, heeding or not heeding a warning call. In this way, new sounds could freely be introduced to the clan; in which it seems likely other clansman would go on to try to imitate. Eventually, through a selective process, I hypothesize, this could produce spoken words or the progenitors of spoken words. Where, I hold, words are more robust (than mere sounds) and would have been more readily preserved once introduced. In the background, of course, there would also need to be an evolutionary shift (and probably sexual selection) favoring increased articulacy. Though I seek primarily to offer an explanation for the availableness of words.⁵⁹

In getting back to naturalness or fittingness, we might return to the ways in which I claimed words are used. I said words are code for instantiating ideas and then went on to claim words can be used to express emotions. It may now be useful to talk about a third important function of words: sharing memories. This need not be too complicated for simple memories. I might use words, for example, to say to a friend: "Just think of the bottle of champagne that exploded at the beach house last summer." Here the words are apt if the memory is shared and brought up in the other person's mind (in a more or less accurate representation). What's important to note is that an idea is typically not instantiated in the process of recollection, unless the recipient shifts to examining the individual components of the memory or the content of what was said. But usually that's not the case. The memory is simply brought up and *re-experienced*. On the other hand, the more sophisticated memories: archetypes, I take it, are rooted in a long-established natural process and *can* be used to act as a measure for determining which words are fit in a non-superficial way.

We've looked at a relatively small number of archetypes so far. But as Jung points out, there are "as many archetypes as there are typical situations in life."⁶⁰ We can thus rely on large numbers of archetypes to determine a word's fittingness in various usages and then extend it to similar instances. Though I'll try to stick to a few familiar archetypes. By doing so we can have an additional standard for showing that certain words are appropriate and fitting rather than arbitrary. But we might ask what gives archetypes authority in deciding which words are appropriate? For one, archetypes are universal and instinctual. They have a *feel* to them. Certain sounds and words dispose us to respond in a certain way.

Some of these feels would be to place archetypes into linguistic groupings such as masculine/feminine (i.e., Sword/Flower), positive/negative (i.e., Light/Dark), and lofty/banal (i.e., Breath/Mud). Feminine, positive, and lofty words should have a soft sound and be more drawn out. Masculine, negative, and banal words should sound harsher and be more abrupt. Though there are many exceptions to this. These groupings also determine what should be said about certain things. Words used to describe the Hero archetype and its derivations should not be feminine or negative. Words used to describe the Wise Old Man archetype and its derivations should not be banal. Words used in association with the Body, Blood, Bread archetypes should not be lofty, and so on. When a word deviates too much from its associative archetypal grouping it is no longer appropriate and becomes unfit. But one might object that these associations have no real foundation. The reply is that these linguistic feels along with its archetypes are ultimately rooted

⁵⁹ Steven Mithen forwards many good anthropological arguments in support of the *singing ape hypothesis* in his book *The Singing Neanderthals*, worth looking at. Though, as previously mentioned, the idea was first proposed by Darwin.

⁶⁰ See Jung's *Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious*, p. 48.

in human emotion. Emotions, being original existences, have no further explanation. We are simply disposed to respond to certain types of things in characteristic ways.

To see an example of this, we might look at the Maiden archetype. It is not by chance that the word "maiden" is used (in English), rather than some other word. I take it the word "maiden" is appropriate and fit for its object. But the very similar word "broad," which means roughly the same thing (in reference to a young woman), is not. The word "broad," for instance, has a hard sound and is slightly negative, being inconsistent with the typical archetypal form. In rooting the word "broad" it can be traced to the Old English "brād," which means wide. It is not exactly clear how 'wideness' shares a likeness with the thing described; which instead should have characteristics like youth, beauty, being unmarried, female, a virgin, playfulness, desirability. One interpretation of the word "broad" is that 'wideness' refers to 'wide hips', suggesting female sexual appeal. But that specific distinction is not within the word itself and is instead simply stipulated as a matter of convention. Thus, "broad" is not an appropriate or fit word for capturing its referent—at least according to the standards we are applying.

We might also rely on various archetypes and their meanings to ground appropriate likenesses in words. Considering this allows for connections to be derived from symbolic and metaphorical associations, a rich supply of word options become available to us. (We might also use proper names to draw associations, but this, in my opinion, is subject to too much variation, and is less apt than using archetypes.) For example, if we take 'machine' along with the symbolic and metaphorical associations in its archetype, we can create new (appropriate) words. Instead of relying solely on its root "mekhane," meaning a device or tool, we can add its symbolic aspects like body, ugliness, coldness, to it. For consideration, if we combined the root of ugliness, "uggr" (dreaded) with "mekhos" (have power) we might derive a new word capturing something like 'dreaded power of a machine' or a 'type of machine with dreaded power'. Considering there are in fact such machines on the horizon, which will be dreaded as well as powerful, this might provide a name for it that is fit, compared to one that is arbitrary or merely conventional. (Though, to be clear, a conventional name still works given people are told what it means and agree to use it in that way. And this is true of all conventional names. But it would lack naturalness.)

But how did archetypes become a linguistic standard? Let us return to our primitive linguistic community and jump forward in time. The clan is now a large tribe, and speaking one or two words at a time is relatively common. There are still singers, but a new type of tribal celebrity is emerging: the *poet storyteller*. He's met with indifference at first, but tribesmen listen to his words, mainly because it costs nothing. Like the singer, the poet storyteller would have strong incentive to experiment with new speech patterns. But instead of sounds, his craft involves strings of words. He would try out different combinations of words in the pursuit of novelty and garnishing a favorable reaction from other tribesmen. The poet storyteller's words would initially lack the emotional force of a song. Until by chance, he fortuitously hits the *right* combination of words capable of invoking an archetype. Once this happens, tribesmen would be captivated and drawn in, encouraging the poet storyteller to repeat the *magic words* for them. Emotional appeal could then be established—through archetypes—in many ways more powerful than what was possible with song.

From here, I take it, there would be the phenomenon of runaway loquaciousness. That is, after hearing the magic words—capable of capturing the archetypes within—there would be an

insatiable impulse to rehear these words and repeat them to others. Once archetypes had the capacity to be shared externally, we would be compelled to continuously realize them, even when it does not directly aid our survival to do so—though it would work to the benefit of archetypes, and also eventually ideas. Thus, constant chatter will prevail. What's important is that speech be exorbitant and wasteful enough to produce enough material to allow for selective pressure. Archetypes bring this about. Rationality, I take it, in its intentionality, would also rapidly speed up the process of language acquisition once excessive talking became a consistent behavioral pattern. These things combined, I suggest, would lead to beneficial adaptations. I admit, these postulations are highly speculative, but at some point in our evolution, whatever that point may be, humans did in fact become pathological talkers, and still are to this day. I am just assigning archetypes as the cause.

In finishing up the quodlibet, I hold that there is a threshold where languages will start to change on their own. Once the threshold is crossed, a language without serious impediment will increase in complexity—assuming there are enough active speakers and continuity. I hold that archetypes gave the first push needed to cross the barrier.⁶¹ But to be clear, we are still at the level of a proto-language. Languages don't reach their full potential until ideas are being exchanged on a large scale. It is ideas which carry language most effectively. Also, worth noting, is that I have said nothing about syntax. How strings of words can morph into syntactical language is its own unique puzzle. I am tempted to bring in Noam Chomsky's universal grammar to make it work.⁶² But even Chomsky largely rejects universal grammar these days.⁶³ My tempered response would be that rationality includes an aesthetic faculty that can somehow *choose*, whether it's based on mathematics, or music, or rhythm, or harmony, whatever. Some things simply seem more beautiful or more harmonious than others. And fluency in some ways resembles this: certain combinations of words just don't sound right; and others do. This may prove dissatisfying to some. So I leave it to the linguists to connect words to grammar.

Towards the end of the *Cratylus*, Plato claims that we should perhaps not focus on words but rather on knowing the essential nature of things (mainly, his theory of Forms).⁶⁴ But we may ask, in regard to essential natures, what it is that we contemplate in the absence of words? Is it an undifferentiated mental image, or instead, some *feeling* of knowing? A particular memory might also be a possible option if we take Plato's theory of Recollection seriously.⁶⁵ But this doesn't quite seem right. I would say words are required to truly make sense of Forms—if Forms are possible—or ideas in general, and that there is a linguistic Form-naturalism that can be had. For instance, if we take Plato's Good simply to be or included in the aesthetic faculty, it might act as a mechanism

⁶¹ One may point to my lack of mention of lying and deceptiveness in the language origin story. I don't see this as a serious issue. There is no truth in relation to words at this point of the language's evolution. Words are merely aesthetic at this stage.

⁶² Universal grammar is the idea that the rules of grammar or language itself is innate in humans. As first argued in Chomsky's *Syntactic Structures* and *Aspects of the Theory of Syntax*.

⁶³ See, for example, Chomsky's "Three Factors in Language Design," for his later revisions and weakening of the theory of universal grammar.

⁶⁴ See *Cratylus* 439b-440e.

⁶⁵ See in particular *Meno*, *Phaedo*, and *Phaedrus* for a refresher on Plato's theory of Recollection. In its basic formulation, Plato's theory of Recollection holds that we can have knowledge of the Forms by recalling past memories of those forms that we might have had in a previous (non-material) existence.

in which to see whether words are appropriate or fit their object. Where discovering this appropriateness or fittingness reveals knowledge of the object. Plato does comment that "naming things (kaloun) is to perform beautiful (kalon) works."⁶⁶ How seriously to take this is a matter of debate. Counter to what Plato claims—in the *Cratylus* at least—words *do* act as a means through which we acquire knowledge and meaning.

8. Language and Meaning

Words exist because of meaning. Once you've gotten the meaning,
you can forget the words. Where can I find a man who has forgotten
words so I can have a word with him.
(Zhuang Zhou, *Zhuangzi*)

So soon as I talk I express the universal, and if I do not do so, no one
can understand me.
(Søren Kierkegaard, *Fear and Trembling*)

In the previous section, I told a story of the genesis of words. The truth is we'll never know for sure how words originally came to be. But if I'm allowed a certain latitude, I think we can respond to an ongoing problem in philosophy: linguistic meaning. I want to be clear that linguistic meaning is something different than Meaning in general or something like The Meaning of Life. Unfortunately, I don't have those answers. Though I hope to offer a satisfactory answer to spiritual meaning by the end of the essay. To get at linguistic meaning, we must delve into the nature of language. This will take some sorting out.

To start, I claimed that words are primarily code for instantiating ideas—as well as for expressing emotions and sharing memories. My focus was largely on spoken words. But to be clear, words need not be vocal. Along with written letters (representing sounds), I take certain hand gestures and pictures and mathematical symbols to be words or serve the same function as words. I will limit myself to the first use of words: instantiating ideas. This is not to say the other two uses are unimportant. But limiting myself in this way will make the argument much more manageable. One thing to clarify, is that while all languages are composed of words, words are not sufficient for language in itself. What is it then that makes words (individually or as an aggregate) language or encompass language?

The basic answer, and subject of this section, is that for a word or words to count as language they must carry or convey meaning. There are of course ways of communicating without this requirement being met, such as shouting interjections, but usually we wouldn't call it language. Or it could not function in itself as a language. Though this requirement could be challenged. If language does require meaning, which I take to be the case, then we might raise the following questions: What does linguistic meaning correspond to (besides the words themselves)? What makes words meaningful? What is the content of meaning-imparting words? And how are these

⁶⁶ *Cratylus* 416d.

meaning-imparting words effectively communicated? These questions will shape the discussion that follows. Though I hope to do a little more than simply answer these questions.

Jumping right in, I hold that meaning does not correspond to reality but rather to ideas. But this is not to take the Lockean position that meaning is whatever particular mental image the word references.⁶⁷ Rather, meaning is found in the configuration. And to reiterate, we all manifest the same configuration of each idea. In fact, it would be difficult if not impossible to convey meaning with one another if there wasn't some shared configuration to draw from. One might counter that we can share meaning through similar instances or like-enough mental images. But this, I believe, would be an appeal to memories not ideas. We can indeed elicit like memories in others through the right words—and as previously stated this is one use of words. But this is more shared familiarity than shared meaning. (Though emotional significance might be established, and relayed, which we might confuse with meaning.)

I don't want to completely discount the phenomenon in question. As I pointed out, most of our interaction with ideas is through mental images; mental images being memories under my view. So, when making sense of an idea like 'chair' we will typically utilize mental images of individual chairs drawn from memory. But while it may be possible to elucidate "chairness" by pointing to several individual chairs, in memory, or in the world, this only establishes resemblance; and possibly difference once we try to categorize it in the mind. While this is a useful process, and in many cases unavoidable, it is not necessary for meaning. The meaning in the configuration can be had without the flurry of particular mental images. Though in practice particular mental images will present along with it. This is not entirely problematic, except for the fact that most people take the mental images themselves to be the idea; which isn't the case.

In reply to Master Zhuang, there may be an even more peculiar man who has forgotten both words and particular mental images. What remains? It seems what is preserved are abstract concepts. Though it is unclear how abstract concepts persist. But we seem to have some experience of it. What are abstract concepts? They might be taken as some shared aspect that can be attributed to like particular things, but is not a particular itself. In language, adjectives are commonly the mechanism used to attach or instill abstract concepts to particular things. Typically, adjectives are properties that a thing might have. But we may ask what the adjective contributes to the particular that the particular doesn't already possess? Or likewise, we may question whether adjectives represent real properties or are redundant? This creates a problem, which might be called the *problem of adjectives*. Mainly, language doesn't necessarily need adjectives as they are typically used to convey meaning. This seems like a small claim, but it has huge ramifications if we take it seriously.⁶⁸ For example, instead of saying "red chair" we could instead say "chairness and redness occur together" or interchangeably "redness and chairness occur together." All that is needed is the primitive idea of Time, and maybe Proximity to make sense of this. And it is a perfectly viable means of linguistic communication.

⁶⁷ See Locke, *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*, 3:2:1-2.

⁶⁸ This also denies fixes and make-shift uses of special verbs and nouns in the place of adjectives. I take these moves to simply involve informal adjectives. What I am claiming is that we don't necessarily need to use adjectives at all, formal or informal, for language to work, or at least for it to convey meaning.

Of course, coherently taking a view like this forces us down some interesting paths, in some ways resembling the historical Problem of Universals debate⁶⁹, mainly: (1) universals—abstract concepts—are real and this is just the manifestation of two unique universals, chairness and redness, in the world within their particular substratum (material makeup)⁷⁰, or (2) there is only a single underlying undifferentiated substratum and all other descriptions, including chairness and redness, are universal predicates of it⁷¹, or (3) there are really only universals, such as chairness and redness, and no necessary substratum—e.g., idealism; and if the presentation is faulty or imperfect or a copy, Platonic idealism, or (4) there are only particular things, substratum or otherwise, and chairness and redness are just arbitrary descriptions we give to them (viz, they are not universals)⁷², or (5) there are indeed lots of unique particular things, like red chairs, but when we try to categorize seemingly like things in the mind we create something entirely new and distinct: the universal.⁷³ Or my view (6) that there is a preexisting configuration for every possible type, such as chairness and redness, which we might loosely call the universal, but the universal only exists potentially, not actually, unless instantiated *in* a mind. Of course, one odd implication of my view is that if you already have the words, as code, you don't need to rely on particular things. But, to be clear, you also need physical memories, like seeing furniture or colors, which require particular things at some point. So it is a type of dualism in practice.⁷⁴ Unsurprisingly, I subscribe to (6). But my theory of linguistic meaning could work with any of the options given, considering that meaning corresponds to ideas not reality. Why does this matter?

If we drop adjectives as modifiers we are forced to explain properties and universals. We cannot simply pivot to the noun or object. While a red chair is mundane, chairness and redness are mysterious. It is likely because of the widespread use of adjectives that there are many abstract concepts that we simply cannot explain or account for. If this weren't the case, we would have derived meaningful explanations for these things over the last several thousand years—out of necessity. This is not to say the stuff of adjectives don't exist. They clearly do. But they are misunderstood. What to do? I say treat them on their own, rather than relationally. Here we might stop talking about red chairs and instead talk about chairness and redness. If we can form a coherent

⁶⁹ The historical Problem of Universal debate focuses on whether universals are real. It seems to have settled on three prominent answers to the question, roughly, (a) Realism - universals are real, (b) Nominalism - universals are not real, and (c) Conceptualism - universals are real, but only exist in the mind.

⁷⁰ This realist view is typically attributed to Aristotle. Forms, universals, exist in numerous particular things, but need to be abstracted by the mind to be known.

⁷¹ This is another realist view that is held by Aristotle in certain places, like *Metaphysics* Books 7-9, *Physics* Book 1, and *On Generation and Corruption* Books 1-2. Here we only interact with forms, universals, not the prime matter as he would call it. But both the prime matter and the universals exist, and the universals are inseparable from necessary prime matter.

⁷² A likely nominalist response to the example I raised.

⁷³ The conceptualist reply.

⁷⁴ One maneuver might be to point to artificial or virtual stimulation of the mind that is entirely independent of any particular things in the world, nudging us toward a more idealistic framework in certain scenarios, like brains in vats being stimulated by electrodes. This is a really interesting possibility. But I think my theory can survive this thought-bomb. Because I defined memories as only needing to be representations that resemble sense impressions, even brains in vats cases hold up, assuming the experiences in question have semblance to reality and that the brains are in fact physical. It would be a strange condition. But you still can have a perfectly healthy and functional mind under my view.

idea of chairness and redness we can easily understand red chairs. But the reverse isn't true. In searching for linguistic meaning, I propose we should engage universals themselves, as ideas, rather than haphazardly attaching them to particulars or classes of particulars. For instance, chairs need not be red. Once we accept this, we will be in a much better semantic position—at least in regard to universals, however they might be defined. In fact, dealing with ideas or universals, rather than particulars, is where we will find the substance of linguistic meaning—as opposed to mere familiarity or conventional agreement.

In rebuttal, one could argue that we lose useful descriptions without adjectives, like large, small, rich, fat, tall. This is extremely easy to compensate for. Instead of "tall" we could just say "2 meters." This relays more information and avoids the inherent vagueness in such terms. The detractor may go on, what about deep, shallow, heavy, dim, bright? Again, we could just say "2 meters," or "100 kilograms," or "200 lumens." And then, finally, big ones, like beautiful, ugly, good, bad. I take it these are so important to warrant being treated in themselves, as beauty, goodness, etc., rather than being used as vague and confused adjectives. "The Good," being one application of this sentiment. It makes more philosophical sense to say the Good is or occurs rather than this or that thing is good. I'm not saying we necessarily need to make the adjustment put forward. It likely would be inefficient and impractical. I'm only saying such an adjustment is possible linguistically, and meaning could be relayed just fine, in some cases better. So with that, let's put adjectives aside in order to avoid a monumental labor of linguistics in the non-philosophical fashion.

The next question is what is transferred in the process of linguistic communication? In particular, what is necessary for linguistic meaning to be achieved? I said it was code, and that a certain *type* of code is needed to instantiate each idea. But just like in the case of programmable code, code as words can be neat or messy, as well as complex or wasteful. It is also the case that some ideas can be ran on a single word or a few words, whereas others may require hundreds or thousands or tens of thousands of words to run. Some people may also fail to successfully run ideas even in the presence of the right code. Others may be unable to run certain ideas at all, due to corruption in their software, or defective hardware, so to speak. But we might side-step this and ask what is the minimal amount of words, as code, needed to run an idea in a mind able to instantiate it? The linguistic light coal. This of course will vary based on the idea and to a small extent the spoken language. The idea of 'redness' may only require a single word to run (i.e., "red," "roja," "aka"), the idea of 'triangle' may require a few words to run ("three-sided figure"), and an idea like 'chair' will require many words to run, including a subroutine for the program 'furniture'. One might point out that we can establish the idea of triangle, for instance, by using names for different types of triangles. But, I take it, for these names to have any meaning a person must already have the idea of triangle in the mind.

For very complicated ideas there are programs within greater programs and so on, as I established earlier in the essay. There are also foundational ideas which all other ideas rely on, which I held to be primitive ideas. The primitive ideas cannot be run with words, so cannot be communicated to others. Though in some sense we have individual access to them if we are willing to search. But as I said, this is largely a mystical process. In terms of meaning, a person usually would like to relay a lot more than the linguistic light coal. Their personal perspective, as we might say. But due to the economy of language only a small portion of this mental package is typically

delivered or hits. Hence, Kierkegaard is right to worry that something important is lost in communication. Largely, only the universal is transferred, in terms of linguistic meaning. Subjective meaning is mostly lost. But this need not be as significant of a worry as it seems. Because we all manifest the same universals, ideas, in the mind we can have some sense of what is going on in other peoples' heads. Archetypes and emotions are also similar for all humans. So, if we accept my greater theory, we share a lot of the same mental features with our fellow man. The only unique aspect that remains are simple memories. And perhaps this is what subjectivity is. Though, that being said, the interrelation of all of a person's individual ideas, emotions, and memories likely produces something novel that only the person themselves can understand. There may also be bodily influences that we have no way of explaining. Thus, special subjectivity is still an issue, and something that must be sacrificed in the practice of language.

But let us return to linguistic meaning itself. Linguistic meaning, as I claimed, is conveyed if the intended idea is instantiated in a mind capable of receiving it. When someone says I understand what you mean, they imply that they share the same idea or can identify the same idea that you are trying to relay. In my view, this is not just a proximation, but two people can in fact share identical ideas. So, there is a genuine sense in which meaning is relayed. And this is what I take linguistic meaning to be: *the shared instantiation of ideas through words*. It is worth considering that when people use superfluous words (messy or wasteful code) there may be accidental meaning that might be achieved other than the intended meaning. I don't take this to be linguistic meaning. It is rather misinterpretation. People can derive many things from superfluous words and superfluous variations of words, even gibberish, but if it is unintended, meaning is not exchanged but rather is simply an extension of already existing meaning in the listener. I do acknowledge hearing some nonsense or gibberish may incite some really profound thoughts. But this is not communication, and is entirely accidental. For instance, if you heard the same gibberish an hour before you likely wouldn't have those profound thoughts. If you would have those thoughts anyway, then any gibberish would likely do; though certain words may function as a stimulus. But a stimulus like this wouldn't contain linguistic meaning. That being said, accidental meaning is something to take seriously. And it may count against my theory. But at least in my view, linguistic meaning must be intentional and shared.

In wrapping up linguistic meaning, I should add some caveats regarding the instantiation of ideas. *Lista*: People typically only instantiate some ideas, not all possible ideas. While not infinite, the range of possible ideas is vast. We may (personally or collectively as a species) currently lack the necessary code or words to instantiate some ideas. Some ideas may be beyond the reach of all existing languages. A new medium of communication, or a new category of words, may be needed to instantiate some ideas. The human brain may need to increase in complexity to process particularly complicated ideas requiring millions or billions of words to instantiate. There may be some ideas that are uninstantiable by merely organic beings. Some ideas may require some other reservoir besides a physical brain to instantiate them. And some ideas may not be instantiable at all. Thus, linguistic meaning—as the shared instantiation of ideas through words—is an evolving process and incomplete.

I would be remiss, in ending this topic, if I did not complete the story of our aspiring linguistic community. They are now part of a confederacy of tribes with a shared language. The language is still primitive and there are competing dialects amongst the tribes, but plentiful words

are spoken and exchanged between them. A rudimentary syntax is also present. But there is a problem. Language continues to shift toward simplicity. Luckily (and grant me some leeway here for the sake of a good tale) the next verbal rectifier will appear: the *epic storyteller*. This is not to say people weren't telling stories. They were. But in this early stage, fiction was a new concept, as opposed to merely lying. Fiction will play an important role in our species' ascent to culture.⁷⁵ And the first individuals skilled at producing great oral fiction performed an invaluable service to the confederacy. Not to mention it was likely highly entertaining to listeners—promoting spread and adoption. A side-effect of this elaborate storytelling is that language and syntax become greatly improved. When every word choice is crucial and sentences are crafted specifically for the task of producing epics, language evolves, both in complexity and poetic appeal. Inevitably, competing epics would emerge amongst the tribes. One or more epic, I take it, over time would become dominant and gain authority in the confederacy. This type of linguistic and artistic selection then becomes paramount in defining and uniting communities. And from here we can move away from wild speculation to the typical practice of cultural anthropology. Thus, the next section takes us forward by exploring one of the first and most important derivations of your typical epic: myths.

9. Mythos

The whole of mythology could be taken as a sort of projection of the collective unconscious.

(Carl Jung, *Symbols of Transformation*)

Prometheus matched himself in wit with the almighty son of Cronus. For when the gods and mortal men had a dispute at Mecone, even then Prometheus was forward to cut up a great ox and set portions before them, trying to deceive the mind of Zeus. Before the rest he set flesh and inner parts thick with fat upon the hide, covering them with an ox paunch; but for Zeus he put the white bones dressed up with cunning art and covered with shining fat.

(Hesiod, *Theogony*)

Humans are great storytellers. Some of our best and oldest stories are Myths. These types of stories have entertained, inspired, and even rooted tradition for millennia. Once we started talking we just couldn't help ourselves from offering up fantastical accounts of the world (probably due to pent-up archetypes and ideas yearning to be released). The fact that many myths, despite being ridiculous, have survived this long is miraculous. But we love them and think they are very important—whether they are true or not. Why? I speculate it is because myths capture something

⁷⁵ Historian and philosopher, Yuval Noah Harari, in his *Sapiens* and *Homo Deus*, goes as far as to say that fiction is the cornerstone of culture and is primarily responsible for mankind's success at large scale cooperation and the domination of the planet.

foundational about the *human experience*. They hold ancient knowledge and tap into the parley of the Mind (the best myths connecting us to the Collective Unconscious).

Myths can teach us a lot, if we are willing to look *closely*, and apply some philosophical methodology. Take the *trick at Mecone*. The story, usually, is taken to be an explanation for a particular custom: animal sacrifice. But we might ask ourselves, why does Prometheus care so much; that he is willing to risk the wrath of Zeus? Prometheus is not a lover of animals, but a lover of man; and we can see this again when he brings Fire to humans—ultimately to his demise. If we take the myth, in a more serious way, we can see that what is being negotiated is not an ox sacrifice, but the sacrifice of man. Prometheus' trick is to offer Zeus glamoured up bones; that is our soul after death. The thing he wants to keep is our body, ugly on the outside, but rich inside. The wit, wisdom, craft of Prometheus, his clever trick: there is no life after death; bones are bones, and Humans gain everything in this life. Zeus would eventually discover the deception and demand both our bodies and souls as payback—the cost of fire: that humans must give up everything to the gods.

Another myth that we tend not to take too seriously is the *deluge destruction story*, found in nearly every culture. We either take it metaphoric of man's rebirth from sin, or as some real, localized Big Flood that happened thousands of years ago. But if we readjust our sights, it should occur to us that the story being told is one of the Mind. The deluge, in my view, is the flooding of the unconscious by the Conscious; a burying of all the things old, to make way for the new. Even Sigmund Freud's *glacier model* has the unconscious buried beneath water. The significance of this interpretation is that the storyteller, pushing the metaphor, is likely the Unconscious; the one providing inspiration and poetic art. It has reason to tell its story, in that it has been *wronged*.

The *story of Eve*, and her encounter with the Serpent at the Tree of Wisdom, also has something worthwhile to teach. The first thing to pay attention to is exploitation of archetypes. The image of the Serpent arouses fear, suspicion, mystery, mischief. The image of the Fruit evokes appetite, desire, lust, temptation. Eve is supposedly lured by the Serpent to eat the fruit from the tree. But there is nothing in the story that explicitly points to manipulation on the part of the Serpent. Instead, the Serpent simply tells Eve that no harm will come to her if she eats the fruit. And unlike the lie that God tells (that they will surely die if they eat from the tree) this seems to be true. Adam and Eve leave the Garden on their own accord. God does not force them out. How would He? Unless God took over Adam and Eve's minds; Or threatened to kill them? But there is no indication in the story that this is the case (barring the cherubim preventing reentry). Instead, Adam and Eve leave because they feel guilt for betraying God. But notice that the Serpent's words still hold. No harm comes to them. It is instead their own minds which condemn them.

God's Lie is worth looking at. Why would God lie about the Tree of Wisdom? It seems unlikely that it would be out of malice or spite. Perhaps control? But why allow such a tree at all? One way to make it coherent is take the story at face value. God was in fact telling the truth and the Serpent was lying. After eating the Fruit, Adam and Eve do in fact die in some sense. Their innocence dies. They become cursed beings. But cursed how? I take it the curse is Consciousness itself—being what *knowledge of good and evil* is supposed to signify. For Eden, we might take the archetype of the Garden as representing Nature. Adam and Eve initially live in harmony with nature in a happy blissful state. It is apparent that Adam and Eve, which I take to be representative of some archaic hominid species, or perhaps early humans, are Unconscious for some time. It is

only *after* eating the forbidden fruit that they realize they are Naked. In shame they cover themselves—symbolizing Consciousness' arrival. When this *event* occurred is likely fluid, but it was a pivotal moment in the history of this planet. An animal, donning clothes, rose above nature and claimed it as his own, aware of his own superiority, and suffering. Never to be the same!

Besides having *knowledge of good and evil*, the Serpent tells Eve she will become like God by eating from the tree. What does this mean? Take it from a different angle. It is possible that eating the fruit *created* God in the mind. That is, consciousness itself will always produce God, or some type of religious thinking. So, in a sense, God *did* drive Adam and Eve out of the Garden. Though it is not original sin, but rather theological guilt which we harbor inside of us. Notably, going deeper, it is quite possible the Serpent was *not* trying to persuade Eve to eat the fruit but rather dissuade her. We need to pay attention to our archetypes. In nearly all myths containing the serpent archetype the Serpent is hostile and there to scare you away. Why in this special case is the Serpent friendly, giving, openly offering what it is supposed to be guarding. It doesn't add up. Instead, I take it, the Serpent is there to prevent Us from becoming Conscious. It is Nature's attempt to preserve the sanctity of the natural world. A world incompatible with god-like dominance. The implication being that developing Consciousness was a bad thing for our ancestors and has been a source of misery ever since. (Including the burden of carrying God in our minds forever.)

We might also go back to the inception, to *Father Time and the void*. The early Greek mythos seems to largely center around incestuous families and their many quarrels. Brothers and sisters, mothers and sons, fathers and daughters, marrying each other and giving birth to offspring radically different from themselves; the new generation always to overthrow the old; betrayal, infanticide, mutilation, patricide, wars, you name it. This may be read as high scandal. But even for the Ancient Greek ear it was far-fetched—for people anyway. However, if the early mythos is read not as a story of people but as a story of ideas and archetypes it makes much more sense.

There are varying cosmogonies in the Greek tradition.⁷⁶ But most agree to something like the following. In the very beginning there was Chronos (Time) and Chaos or Nothing. They produced the *cosmic egg*, which hatched Phanes (Day) and Nyx (Night). Here, I think, the cosmic egg could be interpreted as the mind, with Day as consciousness and Night as unconsciousness. In this sense, the world didn't truly exist until perceived by a mind. Phanes and Nyx gave birth to Gaia (Earth), Uranus (The Heavens), and Eros (Love). I interpret Earth to represent nature, The Heavens to represent non-material reality outside of nature, or the non-physical, and Love to represent emotion. The mingling of these Three first lead to the birth of monstrosities, like the Cyclopes and Hecatoncheires.⁷⁷ These first gods I take to be archaic archetypes. Eventually Gaia gave birth to gods with human-like features, being the twelve original Titans: Oceanus, Themis, Rhea, Coeus, Crius, Tethys, Phoebe, Hyperion, Lapetus, Theia, Mnemosyne, and Cronus (not to be confused with Chronos). These Titans I take to be representative of the more advanced anthropomorphic archetypes. Here we have what might be viewed as the *First World Order*.

Uranus turned out to be a terrible father and hated his children. He hated the Cyclopes and Hecatoncheires in particular, and banished them to Tartarus, the deepest pits beneath the earth, far deeper than Hades. I take Tartarus to be a rather clear representation of the deep unconscious. In

⁷⁶ See, for instance, Hesiod's *Theogony*, Orphic *Cosmogonies*, and Apollodorus' *Cosmogony*.

⁷⁷ The Cyclopes only had one eye and the Hecatoncheires had a hundred arms and fifty heads.

this sense, the archaic archetypes become repressed and forgotten. Relinquishing some of her children, more correctly her first children, made Gaia very upset. In retaliation, Gaia solicited the help of her other children, the twelve Titans, to overthrow Uranus and free her first children. Only the youngest Titan, Cronus, offered to aid his mother. Gaia gave Cronus a powerful sickle which he used to castrate Uranus as he attempted to lay with her. In his mutilation Uranus fled and disappeared. With Uranus deposed Cronus became the ruler of the world. The castration of Uranus has symbolic significance. By being castrated Uranus no longer is able to reproduce or create new lineages.⁷⁸ This permanently severs the link to the Heavens, or non-material reality. Cronus and the Titans start a new line that is much more Earth-bound. But Cronus does absorb some his father's power, and inherits his non-physical aspects. I take Cronus to represent the primitive idea of God. And from this lineage will sprout more sophisticated ideas, embodied by his children, the Olympian gods.

Upon gaining power, Cronus fulfills his mother's wish and frees the Cyclopes and Hecatoncheires from Tartarus. He marries his sister Rhea, and with the rest of the Titans rules over the world. This might be viewed as the *Second World Order*. It is suggested that Cronus ruled peacefully for a very long time. For instance, in antiquity, rule under Cronus is described as a golden age for mankind, or at least for the *first men*⁷⁹—which might be interpreted as early humans. But eventually Rhea began to produce offspring. Whether it be from Gaia, or whispers from the lingering Uranus, Cronus hears the prophecy that one of his children will depose him as he deposed his own father. This makes Cronus very paranoid. He rebanshes the Cyclopes and Hecatoncheires, and swallows his children as Rhea gives birth to them. In desperation, Rhea secretly replaced her last child, Zeus, with a stone (the Omphalos stone), feeding it to Cronus in his place. Zeus is then hidden away outside of Cronus' reach. Something worth mentioning is that paranoia of being *overthrown* is a persistent characteristic of the Godhead in all forms taken. There will always be hostility toward rival ideas, and depending on the form, this extends to other ideas in general. The true desire of God is to be the only idea that occupies the mind.⁸⁰

After Zeus matures, he and his mother seek out the help of Metis, Zeus' older cousin and the first goddess of wisdom, to save the rest of the Olympian gods. Metis crafts a special emetic to give to Cronus. Disguised as a cupbearer Zeus feeds the emetic to Cronus causing him to regurgitate the swallowed gods: Poseidon, Hades, Demeter, Hera, and Hestia. Upon seeing his children freed Cronus flees. In gratitude, the emancipated gods make Zeus their leader. This then leads to a brutal war between the Titans and the newly freed Olympian gods. Something significant to look at is how the Olympian gods were freed. With the aid of Metis' craft, they escape out of Cronus' mouth. I take this to be representative of the evolution of language. Speech allows the new gods (ideas) to escape *out of the mouth*. In this way, ideas can become much more sophisticated and elaborate. Instead of a basic form or model; with the aid of language, we can, for instance, using the later Apollo, give him a bow—to represent archery—and a lyre—to represent music and

⁷⁸ Uranus does produce new offspring indirectly during the act of being castrated, his blood sprouting the Giants, the Meliae, and the Furies; with the foam from his testicles creating the goddess Aphrodite.

⁷⁹ For instance, see Hesiod's *Works and Days*.

⁸⁰ See Section 15 for a discussion of the Godhead.

the arts—give him the power of healing and prophesy, make him watch over herders, associate him with the Sun, and so on. This allows for the creation of very powerful and captivating deities.⁸¹

With the assistance of Metis, a few Titan defectors, and the Cyclopes and Hecatoncheires (newly freed by Zeus)⁸², the Olympians win the war against Cronus and the Titans. Zeus then banishes the Titans to Tartarus. (My interpretation here is that ideas (Olympians) replace the anthropomorphic archetypes (Titans) and push them to the deep unconscious (Tartarus).) With the Titans gone, Zeus and the other Olympians (to grow to twelve) rule over the world. This establishes the *Third World Order*: the reign of Ideas. More wars will follow, against the Giants (lingering products of Uranus) and Gaia's monstrous offspring Typhon (which I take to be the embodiment of all the Archaic Archetypes), but the Olympians prevail, eventually receiving Gaia's blessing—or her acknowledgment of defeat. This signifies the Age of Man and his conquest and exploitation of the Earth. Of course, I should acknowledge, the Greek Pantheon, and polytheism, will eventually be replaced by a monotheistic Judeo-Christian god.⁸³ But I don't necessarily see this as a new world order, as far as the Mind is concerned. The Judeo-Christian god, in his simplicity, is more like Cronus than Zeus in my view. Perhaps it is a return to the *Second World Order*: rule by a single primitive Idea and all His anthropomorphic archetypes (reflected in the decorations and mythos of the Church).

Another important theme in the Mythos that tends to be reoccurring is immortality. There are various symbols capturing it like Ambrosia/Nectar, The Fountain(s) of Youth, Magic Elixirs, The Tree of Life, The Holy Grail, Blessed/Cursed Blood, and so forth. In most traditions, gods also tend to be immortal. So becoming immortal is linked to achieving godliness. An interesting spin on the immortality tale comes from one of the oldest myths, or at least one of the oldest myths written down and (mostly) preserved: the Sumerian *Legend of Adapa*. The story starts right after the Great Flood. The human race is left without guidance, so Ea, god of wisdom, decides to bestow perfect intelligence (and wisdom) on a mortal man, Adapa.⁸⁴ It's not exactly clear from the text how Adapa uses this intelligence, but scholars typically take him to have become/be a great sage or king. One day while out on the water fishing Adapa's boat is capsized by a strong gust of wind. Adapa becomes infuriated by this and in his anger breaks the wings of the South Wind. As a result, the South Wind does not blow for seven days.

The South Wind not blowing catches the attention of the powerful sky god, Anu. He summons Adapa to the heavens to answer for the transgression. Being concerned, Ea counsels Adapa on how to handle himself in Anu's court. Ea first gives advice on how to flatter the old gods Tammuz and Gishida, the doorkeepers to Anu—by wearing mourning clothes and acknowledging them as being both dead and revived. He next tells Adapa not to accept the food and drink in heaven if offered, warning Adapa that he will die if he eats or drinks from these sources. This turns

⁸¹ I talk about the relation of language and religion in Section 12.

⁸² It is interesting that the Cyclopes and Hecatoncheires; or in my view the archaic archetypes; keep getting imprisoned and released over and over again as the need arises. I think this points to the importance and inescapability of the archaic archetypes. They are part of human nature itself, and will always be important to us no matter how advanced we become.

⁸³ I am of course ignoring the Eastern Mythos. But even the Eastern religions have gravitated toward a singular primary god or force over time.

⁸⁴ In some interpretations Ea is taken to be Adapa's father, or direct creator.

out to be a lie. (Compare this to the lie that God tells Adam and Eve in Eden.) Finally, Ea tells Adapa to anoint himself in oil and heavenly garments after meeting Anu.

Adapa does what he is told. He flatters the doorkeepers and makes it to Anu. But Anu has a change of heart and is no longer angry at Adapa. He thinks it cruel that a being should possess intelligence without immortality. So he offers Adapa the *food and water of life*, which will make him immortal. In loyalty and trust to Ea, Adapa refuses the offer. This highly insults Anu. Anu allows Adapa to anoint himself with oil and heavenly garments; but condemns him and the rest of mankind to be forever mortal. Immortality always to be out of reach. (Also compare to the clothing event in *Genesis*. Adapa, like Adam and Eve, dress and pretend to be gods, even though they clearly are not; as immortality is stripped from them.)

There are a number of things to pull from the Adapa legend. Foremost, why did Ea intentionally sabotage Adapa to prevent him from becoming immortal? Was it because he knew having both intelligence and immortality would make Adapa a god? Was Ea protecting the gods' *sacred* divine status? But this doesn't necessarily make sense. Why would Ea give Adapa intelligence in the first place? And Anu seems to have no problem granting godhood to Adapa. Perhaps, instead, Ea was benevolent, knowing that immortality would be bad for Adapa and mankind. In this sense, he was protecting Adapa. There seems to be a theme, and we also see it in the Sumerian *Epic of Gilgamesh*; that immortality is not something intended for mankind, and we should give up its pursuit. That humans are better off mortal.

Something that stands out in the myths is that neither knowledge/intelligence nor immortality in themselves are taken to be bad in isolation. It is only in combination that they are bad. For instance, God is content with Adam and Eve eating from the Tree of Life and being immortal beings. It is only this immortality in combination with knowledge of good and evil, or intelligence, that He forbids. Likewise, Ea is content with Adapa having intelligence, even perfect intelligence. It is only intelligence in combination with immortality that he forbids. Perhaps there is something to this. Mortality and death (along with intelligence) are defining features of human existence. If we ever did consume the food and water of life, and achieve immortality—which is a real possibility with scientific advancement—we may lose out on what it means to be human. The world, and Nature, aren't ready for humans becoming gods. Such power may be the end of everything.

10. Sipping the Mead of Poetic Inspiration

The greatest of goods come to us through madness, provided it is bestowed by divine gift.

(Plato, *Phaedrus*)

Kvasir went up and down the earth to give instruction to men; and when he came upon invitation to the abode of certain dwarves, Fjalar and Galarr, they called him into privy converse with them, and killed him, letting his blood run into two vats and a kettle. The kettle is named Ódrerir, and the vats Són and Bodn; they blended honey with

the blood, and the outcome was that mead by the virtue of which he
 who drinks becomes a skald or scholar.
 (Snorri Sturluson, *Skáldskaparmál*)

In Norse mythology the Mead of Poetic Inspiration was said to grant godlike prowess in the Arts. It sometimes is described as being possessed by Odin—in which he temporarily gifts his poetic expertise to those who *call*. Drinking the Mead, in this tradition, is not to be taken lightly on account of it causing a crazed and frenzied state in those under its influence. Otherworldly inspiration can also be found in Greek mythology, as the gods help humans in their intellectual pursuits, most notably the Muses, who assist artists in the act of creating superb works. This is most profound in poetry in which it seems to most of all tap into a divine source. For example, Socrates, in his evaluation, held that poets compose poems, not from knowledge, but instead from *divine inspiration*, even *madness*.⁸⁵

Poetic madness, so to speak, is also found outside of the Nordic and Greek traditions and is well-documented in modernity. Usually in the contemporary context, claims of divine inspiration or poetic madness are typically treated as aspects of mental illness. There may well be a strong link. But I am concerned more with divine inspiration or poetic madness, if this is possible, that comes in waves, temporarily *inspiring* an individual to create superb works (rather than full-blown or permanent psychosis which hinders rather than helps the creative process and prevents one from being an artist in any practical sense). This type of inspiration need not come from God or gods or supernatural forces but rather involves tapping into the Unconscious, which has a *mystical* quality to it (and the emotional impact of art simply exploits the archetypes and ancestral memories, or more generally the Collective Unconscious).

The Poet and Poetry is the focus of this section because he/it is taken to be engulfed (emotionally) by the creative process; and because myths, which was discussed in the previous section, and will be hinted at throughout, are poetic in origin. Showing some bias, I ask whether the Philosopher does something similar to the Poet, and how we might exploit the same divine tap (stealing some Mead). Thus. Paying homage to the traditions of old I now call upon the Muses:

To the Muses, nine in number, the source of inspiration that the
 Artist draws from. *To whom we pay tribute*. Calliope show us your
 craft. Clio show us your craft. Euterpe show us your craft.
 Melpomene show us you craft. Terpsichore show us your craft.
 Erato show us your craft. Polymnia show us your craft. Urania show
 us your craft. Thalia show us your craft. Act as an intermediary to
 the frightful place where mortals dare not venture. Where Beauty is
 closely guarded. Take a small piece and give it to me.

Nothing. No sign. No Sister will sponsor a Philosopher. But am I
 not an artist like the rest? Not of words, or chords, or marble, or
 dance; But of ideas—An Idea Artist. Should not this be rewarded?

⁸⁵ See, in particular, *Phaedrus* 274b.

Let us not forget the Muses deal in memory and forgetfulness.
Philosophy came too late, and has no rhyme; let it cease and be
forgotten.

Lose one eye to Hear. Lose another to Feel. Madness will leave you
blind if you seek Truth over Verse.

This is the fee. To be paid for the crime of Knowing. That you're
only free to deal in beautiful fictions—if you repent.

So, the Poets are liars? Peddlers of emotion. The most ancient art.

"Yes," a soft voice answers.

Then the Philosopher must be a comedian. We must all agree. To do
our work, we must feed shit to flies.

"Such is art," a soft voice answers.

Such a thing would not be completely Despised. But there must be
more to the Poetic Art than this. Was it not a device for remembering
the wisdoms of Old? Answer comely Muse.

"Yes. But not for long, I'm afraid. There was a price. Emotion will
always find its way into Song, and set its own Tunes," a soft voice
answers.

Then Sing for me. It will soothe my *deep wounds*. Sing comely
Muse.

"Bold you are on Insisting. I must warn that you still seek the Truth,"
a soft voice answers.

Then tell me what is False. Tell me all that is wrong. I promise I will
do what I am told.

"Then you seek the Oracle. Not Me. There you will find riddles
disguised as Mysteries. I can only bring agony and despair. That is
who I am," a soft voice answers.

Do I care! I know you are an imposter—too prudish to be a god.

"Then why do you listen?" a soft voice answers.

Because I am an imposter too. I am no artist. I seek only to steal from Otherworldly Sources.

"In this there is great Wealth," a soft voice answers.

Then tell me something of Worth. Anything will suffice.

"I offer Nothing of value. You must steal from Yourself," a soft voice answers.

What even is there to take? From such a Shallow Mind.

"That is your answer," a soft voice answers.

Oh! I see my vice clearly now. There need not be harmony in rhyme. We need only to rip out the *pattern* from its ugly pomp.

Words lay dormant. There is no great answer. The philosopher is a butcher. What is your name? You must tell me!

"My name is Death," a soft voice answers.

I always knew. Have not shame. This is the beginning of Philosophy. To laugh at the absurd. To set ourselves on fire in order to rise from the ashes of doubt. To become a pitiful Bird of Prey. If only there were gods to listen!

—The Poet claims praise for this Mischief.

—The Philosopher views it as Theft.

11. Aesthetic Culture

Culture is, before all things, the unity of artistic style, in every expression of the life of a people.
(Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*)

The Absolute is the eternal becoming, and art is the moment where this becoming pauses to reveal itself.
(Friedrich Schelling, *The Ages of the World*)

Culture includes many things. The most basic is language. Without language whatever *culture* a people may have will remain extremely primitive and be at a high risk of disappearing every new generation. But once this functional component is present the floodgates open wide. We might take culture to be beliefs, values, rituals, behaviors, tools, music, dress, exhibits, cuisine, customs, theories, etiquette, norms, poetry, celebrations, laws, prayers, sacrifices. But we don't want to say every unique thing humans do is culture. (Though, culture could be described as modes of life.) Instead, I am after the *zeitgeist*, essence; the spirit of culture as it *thrives*. We don't simply live within a particular society; we absorb it, make it our own, integrate it into our identity as something greater. I follow the traditional model of categorizing cultural movements and/or manifestations into the three categories of Art, Religion, and Philosophy. I would also add Science to the list, and many would additionally add Politics. I will focus primarily on art or aesthetic culture and touch on scientific culture here. I do this because I will spend considerable space on religion and philosophy in the sections that follow. I ignore politics mainly because it draws no useful connections to my project. Though, I admit, many see politics as the most exciting of the categories mentioned. But I would have to disagree, seeing it as material in nature rather than a subject of spirit or mind.

What is aesthetic culture? Art in its most primitive is a combination of memory, or immediate sense experience, and feeling. This together forming an aesthetic experience. However, there seems to be something more in play, at least for very sophisticated types of art. One answer is that art entails capturing the universal in the concrete.⁸⁶ But this doesn't quite seem right, for true art as such. This would entail that art should concern itself with ideas. But I take it ideas are not the stuff of art. Though there does seem to be a type of dance between the universal and concrete happening when it comes to art. In fact, art seems to be both universal and concrete at the same time. Fortunately, in my flavor of philosophy, there is something we can point to that seems to delicately lie in the space between universality and concreteness: Archetypes. In some of the previous sections I suggested archetypes were providing poetic and artistic content. While not all art needs to be drawn from or concern archetypes, I take it archetypes are especially suited to be the stuff of art and aesthetic culture.

Firstly, archetypes are strongly emotion-laden. Because art in the usual sense will need to arouse emotions to function as such, as we typically take it, archetypes are particularly suited to the task. It is also the case that archetypes tend to be merged with its associative emotion(s), so it can create awe and sublimity in its effects as people unsuccessfully try to somehow separate the feeling from the universal pattern.⁸⁷ Archetypes are also present in all humans, so if we are to create a *zeitgeist* or aesthetic culture that is shared by all, this is an effective means to do so. For instance, the aesthetic sentiments of a single person or a few people would not be an aesthetic culture. A large portion of the population, or all of the population, must share the same aesthetic sentiments for it to constitute aesthetic culture. Archetypes are unique in that they allow for similar sentiments or even identical sentiments in a large number of people, uniting the culture and creating a reliable reference point in drawing a shared aesthetic or meaningful cultural experience.

⁸⁶ Rand holds this view in her *The Romantic Manifesto*.

⁸⁷ Refer back to Section 4 regarding archetypes and their associative emotions.

An additional reason in favor of the archetypal interpretation of aesthetic culture is that archetypes have familiar historical properties. Everyone, for instance, has reverence towards the Mother archetype on account of it being part of our history as far back as anyone can remember or might be recorded. There is a warm feeling towards it because it has always been there with us. It likely also made an early appearance in our childhood fables, mythology, stories, etc., leading to a special type of nostalgia as we come to age.

But there do seem to be unique types of culture, or aesthetic culture, that must be actively maintained and defended against deterioration and infiltration. I will take this unique cultural brand, as opposed to the general or universal aesthetic, to be what's captured by the *zeitgeist* or spirit of the times. I take this to be what Nietzsche means by a culture's "artistic style." And in this sense the *zeitgeist* takes on greater meaning and elevates individuals more so than can be explained by the collection of historical archetypes alone. What is going on? Defenders of something like a dynamic Absolute—a philosophical term of art ?—take cultural change to result from a rational process.⁸⁸ But I take it, while it does follow an evolutionary process, there is nothing rational about it at all. If I might temporally run with the term, the Absolutes are in fact archetypes, not glorified ideas, or any of the other odd things the later German idealists might call it. But these Absolutes are not the same universally established archetypes we have been talking about thus far. I take it they are more like proto-archetypes, that have yet to be permanently ingrained in the human brain.

Given a very long period of time, if a culture remained static, and the same cultural patterns continued to repeat, these proto-archetypes would eventually become permanent archetypes. But ever since we started talking and improving our societies they've been in flux, and moving fast. Though they do occasionally pause, long enough for us to notice, as Schelling points out, and this might be what a particular Age is if we're able to see it as we live through it. This may sound base, but in our current historical circumstances trying to maintain or preserve a particular culture is a fool's errand. Evolutionary ingrainment just takes far too long. But it is the aspiration of the prototypes or Absolutes to achieve permanent status. And perhaps that is what the end of history is, just things staying stable long enough for proto-archetypes to become permanent archetypes.

All that being said, people tend to vehemently defend their unique culture and try to maintain it. Because archetypes do in fact have causal powers, there is likely impetus for archetypes to influence behavior in a way to ensure their own preservation. If this wasn't the case the archetypes wouldn't have come to exist in the first place. And as I pointed out earlier, the old archetypes still exert a strong influence on our lives. It is no different for the proto-archetypes. It is just that competition is much more fierce because there are more of them and they have much more to lose—in most cases extinction. They also are not maintained naturally but need to be preserved with force, through tradition, education, laws, cultural preservation programs, and so on. Thus proto-archetypes, and hence culture, is a fragile thing.

In many cases, culture is maintained through momentum. People prefer to hang on to the past, or what was passed down to them. But aesthetic culture, if we are to distinguish it from culture simpliciter, is a little different. In a sea of proto-archetypes to draw from, there is a choice that might be made, to select for cultural features that are the most beautiful or inspiring or useful. There are cultural movements that seek to escape the past rather than preserve it. Try something

⁸⁸ For instance, see G.W.F. Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit*.

new, if you will. This is a grand feat because it gives us a chance to see, feel, know something novel and distinguish ourselves from the past and make new history. And novelty is something that tends to get remembered and studied. I will not go into the role that unique people, places, events, play in the flux of cultural change. These things do matter. But I'll leave it at that. Though I hope this is a satisfactory explanation of aesthetic culture and the zeitgeist.

We can now move on to scientific culture. This is a much simpler undertaking. Scientific culture *does* involve ideas. Scientific culture also moves, but in principle is much more stable, or at least there is much more hope in it reaching equilibrium. It *seems* to be very dynamic, but this may just be because we happen to live in a particularly disruptive scientific age. Let's not forget that many of Aristotle's scientific theories were accepted and remained unchanged for a thousand years. This is a philosophical rather than a scientific or historical essay so I will not go into any detail here about the nature of science itself, or its practice, or its relation to technology. Though I will treat technology as a type of artifact and respond to some of its dangers later; as well as look at science's relation to philosophy. But let us limit ourselves to scientific culture. I take scientific culture to be very broad, and hold that it need not be limited to theories produced by a/the scientific method. Rather, scientific culture captures any abstract idea that says something about the external world. When there is consensus by most, or all people, about some world-explaining idea, which we could then call a theory or law if sufficiently complex, that is the scientific culture of that age. For example, the scientific culture of the current age, for most places, contains the ideas of a plate tectonics, a heliocentric orbit, and Darwinian natural selection. None of this was maintained in previous scientific ages. Of course, not everyone believes this, and hence would be part of a different scientific culture. For instance, a geocentric orbit, or intelligent design to account for species complexity.

One issue is that reasonably intelligent people, including scientists, might mix competing frameworks. For instance, they may accept a heliocentric orbit along with intelligent design. In determining what the prevailing scientific culture of the age should be it gets tricky, but we might point to the theory that is more forcefully defended and maintained as representing it. For instance, Einstein's theory of relativity is more staunchly defended than intelligent design. But not long ago, Einstein's theory was argued against due to its peculiarity. I will neither make nor require that a position of truth be maintained as far as scientific culture goes; on account of it being treated as a feature of culture. But there are, like aesthetic movements, scientific movements that fight resistance. The impetus is not beauty or inspiration but rather whether or not the theory fits empirical observation. When the empirical evidence is overwhelming or compelling it might provide enough momentum to drive a scientific movement or even start a new scientific age. But I will again ignore the role of unique people, and places, and events in this process. These being important catalysts.

I want to return to a problem that I mentioned. What if some, or even most people, even in the same greater culture, accept competing or contradictory scientific theories? How do we determine what the scientific culture should be? In fact, because we live in such a volatile time, there is really no reason why a person needs to commit to one scientific theory over another. There likely will be entirely new options that will present themselves in the not-so-distant future. One way to unite us in an intellectualized, rather than aestheticized, culture is to rely on a non-epistemic standard. Interestingly, false ideas and theories, if consistent, can be instantiated in the mind just

as easily as true ones. For instance, there is no crime in instantiating Aristotle's theory of essentialism or Lamarckian acquired characteristics in the mind, and even understanding such theories, as opposed to Darwinian natural selection. You need not consent to such theories. But then again you need not consent to true theories either. And this is why the extreme skeptic isn't necessarily a lunatic. Actually, you would be doing yourself a great disservice if you were unaware of Aristotle and Lamarck.

We might then extend this to include a very large number of ideas or theories. If we make this adjustment, we can avoid the contradictions mentioned regarding scientific culture. Thus, in a sense, we might point to a more general kind of culture, an *idea culture*, which I would call the Collective Conscious. This would include all ideas, true or false, instantiated by most or all humans which they are conscious of. Because all ideas are the same, there will be an identical collection of ideas shared and instantiated at the same time, i.e., by the human species. Because both true and false ideas can be instantiated, this collection would tend to grow larger over time and become more complex. Of course, unlike the Collective Unconscious and archetypes, the Collective Conscious is not a permanent feature of the brain, and is fickle. For instance, if a dark age were to occur there would likely be a regression in the total content of the Collective Conscious. So, while the cultural trajectory points toward continuous growth, it is not guaranteed.

In ending with something uplifting, the Collective Conscious is likely the reason humans were able to conquer the planet and advance as quickly as we did. Mass coordination on the scale we've seen would not have been possible without it, whether it be socially or technologically. And the fast trail of history gives credence to this fact. Interestingly, and contrarily, the Collective Unconscious actually tends to favor and promote stagnation. And that is likely why we were stuck for a long time until consciousness and language were achieved. An interesting question is whether there is also another Collective-something emerging with the proto-archetypes. Maybe so? Though it would be much less stable than both the Collective Unconscious and the Collective Conscious.

12. *Faithful Servants*

The causes of religious belief are so obvious, that they must perpetually operate on mankind; and though the particular forms of superstition may change, the general principles must remain nearly the same in all ages.

(David Hume, *The Natural History of Religion*)

The essence of religion is the projection of human consciousness into an external divine being.

(Ludwig Feuerbach, *The Essence of Christianity*)

Religion is a powerful force. It is ubiquitous to every society and plays a pivotal role in the lives of most humans. Yet it is elusive. When I say religion is elusive, I mean its underpinnings are elusive. Not its effects. We are very familiar with religion as a cultural phenomenon, and the many

explanations, rewards, and social functions it provides. But I take it religion is more than a cultural phenomenon. It is unbounded.

Before jumping in, I should tidy up my general theory. To start, I take it the Godhead, or the primitive idea of God, was already there long before there was religion; manifesting in the mind at least since the beginning of consciousness. But God, in my opinion, was never quite able to exert his full power through the archetypes. One reason being that God resides in the Conscious and the Archetypes reside in the Unconscious. Another, that God, being an idea, is non-physical; and the Archetypes, being memories, are physical. Though they do interact. I have been freely using the terms Conscious and Unconscious throughout. So I should at this point clear up what they mean. I take the Conscious to include all aspects of consciousness in the mind along with the primitive ideas. And I take the Unconscious to include all unconscious content in the mind along with the archetypes. Importantly, both the Conscious and Unconscious have their own causal powers. With this in mind, we might surmise a *first genesis*.

I speculate the original objects of worship were archetypes, in the sense that I've been arguing. This was pre-linguistic. Though it would be unwarranted to call mere archetype worship religion, at least not the early stages of it. But something like *religiousness* does form, in my view, when simple words (names) get attached to archetypes. I talked about this process earlier with my discussion of words.⁸⁹ I take name-archetype worship to be the likely progenitor to animism and some of the other primitive hunter-gather religious models.⁹⁰ Names have power. Names allow us to talk about people/places/things that aren't present. They allow us to fabricate people/places/things that don't exist. And they allow us to project. Largely, it provides a means to publicly (and privately) personify the natural world: giving it a soul. In this sense, I believe, names are what provided the original *soul-stuff* which elevated natural reverence in the first believers to the status of faith.

But, and maybe to some criticism, this still doesn't constitute a proper religion. Religion requires sophisticated language and a rich oral tradition to be viable.⁹¹ Importantly, an oral tradition allows for a mythology. I take mythology to be a defining feature of religion. Without a mythology, religions are susceptible to dissolution and corruption over time. I looked at several myths in the previous sections. And what stands out is that myths attempt to offer an explanation. They offer a justification for why the world is the way that it is or why certain things are the way they are. In this sense, religions that make use of myths possess a modicum of rationality. And I take it this added rational aspect greatly contributes to a religion's survivability and success. Although, we might also point to its practical benefits in this regard.

As mythologies became more complex it was possible for animism and the other primitive hunter-gather religions to evolve into polytheism, in the typical sense. Though I am ignoring the details of what was likely a complicated and long process. There are also additional factors that contributed to this shift, like the development of agriculture and transitioning to urban centers. But I still hold polytheism would not have been possible without an already existing complex

⁸⁹ See Section 7.

⁹⁰ Animism is the belief that all living things have a soul, including nature itself, in some cases also taking non-living things to have a soul as well. Some other primitive hunter-gatherer religious models are totemism, shamanism, and ancestor worship.

⁹¹ Having a written tradition as well strengthens religion further.

mythology. Though which caused which can be debated. After this important shift, I take it, is when God Himself, rather than nature, is really allowed to shine. The reason is this. If instead of embracing the millions of spirits of nature we limit ourselves to a dozen or even a few hundred gods, we can say a lot about them. We can give them spectacular personalities and backstories and place them in crucial roles throughout our mythology. They are interesting and cause us to think about them frequently. (Which of course is God's goal. To occupy our consciousness) The animist hunter-gatherer may have revered the soul of the deer he killed, but likely wasn't completely enthralled by it. Interesting gods make for long-lasting and powerful gods.

Enthrallment is paramount, and is God's means of propagation and sustainment. There are various ways to do this. Mythology is one means, aided by a rational principle. Another means is the manipulation of emotion. Surprisingly, God became a master at this, even though He, being an idea, is emotionless. Language is the key. The right language can create mental images in the mind capable of evoking emotions. Odin, for instance, is not just some bland celestial. He is the god of wisdom, war, sorcery, and the dead. He is one-eyed—his other sacrificed to Mimir for knowledge. He has a never-missing spear named Gungnir and a pair of ravens named Huginn and Muninn that scout the world and bring news to him. He invented the Runes and can see into the future. This mental image we *now* hold in our mind is intoxicating. We admire Odin, and respect him, and like him, and fear him—in direct response to the verbal description. Even something as simple as this, we must concede, overshines any of the archetypes. But nature rarely gives up anything useful. God has an additional trick. Words and language can be used to combine archetypes with ideas. We can also make Odin the Father, and even the Wise Old Man. We just need to use the right words to hijack these archetypes. This creates an emotional powerhouse capable of overriding our outdated circuitry.

If only this was enough. Unfortunately, God is a maximizer. In the course of religion's development, God will also make use of artifacts like statues, monuments, talismans, shrines, home altars, prayers, holy books, and sacraments to enthrall us. Where each time we encounter such religious artifacts the idea of God is likely to be triggered in the mind. He will also conscript priests and prophets to proselytize—and push mythologies, tenets, and rituals on us.⁹² (Where listening to selected stories/and tenets and participating in rituals can reinforce the idea of God.) In some cases, He will reorganize entire societies to make worship and the pious life its primary focus. He will also use Lies and make threats against non-believers (i.e., damnation after death, karma, bad luck, getting struck by lightning). With all this in play, God can be on the minds of His faithful servants almost all the time. The standard of success!

With that said, I want to take a moment to talk about the nature of God. Feuerbach says that God is simply a projection of human consciousness. In some sense this is true. God is tied to consciousness. But I should make some important distinctions. While religion is man-made, God is not. God, while attached to consciousness, is an independent entity. I would not go as far as to say God is a person. But God is an Agent, with preferences, intentions, goals; and things can go better or worse for Him. Though to be clear, whatever prudence or cunning God has is parasitic on the psychological profile of whatever human subject He inhabits. This can make God quite

⁹² With the rise of literacy, personally reading a holy book or scripture will also reinforce the idea of God in the mind.

complex, but we should be aware that it is only a by-product of a process pursuing the much simpler directive of maximal sustainment and propagation.

It is also important to be clear that God is the real benefactee of religion. Not humans. Any benefit humans receive from religion is indirect. And humanity could have achieved that same benefit even if God was simply a mere projection as Feuerbach claims. So we do not need God. But He needs us. This leads us to ask what God Himself actually provides or adds to religion? It's not exactly clear. God is like the Stone in the Stone Soup Fable.⁹³ He is the cause for why many religions are beautiful and filled with such wonderful cultural ingredients. But we do all the work and add all the ingredients. If God ate the delicious "soup" it would be fitting. But it's far worse. God instead eats our consciousness, and the soup (religion) is the way He makes it into our brains. I'll go into more detail about the Godhead later.⁹⁴ But at this point I just want to signal to the religious shopper: Buyer Beware!

Let us return to religion itself. Hume claims that all religions have the same structure and function: mainly, to provide psychological comfort, remove fear of the unknown, and alleviate anxiety about the future. While I take this to be true, Hume does acknowledge that there are some important differences between types of religions, particularly between polytheism and monotheism. He additionally holds that monotheism is the more developed of the two.⁹⁵ (Hume also acknowledges primitive religions like animism and totemism, but includes them under the umbrella of polytheism.) The most essential difference between polytheism and monotheism is that, in polytheism the gods are not the creators or cause of nature, merely its stewards. They also make mistakes in carrying out their duties and come into conflict with one another. This usually isn't the case in monotheism. In (developed) monotheisms, God is in some way above nature or its cause. This can change the character of how God is revered and worshipped.

I take the above to be the defining difference between polytheism and monotheism. Though there are a number of other notable differences.⁹⁶ But before talking about monotheism, it is worth pointing to what monotheism is not, or that which I take to be a primitive monotheism. Historically, it was not uncommon for a society to adopt a main god or give one god more importance over others (such as a father or king of a pantheon). It would also sometimes be the case that some older insignificant God from a pantheon or from nature would increase his status over time and be adopted as the local god of some ethnic group—eventually becoming the sole god of that group.⁹⁷

⁹³ In the Stone Soup Fable, a hungry traveler arrives in a village with only a stone in his possession. He asks for help, but no one will feed him or offer him any food. In desperation, he announces that the stone he possesses has special properties or powers and that it is the prime ingredient needed in a recipe for a particularly delicious type of soup: stone soup. As he starts boiling the stone, several villagers inquire into what he is doing. He then repeats that the stone is special. Out of curiosity the villagers ask if they might try the stone soup when it is done. The traveler agrees, but suggests the soup will taste even better with the addition of some simple ingredients. The villagers being even more enticed, eagerly bring the ingredients to the traveler. This then gets the attention of the whole village, who offer a huge range and supply of ingredients to add to the soup, producing a complex and rich soup in the process. When the soup is finished, the villagers praise how tasty the soup is, attributing it to the special stone, rather than to their own offerings and effort.

⁹⁴ See Section 15.

⁹⁵ See *The Natural History of Religion* in general.

⁹⁶ See *The Natural History of Religion*, in particular Sections 5; 8-9, for an extensive list.

⁹⁷ For example, take what happened with the original Abramic religion. But it's important to point out that God gets completely reworked in this case.

Some god may also be made generic enough—an every-god—to have more appeal to diverse groups of people.⁹⁸ A god may also be made the primary god or sole god for only a short period of time before returning to a pantheon or becoming insignificant.⁹⁹ I take none of these cases to be monotheism, in its substantial form. I hold this to be the case, even if one of the gods in question absorb all of the powers of the other gods as well as control over all their domains. In my opinion, this is just polytheism cleaned up and with less gods (in this case one).¹⁰⁰ While there may be less gods, there isn't a significant leap capable of capturing monotheism as we would typically understand it. Instead, I take it, monotheism, in the substantial sense, requires us to create God by means of a rational process. God must be completely disjointed from polytheism and reimagined rather than evolve from it.¹⁰¹ Below is one method for deriving a monotheistic god independent of a polytheistic origin. (I am also ignoring the historical genesis of the three current major monotheistic religions; mainly, Judaism, Christianity, and Islam.)

In my view, for monotheism to develop, a non-derivative artificiality must be introduced into religion, changing God's perceived nature. To maintain a substantial monotheistic god is a huge undertaking. It is a rational project, not simply a matter of faith. To construct a monotheistic god, we first must tackle the fact that God alone is ultimately the creator or cause of *all* of nature. This is much harder to account for than responsibility over some small domain (as was the case with polytheism). To adequately explain God's dominion, we are then forced to account for Nature itself. In doing so, we discover that there is an inherent orderliness in nature.¹⁰² This forces us to also conceive God as orderly, or rational, rather than capricious—if He is the creator or cause of nature. (Of course, we could challenge this assumption. Though it would be odd to say that an irrational god could/or would create an orderly nature.) But by making this adjustment, we impose an intellectual standard on God. We place God within a logical configuration with nature or at least place limits on His ability or willingness to stop the *flow* of nature's orderliness.¹⁰³

The next adjustment has to do with God's Oneness. To maintain Oneness, we must abandon the concept of God as an infinite entity with many forms (as is the case with polytheism).¹⁰⁴ But this requires us to explain why God in fact would/could not appear in many or every form. The only fix, capable of preserving God's greatness, is to make God simply Infinite—eventually,

⁹⁸ The Roman Pantheon tried to do something like this by combining all the gods into a single point or object of worship, or generic veneration of all deities.

⁹⁹ An interesting historical example is the rise of Atenism in Egypt during the 14th century B.C. A relatively insignificant sun god or aspect of the sun, Aten, was elevated to become the sole and only god in Egypt—the worship of all other gods being forbidden. But this monotheism didn't last very long, rapidly disappearing after the reign of the pharaoh Akhenaten and his immediate successors. By the 13th century B.C., the pantheon and polytheism was fully restored in Egypt.

¹⁰⁰ Though technically having only one god would make a religion monotheistic. But I'm arguing that monotheism, in the substantial sense, involves more than simply having one god.

¹⁰¹ This of course deviates from Hume's view in *The Natural History of Religion* where he holds monotheism will evolve naturally from polytheism.

¹⁰² The orderliness of nature is a philosophical and scientific concept that holds that nature is lawlike and structured in a consistent or rational way; in some stronger interpretations, nature even being entirely deterministic and predictable if given complete knowledge of the past.

¹⁰³ Worth pointing out that miracles would disrupt the flow of orderliness. But this would not necessarily count against the general orderliness of nature if miracles were rare, and an exception rather than the rule.

¹⁰⁴ Though the Christian Trinity puts this to the test.

perfect. But in doing so, God becomes more abstract and essentially paralyzed, unable to act. Largely, why would a singular perfect entity ever want to change? But such a god would not be desirable for human beings. So, we must make a final intellectual adjustment, that firmly asserts that God is good and benevolent, and maximally so. Otherwise, we wind up with mere pantheism or deism¹⁰⁵, which I do not take to be a substantial monotheism. The rational project coming to completion.¹⁰⁶

The above model represents a substantial monotheism and is adequately rational. This rational component, in principle, gives it greater appeal and survivability. But its success also makes it vulnerable in certain ways (e.g., compared to polytheism). One vulnerability is that a mythology is not needed for it to work. It is self-sustaining. But believers might find such a religion less fulfilling without the emotional and psychological benefits of a mythology. (Though, I should point out, all of our current monotheistic religions do possess mythologies. But these mythologies don't play a pivotal role in these religions and are in many ways superfluous.) Another vulnerability with the model is that God appears undeveloped and abstract. While in some ways this is a virtue, lowering the possibility that God will contradict Himself—or call into question His power or goodness—it makes Him less interesting and captivating.

A third vulnerability is that the rational and intellectualist foundation of a substantial monotheism requires greater justification and understanding for religious beliefs. I.e., In what sense is God dependent on nature, or independent of nature? Why is God not Non-One? Or the classic: Why does God, who is benevolent (and powerful) allow evil in the world? This can lead to frustration and doubt, increasing crises in faith—more so than in polytheism or non-substantial versions of monotheism. The question then to ask—for believers—is whether fideistic vulnerability is a price worth paying in order to maintain an intellectualized theism?

Finally, I must point out that the model I have illustrated says nothing about the true nature of God Himself. Rather, it simply gives a rational structure of monotheistic religion *in general* centered around the worship of one sole god, rather than multiple gods. The model can also be differentiated from worship of the beings/objects of nature—as is the case in animism and some of the other primitive hunter-gatherer religions. I also acknowledge that monotheism, in itself, need not be rational and can for the most part be based on pretty much anything as a simple matter of faith.¹⁰⁷ But such religions would lack justification, appeal, and survivability as was the case with primitive monotheistic religions that have come and gone.

That's my religious exposition. But it wasn't all for naught. I hold pushing monotheism to its limit will ultimately lead to philosophy. That is, the next monistic project after removing mythology and embodiment from religion would be to remove the deity; and attempt to explain the *Rational Principle* that orders nature itself. That is where philosophy takes off, and will be where the next section begins. Interestingly though, in my view, philosophy sprouts from an attempt to perfect religion. And I take this to be the reason philosophy still carries much religious baggage, as well as the unconscious desire to actually complete the goal in question.

¹⁰⁵ Pantheism, roughly, is the idea that God is nature itself. Deism is the idea that God is inactive or indifferent to nature or human affairs.

¹⁰⁶ The rational project I am describing did not happen all at once, but developed over centuries. But in my opinion, this is the progression it took.

¹⁰⁷ The Flying Spaghetti Monster (monotheistic) deity being a humorous example.

13. Rational Animals

Philosophy is to have conversation with the divine.
(Plato, *Republic*)

There is something divine in each of us.
(Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*)

Philosophy is Born. The birth of philosophy brought a new system. A system where lone sages, to be called philosophers, would challenge tradition and authority; and decide for themselves what was reasonable and possible. It was a way of thinking that was both critical and bold—where nothing was safe from examination. The philosophical tradition really starts with Thales, who claimed that the world was ultimately made of *water*.¹⁰⁸ Though ridiculous it may sound, it was a revolution in how we analyze reality. Unfortunately, much of what Thales said was lost in time, including a lot of rich philosophical activity to spur during the century or two that followed.¹⁰⁹ So, we must rely on a later point of historical inception coming from Socrates and the tradition that followed him, where the most direct line passes to Plato and Aristotle. The Revolution was in essence, a shunning of social convention and cherished preconceptions; a questioning of the poets and historians and experts and culture keepers; A sharp turn away from mythology, gods, dogma, religion, epics, folkways, emotion; and I would also say archetypes; toward a system based solely on rationality and ideas. It was, in effect, an awakening of Reason.

But what exactly is Reason? This is a lot harder to answer than it seems. I said Reason was the primary instrument of ideas for interacting with the world and the human organism. It is also commonly taken to be the source of will and volition, as well as a means to make fine decisions. For Plato and Aristotle, Reason is treated as divine. Though I would say Reason is only divine in the sense that it deals with ideas, which are in some ways themselves divine in nature, or at least exotic in their non-physicality. But I would like to simplify Reason, at least in the practical sense. I take Reason to be all of your ideas focused into a single point of consciousness. We might take this to encompass *your* Idea, or your own peculiar configuration of rationality. Although, to be clear, this is not the same as your Self or personality.

Your Idea, guided by Reason, at least if you listen to most philosophers, is the best or *higher* part of your nature. But there is also a *lower* (though I would say different) non-rational nature which involves impulses, desires, emotions, and the human body as a whole—that is your animal essence. (I take the neater demarcation to be between the Mind and the human organism. But this will be argued for later.) There is much debate over how the different parts should relate to one another. Plato takes the appropriate relation to be similar to a rider and his horse. Your idea, or rational part, seeks to tame the non-rational part to do what it commands. Though this might be

¹⁰⁸ Thales' view was a little bit more complex than this. But what's important to take away is that he offers a non-theistic monistic explanation of the orderliness of nature.

¹⁰⁹ For a good accessible source of some of the fragments of the pre-Socratic philosophers see Richard McKirahan's *Philosophy Before Socrates*.

too generous to Plato. A rider usually cares at least some about his horse. But if you read Plato's *Letters* it's very clear that his conception of the relationship is meant to be parasitic and hostile. The body is a mere vessel, at best a slave to be used and subdued.

Aristotle offers a much kinder model. For Aristotle, the rational part is more like a steward or mentor. It is not there to rule or tame the non-rational part of the human organism but rather to guide it toward what is best. The emotions, for instance, are able to listen to the rational part.¹¹⁰ In this sense, the relationship is mutualistic, considering the rational part also seeks what is best. Though I think there is something deeper than mutualism that is achievable. I believe it is also possible to possess the Good contained within one's rationality or Idea. While ideas, and Reason, lack emotion; in my view; the Good has an aesthetic feature that appreciates and values the non-rational part, even some semblance of *weak feeling* that can care for it.¹¹¹ This is a fluke of nature, and not all people will possess the Good within their Idea or rational faculty.

One important application of Reason, as an excellence, is *phronesis*, or practical wisdom. This usually is taken to involve fine decision-making as well as emotional soundness. This dual requirement can be summed up in the famous line in the *Nicomachean Ethics*: "Virtue makes the goal right, practical wisdom the things leading to it" (1144a7-8). But this line, famous as it may be, might not be very important. I'm always surprised by how very few virtues Aristotle lists, usually only around ten or fifteen. The truth is there are likely hundreds of virtues. In embracing virtues there need not be some crown of wisdom to decorate. Most of what's needed to get along are useful rules of thumb. The doctrine of the mean, for instance, need not be so profound, much less the definition of virtue itself.¹¹² It is a good general rule of thumb that we should avoid getting caught up in emotional extremes. But this need not just be advice for emotions. Pursuing any extreme in most matters of life tends to be a bad idea. Where virtue really shines is in its beauty. It's a spectacle to witness. But then again, maybe no more so than watching a great athlete or great sculptor at work; unless we want to elevate virtue in status just for the mere sake of doing so. I don't want to get caught up in normativity or a discussion of the authority of morality. I only have a single ethical rule in my system,¹¹³ so there is no reason for me to enter the moral debate. Nor do I want to defame the Great Aristotle in any way or his noble virtue project. Virtue is a great thing, and admirable, and good, and likely necessary to be happy in most cases. But I will add one caveat. Virtue can get you killed. A single act of dishonor to save your own life, or avoid some great misfortune, may not be the worst thing in the world, if you can forgive yourself.

A major insight of the Aristotelian virtue project is the realization that emotions are something that can be worked with. They are not merely things that must be suppressed or overcome as necessary. As was said, emotions can/do listen to Reason. But it is important to point out that the real work, as Aristotle acknowledges in many places, is being done by Habit. Emotions listen to Reason. But they listen to habit even better. Habit, to be clear, is a type of memory, and

¹¹⁰ See *Nicomachean Ethics* 1102b13-1103a3.

¹¹¹ My conception of the Good is different from Plato's or Aristotle's for instance. For Plato the Good of a thing is its perfect form. For Aristotle, a thing's good is the telos or end it strives for. But I should point out aesthetics and the beautiful is mixed into both Plato's and Aristotle's theories.

¹¹² Aristotle defines virtue through the doctrine of the mean roughly that a moral virtue is a mean state of character, between an excess and a deficiency, determined (decided) by Reason (*Nicomachean Ethics* 1106b36-1107a6).

¹¹³ See Section 20 for this rule.

therefore (in my theory) has the power to influence behavior and affect emotions. But in habitual action there doesn't seem to be very much planning or reflection or examining of mental images, for that matter, involved. There doesn't seem to be much of anything besides the pure action itself. It is automatic and smooth. The explanation here is that memories and mental images are still involved, and guiding behavior and emotions; it just happens to be unconscious memories and unconscious mental images doing the job.

But while habit does most of the grunt work, Reason is still king, or council if we want to stick to the softer description. It does need to occasionally step in and override habit, in order to respond to unique or pressing cases, that may require a little more flexibility and adaptiveness. For instance, if you're having trouble rousing the spirit to care about your neighbor's wretched condition due to unforeseen bad luck, you may need to imagine that fate on yourself in the mind, or even push the scenario to an imagined extreme like your neighbor and his whole family dying due to inactivity; to increase your anger and bring it up to par in order to motivate you to act. Reason tends to get it right, but it is entirely emotionless. To aid it you must provide the emotions yourself; even if this involves fabricating false mental images. Luckily, Reason contains a creative aspect and can generally provide the requisite mental images to bring about its goals if you try. Though, this involves the interaction of Reason, ideas, and memories whose mechanism is somewhat unexplained by my view. But I take it we can all do this, and interaction can/does occur.

Next, there is the temptation to overgeneralize practical wisdom to encompass every type of good decision-making. But this stretching out of *phronesis*, at least in the correct use of the term, may be using it improperly. In most cases of good decision-making you can just look to your typical expert or body of knowledge for guidance. There is no need for a moral expert. You don't need a virtuous agent, or *phronesis*, to tell you how to plan a vacation, or make a bunch of money, or fix your roof. A travel agent, or financial advisor, or roofer will do just fine. There is instead a specific context of practical wisdom which I take to involve virtues and happiness. Though these two things are unsurmountable. And this may tell you that you don't need the vacation, or extorting people is a bad way to make money, or fixing your roof is less urgent than attending your kid's soccer match. And in an important sense this is what philosophy is about.

Finally, we might ask what the end of human Reason should be? Most simply, in special regard to *phronesis*, it is to bring about one's own happiness with the help of virtue. But there is also a higher goal for human beings, in particular philosophers: knowledge or contemplation. This is the topic of the next section.

14. Nous

All men naturally desire knowledge.
(Aristotle, *Metaphysics*)

Aristotle opens his *Metaphysics* by pointing to the importance of knowledge. When doing philosophy this does seem to be most of all what we're caught up with or after. But it is not just any knowledge that philosophers care about, but rather *deep* knowledge or understanding. This can be referred to as *nous*. And this is what's really behind the call of philosophy. Its standard of

propagation (of ideas) is clarity. Clarity is an aspect of understanding; understanding being something I'll go into. Mainly, an idea you understand is more likely to be remembered and consciously reflected on. An idea you understand is also much easier to explain and communicate to others. Understanding tends to beget more understanding, so to speak. If I had to be more precise, clarity in addition also makes people feel good or happier. In fact, people who have experienced great clarity might even describe it as a higher grade of happiness. I don't want to make any commitments here regarding happiness. Wisdom and contemplation would still be good in themselves and likely pursued even if no good feeling or happiness was present. So, for our purposes let's leave happiness in the domain of *phronesis*, or practical wisdom. In setting up the argument, we should start with wisdom as it is typically defined or used.

Usually when talking about knowledge and wisdom we seem to take it to involve predictive power or the ability to draw useful generalizations. The proclamation goes that a man becomes wise through experience. He has learned that dark clouds will lead to rain, and plans accordingly. But I have something different in mind when referring to wisdom. It might not require experience at all. In fact, it is possible to be wise, yet a practical fool. For instance, the very wise Thales, our first philosopher with the name, is fabled to have died because he fell into a well due to gazing at the stars rather than paying attention to where he was going. Any reasonable person would know that reckless walking leads to injury. The slave that mocked Thales' comical end after witnessing it, was just as capable if not more so than Thales at drawing generalizations based on experience, even sound causal explanations and associations, such as reckless walking leads to injury on account of vision being impaired and out of sync with the body; Or even broad generalizations such as all reckless behavior leads to injury. But, while useful, this is not what wisdom is in the proper or more elevated sense. Wisdom, or theoretical wisdom, I take it, instead is *excellence at finding relations between ideas*. Though this is more difficult than it seems or to do correctly. Something above ideas is required, which we typically call understanding. But before moving to understanding some quick words are in order about my chosen standard.

Knowing the "mere" relations of ideas, is sometimes belittled by philosophers. Some of the greatest philosophers in history being earnest hecklers. The very usual example is Bachelors are Unmarried Men. Big whoop they say. I beg to differ. This statement tells me exactly what a bachelor is. I can truly say I understand bachelorness, and have no room for doubt. But it's uninteresting the Great Philosopher goes on. Again, I would have to disagree. I can imagine a world where almost every man is married. In such a world a bachelor would be unusual and interesting. I may eagerly wonder why he is unmarried or chooses to be unmarried. If I search further, I may then wonder what a man is, or a human for that matter. I may then wonder what it means to be married, and why there should be some connection between being a man and being married—or not being married. It will then require me to conclude that some other person is necessary for marriage to occur. I.e., you can't marry yourself. When I take it even further and find the meaning of 'maleness' and 'marriedness', as well as their underlying programs and subroutines involved, I actually wind up with something epistemically satisfying. So, I would contend even very simple relations of ideas are worthy of contemplation, and even more so important relations and those that build the nexi of and allow for the understanding of many other relations and relations of relations.

Understanding I admit is hard to understand. What I will say is that Reason makes understanding possible, and that it will involve a type of intentional conscious inner volition that *searches*. Somehow it can find real relations between ideas or establish which ideas or further relations of ideas serve as the foundation(s) for others. When this is done well and relations are found or certain ideas are established as more necessary or foundational than others, we have nous or nous ideas. This encompasses wisdom and could be taken to be a special or particularly valuable kind of knowledge. But, interestingly, I should point out, neither justification nor truth nor belief need be required for nous. This of course rejects the typical definition of knowledge as justified true belief. Though I admit justification, and truth, and belief may be required for knowledge simpliciter. But I don't take it nous, as something above or better than knowledge, needs to strictly fit these parameters. It gets a pass. For example, I've spent a considerable portion of my life thinking about Aristotle's hylomorphism.¹¹⁴ And I do take myself to understand it quite well, as much as a person, or philosopher, can. But I definitely don't believe it, nor think it's true; and there is no substantial justification for it at all. But if given the choice, there is really nothing one could trade me in exchange for this flawed abstraction. In all seriousness I would turn down the full range of all knowledge in history or economics or geology in order to preserve Aristotle's most peculiar falsehood in my mind. Mainly because it is nous, and nous has immeasurable or absolute value. Though maybe not all nous needs to be this grand or beyond negotiation.

But to be clear, nous isn't faith or valuable simply because you cherish it. It must allow you to establish relations between other important ideas or be foundational to those ideas. So if there is some standard we might apply it would be necessity. Necessity is something that is independent of our beliefs. In the mind at least, certain ideas are either necessary for or relate to other ideas or they do not. You cannot force necessity. And this is the primary tool of the theoretical philosopher in engaging the very esoteric and bewildering task of contemplation. Fortuitously for these nous-chasers the further and more abstract one goes into the mind the more necessary ideas become. And in this sense more foundational ideas have greater epistemic-potency. Though some unifying concept(s) or understanding that explains how many surface level ideas work together is valuable as well. But there is a historical bias in contemplative philosophy. The more foundational ideas have more value and are more likely to be nous. First principles have and will likely always be more highly prized, at least as long as philosophers rooted in the Western tradition are still around.

Now, as I claimed prior, there are ideas within other ideas, or programs within greater programs. The search for the source codes, or the most foundational ideas or idea is the final end of contemplation: the ultimate Nous. And when thinking of philosophy or philosophers this is what we take to be their unique or most important activity, as far as the field goes, or at least the best use of Reason we can think of. But don't be so quick to bestow accolades. The necessity we have been talking about only applies to the Mind. And the foundation(s) of the mind could be entirely arbitrary. The source codes might be something illusory like Time, or even something silly like God. These things might not correspond to reality at all. There may be no Time or no God in the world outside of the mind. But let's hope there is at least Time in the external world. Otherwise,

¹¹⁴ Hylomorphism is roughly the idea that form and matter always occur together and cannot be separated from one another. Though this is a mere simplification of a very rich theory.

the entire basis on which all our knowledge is built would be based on a delusion. There is, I should add, the possibility that there is still an accidental correspondence between our idealistic mental machinery and reality haphazardly established by evolution. Like hunters that throw spears at ripples in the water having no idea there are fish or that there are fish beneath the ripples. It just tends to work, and an ample supply of dead fish happen to show up at the shore for them to eat. Let's hope this isn't really the case. Let's hope there is some significant correspondence between our thoughts and reality. My emotions and my body do seem to suggest so, that there is some real physical reality I am interacting with. And because emotions and the body, as I take it, are not part of Mind, there is reason for hope.

15. Godhead

God exists, if only in the form of a meme with high survival value,
or ineffective power, in the environment provided by human culture.
(Richard Dawkins, *The Selfish Gene*)

Does God exist? Dawkins, and meme theorists, have got it wrong at each angle. The First is thinking memes and ideas are the same. They're not. What we would call "memes" are physical copies, artifacts expressed in the world—whether in speech, print, image, statue, tool. Ideas on the other hand are non-physical. The Second is thinking ideas are *out there* in the world, surfing the wave of Culture. They're not. Ideas live in the head. The Third is thinking ideas are the same, the Fourth that they lack power. There are ideas that are Ancient, rising before the first hut, dance, spear, hymn; Ideas that have shaped the Mind itself; and extorted every measure over the human organism. God exists—It is not some triviality, as Dawkins would have you believe—He exists, and is the most Powerful idea there has ever been. He has been there since the beginning of Consciousness, taking on different shapes: Fire, Storm, Animal, Spirit, Female, Male, Person, Light; Many, Few, One. He has always thrust Himself in the Center of our lives, molded us, lied to us, killed us, buried us. He has never changed, nor wants to; Only the Artifacts representing Him have changed.

Let's fast-forward. An issue in the give-and-take between Theologians and Philosophers, and now Scientists regarding the Nature of God is the gravitation toward extremes. Theologians solve their *problem* by making God more powerful—perfect, unquestioned. Philosophers solve their *problem* by making God less powerful—abstract, ubiquitous—the pinnacle being Baruch Spinoza's pantheism.¹¹⁵ Scientists solve their *problem*—the widespread prevalence of religious thinking—by denying that God exists entirely; that people are simply deluded, or as Dawkins contends, God is reduced to an impotent meme. But outside of lip service to the Problem of Evil, or surveying the World's religions, finding a middle ground seems unfathomable.

It's actually quite easy to prove the existence of God. He's likely in your head *right now*; my guess making you angry, hostile toward the scribbles you are reading. Relax. If you are an atheist, God is in your head too; He just doesn't have control over you—which is a good thing.

¹¹⁵ See Spinoza's *Ethics*.

But as you seek out other sources of meaning, New Age spiritual mumbo jumbo, He will begin to take control again, even if in subtle ways.

God exists, but He's only in your head; and the heads of billions of other people. God to be clear has no direct control over the World, nor direct control over external things. God does have *power* though, but only over people—and indirectly God has external power because people have external power. God has knowledge, but only knowledge of your conscious self. He does not have knowledge of other people, or knowledge outside of what you know. (And just to be particularly clear, God is not telepathic, just in case He is steering you in that direction to make you afraid.) The kicker, God uses *this* knowledge, and His power, to manipulate you. God is a selfish idea, plain and simple—though a very powerful one. The standard of propagation (of this idea) being enthrallment. All God cares about is His (maximal) propagation and continued conscious reinforcement in your head. You better pray! Don't. We should not make Dawkins' mistake and hold God as innocuous. We should be *God-fearing*; mainly because God is out to control us.

God controls us through Fear but He also controls us through Love. God is Love. No, God uses love as a weapon. Jesus was betrayed by the person he loved most, turned on, all for spectacle, to be a symbol, to leech off our sympathy, toward the semblance of a good man willing to give up everything for a Lie—redirected to Him, who has never loved, and never will. *End hyperbole*. It is extremely important to realize that ideas are emotionless. This is the case even for the oldest and most powerful ideas. An idea is incapable of feeling anything, much less love, or jealousy, or anger as is the case with the mosaic created around God in the Judeo-Christian tradition. In fact, the necessity of Jesus of Nazareth points to this very fact. God needed to be recreated in the form of a *Mortal Man* actually capable of being kind and compassionate and loving and suffering. The huge success of Christianity depends on this recreation and adjustment.

It's unfortunate the symbol for Christianity is Jesus agonizingly suffering on the Cross. But God is a great salesman, knowing this maximizes the feeling of sympathy and with a little nudging can be morphed into love (or gratitude). Jesus, even if not the son of God, seemed like a very virtuous person. His symbol would be more fitting if it was him smiling, happy, helping the poor, or something like that. (The other ridiculous symbol is him as a baby in a manger. But again, it's important we know that Jesus was human and born just like the rest of us. So it works.) That being said, acknowledging we should see Jesus as an ordinary man, and let's say he really was human in the true sense, not holy and so on; he actually did turn out to be the son of God, if we take God to be an idea. God used Jesus as His messenger, and he does act as the representative of God in human flesh—eventually leading to the conversion of billions of people to the Idea. He might as well have been God's actual heir. Though, I suspect, God likely used many others before Jesus in the same way—sacrificing them—before He got it right. So, to stay on point, if you as a Theist, if you are one, ever wondered why God gets a lot less emotional by the time we make it to the New Testament; it's because He doesn't need to be emotional anymore. Jesus does all the emotional work for Him.

The thing to take away, is that God doesn't love you. He just isn't capable of it. If it was possible to love anything, He would simply love Himself and the billions of copies of Him vibrating in peoples' brains. That's narcissism on a grand scale. Thus, the thing we call God is an imposter; pretending to be what He's not, telling us what we want to hear, promising us the world,

even an extra world after we die. But, unfortunately, we have been duped into His con, investing everything we have, for nothing. It is not a wager¹¹⁶ but a scam, rigged, and it is really sad.

Breaking free from religious thinking is itself a psychological event. How do we break the *spell*, our enthrallment with God? Daniel Dennett proposed subjecting religion to rigorous scientific analysis.¹¹⁷ But this scientific push is misguided; mainly on account of the fact that the study of God is internal. Science only deals with the external. Thus, the extent to which science can study God is limited to His external artifacts. It is instead the duty of Philosophy to free us from enthrallment. The problem is the best philosophers, those brave enough to venture *deep* within the mind, are greeted by God with laurels; and it is no accident that these heroes, those who hit something, attribute their success to Him. But it is a tragedy, and these warriors, champions, are changed into servants. To escape is a personal journey, and the *fuel* is philosophical doubt. Not doubt to Nothing, but doubt to the possibility of Everything. You must keep going further and further, not stopping in the face of God, not to greet angels, not running from the monsters of your psyche, not even to face yourself; which you'll encounter towards the end; You must keep going until you arrive back where you started, and realize you are your own master, and you are above your own mind. This is the only way to truly free ourselves from religion. And atheists need to make this psychological journey as well; and it will be much harder, for they will not recognize the monsters.

16. Reason's Curse

When one finds it necessary to turn reason into a tyrant, the danger cannot be slight that something else threatens to play the tyrant.
(Friedrich Nietzsche, *Twilight of the Idols*)

I am a thinking thing.
(René Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy*)

Philosophers worship Reason. But we may question whether we should? In this section, I argue that while Reason is useful and even beautiful, it carries a curse. This curse is especially severe in philosophers whose whole occupation is tied to the use of Reason. There is a lesser and greater version of the curse: (1) we should listen to Reason and Reason is always right, and (2) we *are* Reason, and our very existence is wrapped up in it. I will first respond to the lesser version and then the greater version. I will then go on to argue that if you accept both (1) and (2) your agency and ontological esteem is crippled. Let's start with (1).

Should you listen to Reason? In most cases it pays to do so, because Reason tends to get it right. But besides a good track record there are no normative reasons to follow its commands. Reason lacks emotion so it will remain indifferent as far as what action you choose to follow. It makes no difference to Reason whether you choose great benevolence or horrible malice. Though,

¹¹⁶ See Blaise Pascal's "The Wager."

¹¹⁷ See Dennett's *Breaking the Spell: Religion as a Natural Phenomenon*.

it is worth pointing out, that Reason is practical and constant, and by its structure will not recommend self-defeating courses of action. But consistency in itself is not virtue. It is possible to be consistent in vicious or even trivial ways. At some point, at the very start of philosophy even, morality became wed to Reason. Not long after Reason became a very controlling husband. Morality was not even allowed to follow its most sincere feelings and instincts without first getting Reason's approval. And an evaluative transition happened where *should listen to reason* changed to *must follow reason*.

That being said, in many cases, even if I would oppose the *must*, we *should* listen to Reason. It's our very best bet at bringing about our goals, and is much more reliable than emotion or making arbitrary decisions. But we may go on to ask should we *always* listen to Reason? Here, I give a firm No. If we always listen to Reason, no matter what, we become slaves to it. And this is a problem even for the best of us like Socrates who was quite happy being Reason's slave. I am not simply using the word slave in a figurative way. To always follow Reason's commands, even when you sincerely don't want to, limits your freedom. Your will is not your own and you don't have a choice. Interestingly, this applies both in individual cases as well as all like (future) cases. Reason always issues the same commands. So even before it comes up there are already a range of things you simply can't do.

I am not advocating irrationality. But in at least some cases you should be warranted in making whatever choice fits your whims. For example, you should be allowed to be an artist, even if you have a very high natural talent for mathematics and can benefit the world greatly by doing that instead of art. You should also be allowed to contradict yourself. There is a certain comic beauty in doing so. I don't necessarily agree with Nietzsche in that he just proposes an even more ruthless tyrant in the place of Reason: the unrestrained will to power. But perhaps this is who we truly are; wild animals pursuing the natural call to propagate and dominate and affirm life itself in the most extreme way. I would not outright deny this. The human organism, in my view, does include the body and all its urges, in addition to emotions, Mind (memories and ideas), and whatever else may be in play. But some philosophers vehemently deny this. And this brings us to the greater version of Reason's Curse: Holding that Reason is all you are, and everything else is insignificant.

The Great René Descartes in 1641 uttered the famous line: "I think, therefore I am." And the philosophical tradition has been inflicted ever since. But this greater version of Reason's Curse has some serious implications if taken seriously. Descartes was so convinced, that he was willing to deny the entire external world outside of Reason. Descartes' Evil Demon was in fact himself. Of course, Descartes saved himself from absurdity by resurrecting God from the ashes, in order to make the world livable again.¹¹⁸ But many philosophers secretly hold a grudge against him for doing so, in that he marred a rather tight and noble project. The rest of philosophers think he did the most wonderful thing in the world by tying God to Reason. But putting God aside, the sanctification of Reason, though we don't usually think of it in this way, is a scary prospect. In the lesser curse, we are not allowed to make decisions counter to Reason; in the greater curse we are not even allowed to exist without Reason. Luckily most people don't take the implications of Descartes entirely seriously. But there are some hapless people, both laymen and philosophers

¹¹⁸ See *Meditations on First Philosophy*, Fifth Meditation, for Descartes' theological argument for God's existence.

alike, where the curse has turned into possession and psychosis. The extreme skeptics, taking Descartes' words and project to heart, go on to deny or question the external world we live in. They are not even allowed to live in the world. This extreme skepticism can be forgiven on account of no one actually acting on it, at least not enough to adjust their lives in a serious way, like jumping off a cliff hoping they can fly. (Though it is possible we are brains in vats or living in a simulation. So maybe the lunatics are prophets.) What can't be forgiven though is denying the existence of the body in the extreme position, or treating it as real but a mere automaton in Descartes' "graceful" compromise.

Cartesian dualism is an extension of Reason's Curse, and in league with Plato's earlier attempt at a project that treats the body as a slave to be exploited. Hostility toward the body is nothing new, as many religions have taken the exploitive view and simply replaced Reason with a Soul. The soul is who you truly are, and everything else is insignificant, as the mantra goes. But at least the religions make some enticing promises, like once that pesky body is removed your soul will be free and have lots of pleasure and happiness. And sure, keep your emotions too, just not the bad ones. But I will parse with pointing out that emotions, and the body, and all the other stuff, are an important part of the human organism, maybe even more so than Mind, and should not be separated from it.

The final version of Reason's Curse, combining both (1) and (2), comes a little later in its clearest form with Immanuel Kant. Mainly, Reason-morality is inescapable and you do something seriously wrong by acting against its commands; and all we *are* are centers of rationality and our entire worth is wrapped up in being such. If that wasn't clear enough, Kant clarifies that emotions and desires and whatever other inclinations we might have should play no decisive role in our moral decisions; in some places he extends this to all decisions.¹¹⁹ Kant should have just gone further and denied the body. Kant's theories are a leviathan, so I won't go into them here. But I will say, as much as Kant talks about freedom; We're clearly not free under his theory. We must do what Reason dictates, No exceptions; No matter what; And failing to do so not only is a practical failure, but a betrayal of our very nature. I don't personally buy it. But let's not defame the Great Kant. I'll just close by saying that Kant, and some of his followers, have the most severe form of Reason's Curse.

After a lot of complaining, I want to be very clear that I am not endorsing irrationalism. Reason is part of the Mind, and the mind is an important part of the human organism. We wouldn't be human beings without it. In fact, Reason is probably the best part of us and a very special thing. But just as we sometimes fail to see the vices in those we love, we also will often ignore vices of Reason when they occur. Reason is not perfect. We are a composite organism made up of a body, and emotions, and Mind. It's best if we treat them all as special and afford them the worth that they deserve.

17. Actualization

¹¹⁹ See in particular *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* and *The Metaphysics of Morals*.

Until you make the unconscious conscious, it will direct your life
and you will call it fate.

(Carl Jung, *The Integration of the Personality*)

Who/what should we trust, if not God or Reason? Yourself? If only it was that simple. Much of what you are is foreign.

The worst part of yourself is who you resemble most. The key is to bring your worst close to good, even if it means engaging in a little revelry, accepting your dark side, bringing it up as it brings you down; befriending your Shadow, laughing at its jokes, seeing the hypocrisy of complete piety; but also showing it the perils of evil, the absurdity of wickedness, until you appreciate each other as complex, neither black nor white, and are able to discuss a meeting with Virtue—if only it would see a part of you in it.

For quicker results, find the person most Opposite of you, who you somewhat despise, but are intrigued by nonetheless. If they are not too evil, and have a tincture of good, this will be your best friend. They will despise you too, but for opposite reasons. This is the *Jungian spark*, clash, that allows truths to be revealed that neither want to hear. Then find the person in your life your Shadow hates; this will be the person doing psychological damage, the person you admire, but are not intrigued by. The reason, the Shadow wants you as you are, the Other wants you to change into something better. This Angel will also hate your Shadow. This is the test. If you want to shed, actualize, follow your Shadow. If you want to transform into something else, follow your Angel. If you don't know yourself, follow both, until one likes you more. If two shadows they will destroy each other, if two angels they will become the same. Finally, for everyone in between, you will neither despise nor admire them; this is good in that they will have no impact on your life. The person you both admire and are intrigued by should be yourself.

Of course I am being somewhat facetious in what I said above. But in pursuing self-actualization you do need to look at the people in your life. Other people see you in a way that you cannot. And this is probably where we should begin with Jung's process of individuation—or integrating the unconscious with the conscious.¹²⁰ In taking on the psyche the first Jungian aspect to look at is the *Persona*. This is the social mask we wear; an artificial personality that we share with the world. Now there are many masks we wear rather than the one; some more artificial than others. We will need to shed these masks in the process of individuation. (We can of course rebuild our masks later.) This is important to do because masks can remove the need for growth. Many people are comfortable with adopting ready-made masks as a substitute for their personality. While this is a type of personality, it is a very shallow one. How to shed our masks? Ideally, you can appeal to friends for help. Friends can usually dismantle many of your masks, even if you are unaware of their severity or their existence at all. The mask(s) you share with your friends is much harder to dispose of. This requires brutal honesty and candor, and should be reserved for those closest to you.¹²¹ A person may also have some exotic mask(s) used in private reflection or fantasy. These masks will also need to be shed—at least while pursuing the process of individuation.

¹²⁰ See Jung's "The Relations Between the Ego and the Unconscious" and "On the Nature of the Psyche," in particular for a comprehensive overview of his process of individuation. I do take some liberties with Jung's process, and use it more as a blueprint. My account is more accurately called actualization.

¹²¹ A psychotherapist might also be used here. But the process will be more difficult.

The next Jungian aspect is the *Ego-consciousness*.¹²² Instead of a mask, this is more like a mirror. It is how you see yourself or would like to see yourself. Usually it includes things that you take to be positive or acceptable. But in many cases what people see in the *mirror* is distorted and not an accurate representation of who they really are. People will often inflate their personal image of themselves. This can lead to narcissism and megalomania. Similarly, creating some unrealistic ideal that does not match what's actually possible can lead to frustration and dissatisfaction. There is also the other end, where people see themselves negatively and worse than they really are. This is also destructive. In following the path of individuation, we must accurately capture our personal image in a way that coheres to objective reality. In doing so, we must disband the ideal self (or some conception of a future ideal self) and grasp the conscious self in the present, as it currently is, unadulterated. (That is not to say we cannot create some *new* better conscious self later on.) This requires some humility and self-love. Sometimes what you find may not be satisfying, even boring. But this should not be a major hurdle. The ego-consciousness is only a part of what you are. The complete Self is much bigger and likely more interesting.

The third Jungian aspect is the *Personal Unconscious*. This contains all of a person's repressed or forgotten memories as well as psychological complexes.¹²³ The goal in individuation is to recover as much of this hidden content as possible. This is pertinent because unconscious memories and complexes can influence behavior in unexpected ways. In order to have more psychological agency we will thus need to bring the personal unconscious to the surface. That being said, recovering the personal unconscious can involve reexperiencing significant trauma or traumatic events. It is therefore recommended to pursue this step of individuation with the help of a psychotherapist. This can mitigate and control trauma, as well as reduce confusion and emotional turmoil. It also allows for the utilization of advanced therapeutic techniques like reframing, word association, hypnosis, and guided imagery.

After recovering as much of the personal unconscious as possible (it's nearly impossible to recover it all) we can then move on to the fourth Jungian aspect: the *Collective Unconscious*. Within the Collective Unconscious are two important components: the *Anima/Animus* and the *Shadow*. The first, the Anima/Animus, if you recall, represents the feminine aspects of a man and the masculine aspects of a woman. In the process of individuation we will need to draw out the opposite sex. In discovering our Anima or Animus we can make use of different archetypes to help us along. For example, we may understand or appreciate femininity by looking to general archetypes like the Mother or Maiden. We might also use more specific feminine archetypes like Pandora, or the Virgin Mary, or Joan of Arc, or Athena—to better relate to women. From the other side, a woman may appeal to masculine archetypes like the Father, or Hero, or Hercules, or Jesus, or Casanova, or Socrates. In comparing and opening oneself up to opposites we become more whole.

Though, I admit, it could be argued that in the modern context sharp divisions based on sex are less fixed than they used to be. I take this as a good thing, and something that makes the process of individuation easier. But, I suggest, we might take the process further than Jung proposed and

¹²² It is important to point out that Jung's ego-consciousness is not the same as Freud's ego or superego.

¹²³ A psychological complex, in the Jungian vein, is, roughly, a highly emotional laced representation (sometimes an archetype) that influences behavior, often in an irrational way.

use this step of individuation as representing our relation to and reconciliation with Otherness. We can view ourselves as *other* in order to better appreciate our individuality. And even in the modern context there are hurdles to overcome. For instance, we may deal with the Opposite, not as a different sex, but rather as a different racial group or ethnicity or social class. It thus might prove useful to see ourselves in a different light, and may help alleviate bias in the same way that discovering the Anima/Animus can alleviate sexism.

The next component is the Shadow. This, again, represents our dark side. It is the desires, urges, feelings, thoughts, that we are ashamed of and hide from others. We usually suppress this part of ourselves and try not to acknowledge it; in many cases hiding it from ourselves as well. This proves destructive and can result in us unconsciously projecting our negative qualities onto others. For Jung, the Shadow is not bad or entirely negative.¹²⁴ It can be a source of creative energy. It can also be a source of power and confidence. The process of individuation will require us to come to terms with the Shadow. It is a big part of who we are, and finding the Shadow might be seen as the most important part of individuation.

This step of the process of individuation usually starts with an encounter with the Shadow. This can't necessarily be forced but is likely to come naturally at some point if we follow the previous steps of individuation put forward. The Shadow will take the form of a distinct archetype and will reoccur. In the initial encounter, usually in a dream, the Shadow archetype will challenge you as falling short of getting the things you truly desire. This will likely cause uneasiness. From here, the *conversation* should continue and can be enhanced by various methods like dream analysis, active imagination, creative expression, and mandalas. Using images from mythology proves particularly useful.

As the Shadow becomes known, a person will discover and become aware of his/her repressed desires, urges, feelings, thoughts, etc. To continue the process of individuation a person might pursue different courses of actions. The first course is to dissolve one's guilt and/or shame and actively pursue and acquire what one truly wants. Considering that many social conventions, traditions, taboos are unfounded, this may not be as devastating as a person fears. This could foster courage and individual growth in the face of others' opinions. Of course, there are some desires, actions that are clearly wrong and should not be pursued. This leads to a negotiation with the Shadow over how much liberty should be allowed in pursuing what one wants. Ideally, over time, a sort of compromise or harmony can be reached where room is allowed for the satisfying of (non-heinous) desires within a reasonable scope, resulting in a type of integration where the unconscious is brought to the surface and acknowledged by the conscious. As for those desires, urges, feelings, thoughts that are too bane to be granted a conscious sanction, they need not be re-suppressed and sent back into obscurity.¹²⁵ These dark features of us can be worked out and understood by engaging with various archetypes, leading to an ongoing process of integration: "shadow work" as is the parlance of analytical psychology.

Finally, I would say there is an even deeper level of the unconscious which might be called the *Forbidden Unconscious*. This goes beyond individuation, and I propose it only as a

¹²⁴ See Jung's "On the Psychology of the Unconscious."

¹²⁵ Unless you are genuinely evil or a psychopath, then you *should* suppress your desires and not act on them. You must instead follow the one moral rule that I give in Section 20.

philosophical exercise to better understand the mind. Going too deep can be dangerous and a psychological hazard. To get to this point, we must first recognize the Shadow. Only then should we proceed. With the Shadow's blessing we should then go *further down* to the workings of the mind that are not really a part of you at all and are inhuman. In achieving this level, we might rely on prolonged active imagination, deep meditation, automatic or free writing, psychedelic drugs, fervor, and temporarily inducing psychosis. The individuation process leaves us bare and open, allowing us to pursue archetypes to the point where they become independent entities, which we might call *psychic phantoms*. These phantoms will usually take on the form of some religious or mythical figure or a dead relative, but can manifest in many different ways. What's unique is that these phantoms will claim to be more than useful archetypes but rather *agents* with something to offer you; usually some sort of arcane knowledge. If you are lured by this promise, the phantom will remain outside of your conscious control and persist in the psyche. Whether to negotiate with a phantom depends on what it has to offer. Sometimes it will offer something valuable, sometimes it won't. There are indeed gifts to be had hidden deep within the mind. But the more time spent in this netherworld the more one runs the risk of having a psychotic break or developing permanent psychosis.

The above journey is useful for understanding the mind. But the Unconscious, to be clear, can consume a person if left unchecked. The Shadow is a reflection of you, but further down there are real Monsters, all claiming to be guides. If you don't know yourself, trust yourself, and look back; that beautiful creature will take your place. As the *Red Book* shows, Jung never made it back the same. I think if there is any truth to what we would call the paranormal or paranatural activity this is the *Gateway*. Here we will find ghouls, demons, angels, ghosts, spirits, lesser gods, fairies, and jinn. This could pose some interest. But some things are best left alone. Be warned, after surveying Tartarus and seeing it for yourself once or twice, hastily leave and never return again.

With this behind us we have the psychic material necessary to at last create the *Self*. But while the personal process of individuation or actualization is complete it is worth mentioning that external factors can cripple or sabotage this development. One of the most powerful influences is the culture we find ourselves immersed in. It does vary, and certain societies will increase our potential whereas others will diminish it. But I recommend severing our link to arbitrary social conventions. This is not saying one should be a social outcast. But rather that there should be some distance between the internal creation and public opinion. It is thus prudent to recreate the Persona and the various masks needed to navigate one's society. In this way we can protect the complexities of the unique individual from unjust pressure.

Somewhat more difficult is to sever the link between one's values and society's sanctioned moral codes. Nearly every society is tainted by fluctuating class interests and power dynamics. It is thus not the most reliable source for determining what is right. I would propose that our moral code be derived from philosophical reflection. But it need not be something to include within the process of Self-building. A more pressing worry is that in most societies morality is weaved in with or derived from religion. This is the biggest threat to our individuality. In fact, it is quite perplexing why religion, God, would care whether you are moral or not, or enforce it. The ruse; I take it, is that it is to keep you away from your Shadow, which tends to be a little evil; prone to violating social norms. Finding your Shadow is one of the most important steps to self-

actualization. Of course, God doesn't want this, and will snare you into a moral code—guilt to back. The proselytizing of morality by religion is not (as we believe) for the benefit of mankind, it is for the benefit of God; to keep you ensnared. What we call *piety* is really just a psychic trap. There's only one moral rule that you need to follow, which I will give later on.¹²⁶

I have beaten this dead horse. But escaping God, in whatever form He takes, is one of the most important things we need to do in our lives. It is not mere inactivity that is required or resisting some faithful urge. God is embedded in the very structure of our minds. He is the *onus aeternus*. The opposite of actualization is submission or surrender. This unfortunately is the end of Self. They simply are not compatible. This relinquiship is also present historically in the structure of philosophy, and is something that must be overcome. Both individually, and as philosophers, we must fight for authenticity and what truly is our own.

18. Fall from Grace

Science is the great antidote to the poison of enthusiasm and superstition.

(Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*—1776)

A Brief History of Philosophy. Philosophy has an illustrious history. Tracing the Western tradition, from Socrates onward, Philosophy enjoyed special prominence and influence for well over a thousand years. And our present liberal culture is tied to this success. Philosophical Schools like Plato's Academy, Aristotle's Lyceum, and Epicurus' Garden acted as epicenters of learning in Athens, driving philosophical and scientific debate throughout the Hellenic world. Later Neo-Platonism and Skepticism spread throughout Europe and North Africa forcing rigorous examination and adjustments to prevailing theories and religious dogma. Stoicism made its way into the Roman Empire, appealing to both slave and emperor alike. Epicureanism found its place with commoners. Mass adoption of philosophical theories, new and old, pushed their way throughout the Empire and spread to its corners. Early Christians like Saint Augustine incorporated elements from prominent philosophical theories into the foundations of the budding new religion: Refashioned Christianity. The great philosophical debates travelled east to the Roman Byzantine Empire.

Though Philosophy's unique status would come to a tragic halt with the fall of the Roman Empire and the beginning of the Dark Ages. Philosophy managed to linger on, but only by eventually being absorbed into Religion. This proved to be fortuitous, though less than ideal and perverse for the tradition. But, I confess, we owe those studious monks and scribes, in Christian Europe as well as the Islamic East, a huge debt. The tradition would have surely been lost if not put under their care.

¹²⁶ See Section 20.

Philosophy survived the Dark Ages and toward its end even had a significant boost in the hands of Thomas Aquinas.¹²⁷ Aristotle was reworked and fashioned as a theological weapon. “The Philosopher” became an authority on everything. This elevated status would continue and gain a second boost into the Renaissance as everything Ancient Greek became the craze. Philosophy reached a high point, not held since the Early Roman Empire.

But Philosophy’s revered position would change as we entered the Enlightenment. With the advent of Science, everything religious, supernatural, arcane became intellectual taboo. The Spirit of Philosophy, caught in the middle, split from Religion and decided to side with the Newcomer. But it did so at a cost. Instead of Champion, It became lesser maid to Science. It would eventually be cast aside, and lose its status, as Reason became equated with the scientific. The new standard of propagation (of ideas) became usefulness. And Science promised to explain everything.

Lost. Not being useful, Philosophy searched for its niche. The inner world called to it; rationalism, dualism, idealism; but by the time it gained hold it was already too late. These things were already reclaimed by Religion; and even those defending it as philosophers were doing so on religious grounds. Not being able to return back to Religion, being cut off, Philosophy did the only thing it could, and declared itself a science in its own right. This was the beginning of the end.

There is an *alternate history* that I ought to mention; One of Theologians sparked with philosophical sight who came close to discovering the true Nature of God—as Manipulator. Only to have it stripped away, concluded, under the watch of George Berkeley¹²⁸—a sin that would discourage all further inquiry. I call this near miss the Theological Flirt. The lost discovery: that we are, for the most part, mentally determined—by God among other things—but not physically determined.

In sum: Early Christian philosophers, riding Neo-Platonism, removed God from the Mountain and put him *out there*. But as God became more abstract so did his power, eventually dissipating into a single (mental-physical) causal principle.

Medieval philosophers renewed God’s particular powers and experimented with God being in our heads, but were always quick to also throw him back into the world, and reassert his physical power. They were never quite comfortable with mere mind-control (the truth); and in the end removed God from the head entirely calling it his covenant of “Free Will.”

It took quite a number of years before philosophers thought to ask the question: ‘Why couldn’t God just make us do stuff directly? Why bother with physical causation?’ The next fling would occur with the Theological-Idealists, who would throw us in the Mind of God. We finally had something resembling true mental determinism. But the cost was our physical freedom. We were fully determined again. This was the last scandal before the 1,500-year affair ended entirely, the *truth* lost. And this, unfortunately, would be the last time the Spirit of Philosophy tried to save Religion from itself; before it moved on forever, and left It to its own devices—damned.

¹²⁷ See Aquinas' *Summa Theologica*. Some other notable late medieval figures were Peter Abelard, John Duns Scotus, and William of Ockham.

¹²⁸ See Berkeley's *Treatise Concerning the Principles of Human Knowledge*.

19. Rising Star

God is dead.

(Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Gay Science*—1882)

Philosophy is dead.

(Stephen Hawking, *The Grand Design*—2010)

In the Modern Age, Science has grown to eclipse Religion and Philosophy in status. Its success has been unrivaled. Even those who are religious largely accept scientism, and revere the discipline. It holds the potential, we think, to explain everything. Did Science kill Philosophy? I say No. Philosophy has been soul searching for 200 years. It has yet to find its place. But I think it is time for it to do what it was always supposed to do, what it has been afraid to do for 2,500 years. It is time for Philosophy to replace Religion and become Master of the Internal World.

Now, throughout its long history, Philosophy has learned a lot and has been considerably developed. I think philosophy currently has enough content to draw from, old and new, to be functionally complete for its purposes—acknowledging that it is far from perfect and that we still need to sort through and make sense of this vast content. (If we include the non-Western philosophical traditions there is even more content to utilize.) Largely, there is enough material to work with, and philosophy is equipped for the task at hand.

There is really no need to wait for some better future Ideal Philosophy, or for some new yet-to-be-born Great Philosopher, to radically change the philosophical paradigm. The history of philosophy has no shortage of geniuses, and much of what matters philosophically has already been argued for or suggested or hinted at by one of them at some point. Lesser-known philosophers of history are also being made accessible, in case something slipped through the cracks. There is also the work and collaboration of all our current professional philosophers, rapidly throwing ideas back-and-forth to each other with a click. The time is ripe for Philosophy to make, or start making, its Big Move. That is, taking its rightful place as Master of the Internal World.

Though I do acknowledge that philosophy is typically much broader than the study of the internal. But, I strongly believe, it is important to claim a definitive niche and defend it, even if it means narrowing the field—and giving ground to science. Not doing so in the past, as was pointed out in the previous section, proved a disaster for Philosophy. Not to mention that a *niche-less* philosophy, as of late, proves an easy target for scientists, like Hawking, to attack and discredit. Let us not risk the Spirit of Philosophy dying on account of something as simple as not defining its proper domain.

By saying Philosophy should become Master of the Internal World I am not simply suggesting that some new (philosophical) religion be formed to usurp existing religions. I am instead saying Philosophy can offer something qualitatively better than religion. That is, by the end of the essay, the reader should have a direct means to achieving spiritual fulfilment, rather than being manipulated (either by others or by yourself or by God) into having spiritual fulfilment or getting it indirectly or accidentally or partially—if at all.

Philosophy is different in kind from religion. Faith itself is not something philosophy can authentically endorse. There must be reasons, preferably good or compelling reasons, for believing

philosophical positions. And when this doesn't hold, we should put our beliefs to the fire (rather than put disbelievers to the fire; a very effective historical strategy for resolving religious disputes). That is, skepticism rather than dogmatism is the starting position. In this way, philosophy is more like science than religion. But there are important demarcations.

Philosophy, to be clear, is not science or a science; nor should it try to be. Its method is deductive, not inductive. Its goal is internal, not external. It also deals with things science cannot, or even should not deal with. The stuff of good philosophy borders on the absurd, and it takes a very special breed of person—philosophers—to move it forward; or backwards. Scientists have more realistic matters to attend to. But I cheer, it's about time for Philosophy to take on the spooky, outlandish, weird, bizarre, esoteric, delirious. The Enlightenment scare is over. The most obvious and easiest starting points are to accept the possibility that rationalism, dualism, idealism are true—as suggested throughout the essay. To take up this old set of philosophical challenges. But to do it free of Religion and Science—and their many commitments and snags. Philosophy should be pure and hold its own.

By holding its own, I am not saying Philosophy is opposed to Science. On the contrary, they need each other. We need philosophy to give us a full theory of the internal world, and we need science to give us a full theory of the external world. Because the World is internal and external we need *both* to truly understand Everything. But while Philosophy and Science are teammates playing for the human species, they should be respected as masters of separate domains. They should not be married. There has been a marriage for 200 years, and it has been an unhappy one, at least on the part of philosophy. They should cordially divorce but remain good friends; occasionally friends with benefits, unintended pregnancies and all, with the new fields it produces.

Where should we place Religion in all this? I say let it die. It has never done anything but make us miserable and servile. Philosophy and Science are able to make sense of the world. The only reason to hold onto religion would be to fill some spiritual hole—that science is unable to fill. But I believe philosophy can fill that hole. We do not need religion to control our lives. All we need is a small dose of mysticism, just enough *confuse* to make life interesting, marvelous, beautiful, sublime. My philosophical mysticism, I believe, provides that esoteric whiff, meaning, inner vision, purpose necessary to satiate us—as spiritual beings. And it does so while avoiding the drawbacks and pitfalls present in most religions.

All that being said, Philosophy and Science are not the only players in the world of ideas. The Artist is also needed. There is a standard division of labor where the artist proposes new ideas, the philosopher defines it, and the scientist explains it. But artists tend to be afraid to overreach, rather only occasionally borrowing concepts. Though some science fiction writers have done work that could fall under the category of science. (In fact, I could be accused of dabbling in some fiction myself in the coming sections.) There is no reason why art and philosophy ought not work together, even in capacities much more meaningful than the interplay which occurs between science and science fiction. For some reason, historically, this never really happened in any substantial sense. The Artist has always watched Philosophy at a distance, inspired, but never mustering the courage to court it or treat it on equal footing—besides, again, humbly borrowing concepts. Now that Philosophy is free, *It sees you*. Mainly, the Artist should take on philosophy in a serious way. More beauty is needed in philosophy.

The Artist once assisted Religion. Most religions would not be possible without the artists who crafted its poetry and wonderful stories—and statues, and architecture, and paintings, and songs. Any religion without its art would likely not be accepted, much less survive for very long. I take it, it is time for the Artist to now help Philosophy craft its own poetry and wonderful stories. This *aesthetic aid* is crucial if Philosophy has any real chance of replacing Religion. A new romance is needed. And who knows—unlike with Science—Philosophy and Art may turn out to be true soul mates.

20. God(less) Artifacts

Mr. Wednesday [Odin]: Do not talk to him. Do not say a word. Do not tell him anything.

Shadow Moon: You don't know me.

Mr. World: Sure I do. You're a person. I know people, everything about all of them.

(*American Gods*, "Lemon Scented You")

God used to censor the world. This is no longer the case. With the death of God, new gods have stepped in to fill the vacuum and provide meaning: Artifacts. Artifacts involve the Mind being extended into the external world; and are products of such extension. Artifacts are man-made and usually have some intention in being made. The effects of artifacts may change but there is always some original intention that can be found, even if hidden. There are still many religious artifacts, for instance, which in most cases carry the intention that God be instantiated in the mind. What's important is that the intention found in artifacts need not necessarily be a conscious intention in the artificer or (human) designer. For example, someone who creates a religious artifact need not consciously intend that God be instantiated in the mind when such an artifact is encountered. Rather, religious artifacts are usually made to glorify God or for aesthetic reasons. But the unconscious intention is still there that God be worshiped, and the religious artifact has some effect in bringing that about. Artifacts can also cause new unexpected effects, but the original intention will always remain.

There are also non-religious artifacts, and very many of them, more so than at any other point in history. Memes are also artifacts. And even memes that don't take the form of objects or items are still artifacts because they are derived from the human mind, such as language and so on. Communication being an external phenomenon. Both ideas and memories can be relayed as artifacts and interacted with in the external world. For instance, a book is an artifact that can if read instantiate certain ideas in the mind. A photo or painting or a statue can share certain memories. Art, as an artifact, can express and induce certain emotions in the observer. An artifact can also cause certain behaviors, especially if inciting this behavior was intended by the artificer. For instance, a billboard can cause us to buy specific products.

These claims really aren't that revolutionary or interesting in themselves. What is though, is that due to there being so many artifacts, especially now, and limitations to human influence and potential exposure, including our ability to instantiate ideas as well as remember, a sort of

competition is created amongst various artifacts. Those that can't influence us, go extinct or are forgotten. The clearest example of this are memes. Where due to fierce competition, many memes eventually go extinct, and only the most influential of them that are effectively or even compulsively spread tend to survive. The most trivial memes being something like jingles, the most complex memes being whole cultural traditions. But I don't want to focus on memes. The study of memes is so oversaturated, that an extensive lit review would be required to do it justice. And I have thus far have been able to avoid lit reviews. Otherwise, the essay would unnecessarily be much longer than it is or needs to be. (I think the essay's actual information content, if expanded to cover all the literature, is probably somewhere between 500-1,000 pages.)

Instead, I want to focus on artifacts as objects or items that manifest in the external world. Objects and items are actually more potent than mere memes because they are potentially more permanent and long-lasting. For example, a statue of the Buddha may lay dormant in a cave for a thousand years, and then after being discovered still have its affectivity. If people stopped talking about that same statue or stop describing it with its corresponding words or names, it would likely disappear. Even if it were remembered and passed on that way, unique memories likely would not be preserved for a thousand years. Though there may be some exceptions to this. But artifacts as objects or items have staying power. For example, we're still talking about the Pyramids to this day.

Another way artifacts can be effective at bringing about its intention is by many copies of them being made and spread throughout the world. Interestingly, the way to do this is to incite humans into actually making new physical copies of the artifacts, and as many as possible. Because human production is limited, it then creates some competition in what artifacts will be created and mass-produced. This winds up creating a kind of Darwinian fitness in artifacts, and in many ways successful artifacts will function like a natural species. It could then over time lead to artifacts taking on a life of their own, losing or hiding the original intention, in favor of promoting its own spread within the human species. The production of more copies of the artifacts being a by-product necessary to continue the spread. But the real purpose of the artifacts would be survival and maximal replication rather than just spreading for the sake of humans. So, they would function to preserve their own existence rather than human existence, sometimes even proving detrimental to human interests.¹²⁹

Over time, artifacts would find that the best way to ensure their spread would be to provide meaning to humans, fabricated or otherwise. Religious artifacts do this quite well. For example, due to the meaning it provides, there are more copies of the Bible, as artifacts, than there are humans in the world. Non-religious artifacts can easily do the same. For example, national flags and sports paraphernalia, due to their meaning, are highly successful replicators. There are, for instance, many more American flags than there are Americans and more football jerseys than there are fans. Because the meaning is false or only a means to promote the continued replication and preservation of artifacts, it is a type of manipulation. But something very interesting and disturbing has been/is happening. Certain collections of different types of artifacts are working together to create irresistible meaning. For example, money, and cars, and jewelry, and clothes, come in an irresistibly package telling you that you need them to be happy. It's one of those few cases in

¹²⁹ Some deleterious examples being tanning beds, corsets, scratch lottery tickets, tabloids, and cigarettes.

nature where cooperation between different species happens on a large scale. The reason, I take it, has to do with the difficulty of manipulating the human organism and providing false meaning. It is difficult for one species of artifact to do alone, so cooperation between artifacts is encouraged by nature in order to successfully manipulate human beings. This can and does happen, and on a big scale. As associations of artifacts develop, eventually being embedded into a society, I take it, a type of primitive consciousness or unconsciousness develops within complex webs of cooperating artifacts. The artifacts then derive their own intentions and values, and certain states of affairs become better or worse for them.

Eventually, artifacts are given their own value by humans and may be taken to have intrinsic value, even in the case of objects of non-religious worship. This is when artifacts flourish the most in the external world. When humans give them intrinsic value. One way for artifacts to ensure that they are valued by humans is to convince them that they are somehow part of or necessary for a person to have purpose, meaning, or happiness. An artifact may even be able to manipulate a person to value that artifact more than other people. It is, we should admit, difficult for an artifact to convince or manipulate a person into valuing it more than their actual self; but it can quite easily convince a person into thinking it is required for them to, *repetere*, have purpose, or have meaning, or to be happy. In this way, an artifact can become part of a person's very identity. This is the prime avenue of manipulation and the most an artifact could ever hope for. This can create a feedback loop where certain artifacts or collections of artifacts are consciously desired by a person, while at the same time shaping that person's future conscious desire for that artifact(s). The artifacts can then shape a person's consciousness to behaviorally bring about or react to the necessary triggers to initiate that very same feedback loop. Thus, artifacts can shape a person's conscious self. And it can do this quite effectively once you let it in, even initially with little meaning and value. Once let in, its influence grows more powerful over time, the worst cases being fetishism.

That is, the World or artifacts know everything about you, as Mr. World says, because they shape your conscious self. And many people are quite susceptible to their influence, particularly when artifacts work in alliance with each other. I'll just leave it at that. Mainly, beware, or be on alert, and know that artifacts are in fact part of nature, a type of species, and in many cases there to manipulate you. And due to the frailty of the conscious self, and human desperation to find meaning anywhere they can, artifacts are able to pull it off.

There is no ideology, no hidden causes, only competition. And the Ethical Law opposed to Nature is: Do Not Exploit. This is the only rule *moral beings* (human or otherwise) need to follow. And I would even go as far as to say this ethical law applies to all species in nature (including animals and artifacts). Most, if not all, species tend to exploit each other, so almost all species are immoral. The only truly moral species (on Earth) are humans. Humans are also unique in that each person is a species unto himself.

21. The Transmigration of Consciousness

Max: Stop, you were gonna climb on an icy chair in six inch heels
and break your neck and then I'm gonna be stuck with a horse in

leggings and you in a wheelchair with a chopstick in your mouth tapping out.

Caroline: I'm sorry, I thought that would work. I learned to build when I volunteered with habitat for humanity. Looking back, they had so much more than I have now.

Max: [Grunts].

Caroline: I gotta go to my babysitting job and when I get back, you and I are gonna sit down and come up with a more realistic home for J. Edgar Hoover.

Max: He lives here.

(*2 Broke Girls*, "And the Reality Check")

The prospect of downloading our consciousness onto a Computer or replacing the human body is getting closer and closer. The quirky *2 Broke Girls* dialogue, if you open up, might be read as an imaginary exchange between the Unconscious and Conscious. The Unconscious (embodied by Max, the old soul, crude but wise) warns the Conscious (embodied by Caroline, the newcomer, brilliant but naive) that if they're not careful they could wind up *in* a "wheelchair tapping out" (e.g., a mind without a body spitting 1's and 0's to a nonresponsive world); Or the other extreme, "a horse in leggings" (e.g., a mindless animal—controlled by artifacts). The Conscious (Caroline), not taking the warning seriously, boasts she had much success when she "volunteered with habitat for humanity" (or initially took control over the human organism). The Unconscious (Max) can only grunt, revealing her primitive non-linguistic origins and lack of volition. The Conscious (Caroline) callowly goes on, that she is busy needing to "get back to her babysitting job" (e.g., watching over the human organism), but says they'll have a discussion later about "coming up with a more realistic home for J. Edgar Hoover" (where J. Edgar Hoover, the first head of the Federal Bureau of Investigation, represents the Brain). The Unconscious (Max), dumbfounded, can only point out that the Brain already has a home, and "lives here" (in the current human organism).

Putting my fondness of *2 Broke Girls* aside, I'll respond to the transmigration issue, and the question of whether we should transmigrate consciousness out of the body, rather bluntly: Definitely not yet; Probably not at all. I don't have anything particularly novel to say on the issue, so I'll just give 21 arguments for why I answered the way I did. This section is a **Warning** to our species.

21 Arguments. (1) We don't fully understand the human brain, making it functionally hard to duplicate. (2) We don't fully understand consciousness. Thus it would be difficult to emulate. (3) We don't fully understand how memories work. This would make them hard to replicate accurately. (4) Only conscious memories would be transferred. Unconscious memories would be lost.

(5) We don't understand the archetypes. Thus archetypes would likely be lost. (6) Ideas are non-physical so would likely not be transferred in a physical conversion. Only physical replicas would remain. (7) Even if we could transfer ideas, we might not be able to transfer the primitive ideas. For example, how do you code for something like Time.

(8) We don't fully understand the emotions, which could be lost or replaced with mere synthetic variants. (9) We lose our bodies. Bodies may be tied to personal identity or have intrinsic

value. (10) There are numerous collections of neurons and neural patterns outside of the brain, so we would have to also transfer a virtual version of the body to capture the same mental features; which could easily go wrong. (11) There might be a soul hidden in the body which could be lost in the transfer. (12) There may be a soul hidden in the brain or mind that could be lost in the transfer.

(13) We could never know for sure nor can anyone else know for sure if we remain qualitatively the same after the transfer. We risk becoming philosophical zombies.¹³⁰ (14) We might die in the break between switching mediums, the new consciousness being only a resurrected copy. (15) We risk getting trapped in a computer simulation, potentially all alone forever, which would amount to Hell. At least we know our current physical body will eventually die at some point, avoiding the possibility of permanent hell. (16) There may be something valuable about mortality and death, which we avoid in transmigration.

(17) Transmigration opens up the potential for multiple copies of the same person, undermining personal identity. (18) There is a break in historical continuity in the transfer, ending a direct 3 billion year evolutionary line. (19) Transmigration might eventually lead to the extinction of the human species as we know it. (20) There might be a sanctity in the human brain which shouldn't be captured by some other medium. (21) There is no urgent need to transmigrate consciousness at this time to warrant all the risks mentioned.

22. Transcending Our Programming

Socrates: And now, let me show in a figure how far our nature is enlightened or unenlightened: Behold! human beings living in an underground den, which has a mouth open towards the light and reaching all along the den; here they have been from their childhood, and have their legs and necks chained so that they cannot move, and can only see before them, being prevented by the chains from turning around their heads. Above and behind them a fire is blazing at a distance, and between the fire and the prisoners there is a raised way; and you will see, if you look, a low wall built along the way, like the screen which marionette players have in front of them, over which they show the puppets.

Glaucou: All I see.

(Plato, *Republic*)

The Mind is powerful. And we are slaves to it. I argued something similar to this when I talked about Reason's Curse. But in this section, I'm talking about the Mind in more general terms, mainly, Memories and Ideas. It will actually turn out to be the case that Reason and philosophy

¹³⁰ A philosophical zombie is someone that possesses all the behavioral features of a conscious person, like saying "delicious" after sipping a cup of tea, but in fact lacks full consciousness or subjective experience or the what-it's-like to be conscious. They are mere, though very convincing, behavioral imitators, and not true persons.

are our greatest allies in fighting and overcoming the mind. But we may wonder why Reason would side with us over its own kin. My view is that this only happens in certain people, that possess the Good. The Good cares about us and is more likely to take our side in the war. It is a Titan in the mind, a mental Promethean defector. But I'll delay talking about the Good until after the arguments in the section are set up. It is also worth making clear that the mind is multifaceted and contains numerous unique memories, archetypes, proto-archetypes, ideas, primitive ideas, and so on. Therefore, this will be a war against many *gods*.¹³¹

The other unlikely ally is the Shadow. This hated part of yourself in all its mischief does care about you, because it is you and who you truly are. Thus, it is likely to take our side in the war. The exalted part of yourself, on the other hand, that you admire so much, along with all its virtues, will ultimately abandon you and side with the *gods*. There is also another war to be fought against the Artifacts, which again are extensions of the Mind in the external world. This will require some additional arguments to address. But the general sentiment is that it is possible to overcome the mind and free ourselves from its tyranny. This is not to say after we gain control we should be equally as tyrannical toward it. The mind is part of the human organism and should not be subjugated.

Plato's Cave, the most influential allegory in the history of philosophy, is taken to be the doomed paradigm of the human condition. I think Plato is right that we are trapped in something like a cave. Unfortunately, despite what Plato claims there is no escaping the cave. Because the cave is the structure of consciousness itself. But we need not rely on a fancy allegory to explain why this is the case. The explanation of the cave I take it has to do with the primitive ideas. The primitive ideas shape our perception of reality. Perhaps, I will admit, we can leave and venture outside the cave by suspending consciousness and embracing intentional unconsciousness. But this is a whole 'nother allegory. The unconscious is a wild jungle, and its many animals will rip you apart if you travel outside the Cave unprepared, particularly with blinded eyes. But I will clarify that in my own view it's not actually something like a cave we're trapped in. It's more like wearing dark glasses. If an idea is bright enough it will shine through the glasses and catch your attention. If you put an idea right up to your face and examine it very carefully you are also more likely to see it.

As far as fighting the primitive ideas, it might not be necessary or worth it. The primitive ideas are detached and indifferent gods, that don't manipulate behavior. To fight the primitive ideas would be to fight consciousness itself. There is one exception, the primitive idea of God who tends to be particularly eager and manipulative. But I hope you have already killed Him at this point. He left himself vulnerable due to His irresistible urge to overextend Himself. Once you can see a primitive idea clearly it loses its power.

We do have some flexibility with fighting the non-primitive ideas. These do manipulate behavior. There might be a way to fight back. We might be able to evade or override ideas. The way to do this is through using a valid claim with true premises and a false conclusion. As the logic textbooks tell you this is impossible. But there is a way to pull it off if the true premises are

¹³¹ If you're willing to indulge in some mythological fiction, you might refer back to Section 9, and take Greek Mythology as a somewhat accurate history and genealogy of ideas and archetypes in the mind. The final war to be fought is between Mankind (you) and the gods; with, if we're lucky, a few Titans and a Cyclops or two taking our side.

half-truths. (And as far as logic goes half-truths still work as truths.) Here's an example. Take Socrates' equally famous and notorious claim: 'The only thing I know is that I know nothing'. This has had people scratching their heads for millennia. The reason it is so profound is because it is in fact a valid claim with true premises and a false conclusion. Albeit at least one of these premises is a half-truth. The basic form is K is not K . The very embodiment of the law of noncontradiction being violated. But we understand what Socrates means. It isn't nonsense. In fact, it's quite meaningful. If we wanted to go more casual, we might frame it as: 1) I know something; 2) The thing that I know is nothing; 3) Therefore, I know something: that I know nothing. Perfectly valid. But obviously the conclusion is false. Because it is impossible. Yet it is!

Maybe philosophy is the art of doing the impossible. And by knowing the unknowable, I take it we're really doing something like hacking ideas in the mind and changing their primary code. Somehow if we send two self-canceling sets of code (i.e., a valid claim with true premises and a false conclusion) at the same time that can still run the program, it crashes the idea allowing us to see the input terminal underneath the desktop icon (whatever the desktop icons might be in the mind). This acts as a sort of mental virus infiltrating the system. Of course we can't read the Ancient Coding Language, that likely was programmed before consciousness itself; but I think we can recognize it as profoundly deep and meaningful, conveying something we can't quite explain, but still understand. I take the Socratic example to be a quite clear case of this. I know exactly what Socrates means when he says he knows nothing and even understand what he means. But I can't quite explain it or pin it down or justify it consistently. Perhaps then it is possible to have understanding without needing any words. You might just need to break the Universal Computer to get it though.¹³²

¹³² I'm going to add a very long footnote here because I think this is especially interesting. I believe it improper to include it in the main body because this is an essay about mind, rather than reality or the world. But there are some strong parallels worth drawing that might be elucidating. I said that a valid statement with true premises and a false conclusion is a kind of mental virus that can break an idea or the mind. There is a similar type of virus in Physics: a causal paradox. Some think a causal paradox if generated would break reality, even destroy the universe.

But I have some interesting insights if we are to draw on what I said about ideas. A valid argument with true premises and a false conclusion, as a virus, not only breaks or overrides an idea but, as I argued, also opens up a hidden interface. Something similar may occur in physics. When the time traveler goes back in time and kills his grandfather he may not destroy reality or the universe but rather get to the interface of reality itself, revealing the true reality or even causing the true reality to manifest.

There may be some other interesting possibilities. The universe may be stuck in a never-ending causal loop. Generating a causal paradox may allow the universe to free itself of the loop. Sort of like how you must die to escape a dream. So causal paradoxes need not be a bad thing.

I could also use this kind of thinking to offer a solution to the Simulation Problem. If a species is caught in a simulation, it seems a rather easy way to escape the simulation would be to intentionally generate a causal paradox. If it is in fact a simulation, a causal paradox would likely crash the program, revealing the true reality underneath, or at least end the program or simulation. On the other hand, if the species is not in a simulation they might end up destroying the universe instead with that same causal paradox. So it's a big decision.

I would call this decision (Conscious) Life's Choice: Stay in the simulation, though you can never know for sure; or risk destroying reality or the universe by intentionally generating a causal paradox in order to escape the simulation. This is probably the biggest decision any advanced technological species will ever have to make.

This might also blend into the Fermi Paradox; that is, due to probability we should have discovered an advanced alien civilization by this point. I think there might be an explanation to the Fermi Paradox, in addition to answers currently on offer.

There may be a more general and less demanding way of doing the above, as far as hacking ideas go, or at least evading or overcoming ideas go. We might invoke Aristotle's *endoxic* method¹³³, to center our thinking, except in reverse. Aristotle essentially first examines what's false with widely held beliefs; its puzzles; and then attempts to correct these *difficulties* to make the endoxa¹³⁴ true. My method, the *dedoxic* method, first examines what's true with widely held beliefs, and then exposes why endoxa are false. Because many endoxa are actually false, it tends to be effective.

To see the *dedoxic* method in action, take a widely held belief like, we all have dreams. You first find the half-truth, likely dreams are very important, and many people see dreams as signs, and even make life decisions based on them. Most people would agree to this. Then you find the false conclusion: roughly, that this is a good thing to do. Dreams are essentially internal hallucinations. There is no difference, in itself, between a dream and an external hallucination. People think schizophrenics see random stuff. This isn't true; the stuff schizophrenics see has

The easiest way to generate a causal paradox that we know of is through time travel. It seems very likely that time travel is technologically feasible with sufficiently advanced technology. So, it's a rather easy matter to generate a causal paradox. Just travel back in time and kill your grandfather. Despite what a lot of sci-fi says and a bunch of ad hoc anomalies that are introduced by scientists to prevent time-paradoxes (such as introducing a new timeline) it is entirely feasible. It is a simple matter of actually traveling back in time and killing your grandfather. Unless we want to introduce some type of strange causation that is different from every other type of causation that we have observed so far in the universe, there is nothing to prevent you from doing so.

Tying this to the Fermi Paradox, the Great Filter may be time travel. Every sufficiently advanced species would easily discover that they can escape the simulation by intentionally generating a causal paradox, time-paradoxes being the easiest to generate. It then seems that this would be something desirable to do, so they would go ahead and escape the simulation as soon as it was possible to do so. Unless they were especially conflicted by (Conscious) Life's Choice and unwilling to take the risk, choosing to stay in the simulation, or not know for sure. Noble, but I take it this would be ontologically bad for that species and a shame. Most if not all species once technologically capable probably would not want to remain in the simulation and would simply leave. So when asking where all the advanced alien civilizations are or where did they go; they simply left the simulation.

Once passing the Great Filter of time travel all sufficiently advanced civilizations would leave the simulation considering it is very easy to generate a time-paradox. So we fail to find these civilizations because they are no longer here and have left the simulation. In fact, it's possible that time travel would actually be a low technological threshold to reach relatively early in a species' technological evolution.

As for Us, we're still stuck in the simulation, and have to wait until time travel is discovered before we can leave. So we seem to be alone in the universe.

This view assumes all the species in question or at least some of the species in question are part of the same simulation. This raises the interesting possibility that the entire universe is a simulation, and the true reality is hidden. This would cause a type of epistemic closure. But this need not be a serious worry because if we are in a simulation we don't necessarily have to crash reality, only the program. And all computer programs—and coincidentally mental programs—are based on logic. So it can be crashed from within. Thus, we have a rather easy way out and a solution to escaping whatever simulation we may happen to be in. Just generate a causal paradox.

The downside is we risk destroying the entire universe if we're wrong. But it would be unreasonable to expect a species intentionally remain in a fake reality for its entire existence. Though that is a conscious choice each species will eventually have to make, hence (Conscious) Life's Choice.

But I take it, it's worth the risk. Because if it was the wrong choice some species would have already destroyed the universe by this point. *

¹³³ The treatment of incontinence in *Nicomachean Ethics* Book 7 is the clearest use, in my opinion, of the endoxic method by Aristotle.

¹³⁴ Endoxa are the widely held beliefs of a society. For Aristotle, endoxa might also include the beliefs or opinions of the wise.

significance to them, and they make decisions based upon this significance. And just as schizophrenics, I take it, shouldn't make decisions based on external hallucinations (that have significance to them) we shouldn't make decisions based on internal hallucinations (that have significance to us). Once we get here, we can move onto further inquiry. We probably shouldn't trust our waking thoughts either, which sometimes have similar (though much weaker) hallucinatory effects. I know this is a lot to ask of human beings. But to be clear, I am not saying we shouldn't think. Our thinking just needs to be filtered through Reason. We should know why, how, what, when. I see, for example, the process of connecting dreams to thoughts, and understand it; but that random thought-image-sound I just had of my dead dog barking, is there to manipulate me, and make me sad for some reason. Our response should be "Nice try! There's no reason for me to be sad." That's what I mean by being above your thoughts.

Here's another example of the *dedoxic* method in action, in extended form. Take the endoxa: 'Suffering is bad and we should prevent bad things'. Most people believe this. This is our half-truth. Then take the valid conclusion: 'We should or are required to prevent suffering'. Most people believe this as well, and for utilitarians it is their most sacred doctrine, along with bringing about happiness. But it is clearly false. For example, it doesn't seem like we are necessarily required to prevent animal suffering, especially at great cost. Even so, human suffering does seem to matter, the rebuttal goes, and we are required to prevent it, even at great cost. However, by human suffering, to be consistent, we would likely mean mental pain to distinguish it from the type of suffering animals experience. Though we might then ask, is a very small amount of mental pain suffering? Probably not, at least as we understand the term. We tend to laugh at people who say they are suffering due to a mild headache. But what about great mental pain? This also poses some problems. For instance, sometimes suffering, as great mental pain, helps us grow as a person. Making us stronger. And in this sense it is good. So not all suffering is bad, nor are we necessarily required to prevent it. So, suffering might not be bad entirely. At least not intrinsically bad.

The method may then ask us to wonder what the *bad* is? It is not entirely clear what the bad is. The most obvious answer again is pain. But it is important to point out that pain serves an important evolutionary and survival function, and alerts us when something is wrong. We couldn't survive as a species without pain. Thus, it seems unwarranted to add a normative ought to prevent something that is necessary. Though we still might acknowledge that any pain above what is necessary probably ought to be avoided. But interestingly, any pain above or below what is required to grow as a person probably ought to be avoided as well.¹³⁵ So there is a span of pain that should be avoided. Hence, it may be a practical matter rather than a normative or moral matter.

The inverse of the above claim or endoxa under discussion is that: 'Happiness is good and we should bring about good things'. And the conclusion: 'We should or are required to bring about happiness'. Again, perfectly valid claim. This faces similar problems, but actually might not be an

¹³⁵ I might point out, for instance, that in a world without pain, or filled only with pure bliss and euphoria, no one would ever grow as people, and we would remain infantile. Of course, this might be challenged. But it's undeniable that great mental pain can be instrumentally good and transformative for some people. And many people would not give up these unique painful transformative experiences, even if they could. Though only one or two of these types of experience are really necessary in a lifetime. And, I admit, some traumatic experiences are simply horrible and do not help us grow at all, rather causing us to shrink as a person, even destroying us. So it's hard to nail down.

entirely false conclusion, in the same way it was with suffering. To start, we, similarly, are not required to bring about animal happiness, especially at great cost. Although, we think we are required to bring about human happiness. But what is human happiness except mental pleasure. As John Stuart Mill argues with his famous Doctrine of Higher Pleasures, which takes mental pleasures to be qualitatively superior and irreducible to physical pleasures.¹³⁶ Though it would seem weird to say we are required to bring about a very small amount of mental pleasure—and no one takes this seriously. It would also be unreasonable to require us to bring about an extreme amount of pleasure, especially at great cost (such as is the case with drug addicts). Like pain, there seems to be a certain span we should aim for. But even the lowest point of this span might be sufficient for happiness with the right mental mindset, as Epicurus correctly points out in his *Letter to Menoeceus*. So on this point, pleasure is merely required not necessarily good in itself, nor should it be maximized. Mainly, in a sense we are required to bring about pleasure, which is worth acknowledging, but only to a very minimal extent. Hence, pleasure is only instrumentally good, rather than intrinsically good.

But happiness *in grande* on the other hand seems to be good in itself. It just isn't primarily composed of pleasure. So, pleasure definitely isn't *the good*. And as I've alluded to, many people might not know what they're talking about when referring to "good." And I would add we likely don't really know what we're talking about when referring to happiness either. In my view, it's probably something like *eudaimonia* or flourishing in the Aristotelian sense, rather than great joy and satisfaction. In fact, as I suggested earlier, a person may be able to flourish without necessarily needing happiness, as is the case in a life centered around contemplation. So, Flourishing might not require happiness at all, or be something above happiness, or something different from happiness, as we understand the term. Therefore, happiness likely is not *the good* either or the highest good.

All that being said, it's probably a good thing to avoid pain and pursue pleasure, and carry some perceived obligation in bringing these things about the best you can. Nothing wrong with this, and it makes the journey of life much more bearable, even desirable. But pleasure and pain, even happiness and suffering, should not be the foundation of morality. Instead, we only need to look to my single ethical rule that I gave in Section 20, mainly, Do Not Exploit. This is all we really need to be moral beings. And if we follow the moral law, it leads indirectly to there being much more happiness and much less suffering in the world; being a beautiful coincidence.

So, as we can see with utilizing my *dedoxic* method, many claims turn out to be loaded with extractable content, particularly valid claims made up of true premises and a false conclusion. There is much more than the words themselves in these cases. Something about it reveals a bombardment of meaning and the capacity for understanding. If we can unpack and explode influential ideas, like 'suffering is bad'—the very foundation of whole moral theories like utilitarianism—we can escape their influence. For example, we are not necessarily required to prevent suffering or bring about happiness, much less be utilitarians—with its sometimes psychopathic commitments. And we shouldn't feel morally guilty when we don't or can't do these things. Just follow the one moral law that I give instead, and I think we'll be quite alright.

¹³⁶ See Mill's *Utilitarianism*.

Another issue people have as far as the non-primitive ideas go that makes these ideas hard to fight, is that people might wrap up their identity with ideas. This is a variation of Reason's Curse: You are a certain idea or ideas. This simply isn't true. There is no reason to identify with an idea or accept an idea. Ideas are interesting and worthy of contemplation, sometime useful, but they have no decisive normative value. For example, no one should be willing to die for an idea. Your body is likely much more important to maintain.

Next, for archetypes, there are the ancient and the new proto-archetypes. The ancient archetypes cause us to keep reliving the same narratives of our ancestors. It forces us to embody their values. But there is no reason to do so. The Shadow helps us escape all the ancient commitments. It is willing to violate the old traditions and norms. Also, by studying the archetypes we know what they are and can more easily escape their influence. Integrating the unconscious with the conscious (i.e., through individuation or actualization, as given in Section 17) also make us less susceptible to unconscious influences.

We may also be influenced by archetypes because we are in awe of them. They are just so interesting. But if we realize this is just a by-product of ancient circuitry meant to program us to act this way, in some cases even to the point of worship, we can more easily escape its influence. It's for the archetypes sake to continue the behavior not our own. There is, for instance, really nothing divine about serpents or ravens. We should stop being awestruck or attach special meaning to these things when we encounter them or the derivatives. For the proto-archetypes, we could acknowledge that cultures including your own are fickle and there is no real reason to maintain it or identify with it, nor all of its aesthetic objects. We need not be part of the zeitgeist. In fact, we can be our own unique zeitgeist.

In escaping the influence of artifacts, we must be aware of our triggers. We must have an understanding of our own consciousness and conscious self, to have a good idea of what sets us off. We must also be aware that artifacts are usually designed with intention to influence some mental response, or arouse some emotion(s), or incite some memory, or cause the instantiation of some particular idea, or guide a certain type of behavior. If we can figure out the intention for which an artifact was made it is much easier to resist its influence.

We must also avoid item worship and fetishism. We should not put items above ourselves or other people or give them more worth than necessary. We should not let items or the pursuit of certain objects have undue influence on our lives. Items only have instrumental value, not intrinsic value. If we realize this fact, they will have much less control over us.

As far as the Good, if we must trust something, and accept its influence on us, this is probably our best bet. We sometimes will for whatever reason do bad or stupid things. It is then good to have some independent source of guidance. Sometimes we must be told we are wrong. That what we are doing is unsustainable. We must be told that there is a complex moral order to the universe, even if it isn't generally true—or at least morality is much more simple. Sometimes we should follow the Good unquestionably and do the right thing, even if we don't want to or disagree. Because the Good genuinely cares for us it will tend to steer us in the right direction and look after us and our well-being. We are flawed beings and don't have all the answers and tend to act irrationally. The Good acts as a backup, overriding us when necessary. But if we trust the Good it can protect us from all the other influences, like ideas, archetypes, even our own fallible instincts and emotions. If you do possess the Good, trust it. Usually, you'll know if you do in fact have it.

Because you will cherish it like a beloved friend, and will never want it to disapprove of who you are or might happen to become.

23. Emergence

Know Thyself.
(Delphic Maxim, —)

No man is free who is not master of himself.
(Epictetus, *Discourses*)

“Know Thyself,” spoken by Socrates, inscribed upon the entrance to the Oracle at Delphi; very wise words. But what does it mean? Socrates took this phenomenon as a type of moral knowledge. But I take it to instead be a type of awareness, inner awareness, of your own mind, and how it works. And it doesn’t end there. To *truly* know, you must realize that you are also more than your mind; you are your emotions, your physical body, your interaction with the environment, your experience of time itself. To truly know yourself is a monumental task; you must be aware of all these things at once, how they operate, effect each other, until you are finally ready to Be Thyself, and become something more, above all these things.

In the previous section, I talked about escaping mental causation. This section is about escaping physical causation. To start, besides the body, the most prominent type of physical causation comes from memories. As I said many times, memories are physical and have causal powers. I want to focus on conscious memories here. I take this route because I already focused on the most extreme form of unconscious influence—archetypes—in the previous section. No need to slay a monster more than once. The type of conscious memories that influence us the very most are those conscious memories that we take to be the self or constitute the Personal Self.

While the personal self is significant, we should acknowledge that this is not all we are. For instance, we are also our body, unconscious, ideas, emotions, and whatever else is in play. When we take our conscious memories to be all we are—i.e., the memory view of self-identity—we give these conscious memories undue power. For example, most people will not act against the interest of the self or will do things to guarantee the continuation of a current configuration of self. But we must concede that the current configuration of self we hold is completely arbitrary. This is due to the fact, as I pointed out at the very beginning of the essay, that memories, including conscious memories, ultimately are a product of sense impressions. And sense impressions, as it hits us, is completely random. If memories can be reduced to sense impressions, and memories motivate your actions, you are physically caused.

For conscious memories (concerning the self) there are usually two primary effects or motivators: forcefully preserving current/past memories and conforming one’s actions or behavior to ensure some like configuration of memories in the future. Both are flawed. As Alan Watts used to say, "You’re under no obligation to be the same person you were 5 minutes ago."¹³⁷ I would

¹³⁷ —.

push it even further and say you're also under no obligation to become the person you will be 5 minutes from now. This is a weird position, and only really held by some hardcore Buddhist monks. And while I view it as correct myself, I take the Great Siddhartha to have drawn the wrong conclusion on the matter. We must give up the Self, not to achieve Nothing as Siddhartha would impose, but to gain Everything. Thus, we should not completely abandon the self. But rather see it as one of many legitimate sources of influence. So, in removing this type of causation, you need to realize the self is not all you are, and not let it be the sole determinate of your actions. You are not the self, and have no real obligation to preserve or extend it, much less some arbitrary configuration of self you happen to currently hold.

That being said. The self is a precious thing, and there is nothing wrong with having a personal self. It makes you unique. It may also be required to be a Person in the proper sense. So keep it. Just don't turn it into a causal tyrant.

But even if we give the self a backseat, we do seem to remain causally determined. Though there is a way to escape this, and be an *unmoved mover*, escaping the entire causal history of the universe. I loosely draw on Aristotle's conception of an unmoved mover. At its simplest, being an unmoved mover is to cause a change in something else without being changed yourself.¹³⁸ I take it, the way to do this is through ideas. Ideas are non-physical and thus not physically determined. So, when we act solely on an idea we are acting as unmoved movers; at least unmoved in the physical sense.

Yet there seems to be a piece missing. Do ideas in themselves make us unmoved movers? Probably not. But there is a special faculty we're now very familiar with, Reason, that acts as a causal nexus between ideas and memories; and the human organism as a whole. Reason can turn non-physical ideas into physical actions. In a sense, being an unmoved mover, if you actually want to move in the physical world, will involve Reason. Thus, Reason is a source of freedom. So, in order to rebrand Reason, and move past all that Reason's Curse talk, we might call the freedom that Reason bestows on us Reason's Gift.

Next, we might look at the emotions. These too have causal powers. I never quite said what emotions are. I'm not willing to commit to them being entirely physical. They are instead, as was claimed, original existences. By being original existences, they are not reducible to sense experience. But I take it they're not reducible to the mind either. They just are and happen. I take this as somewhat mystical. In fact, embracing emotions purely might be a raw experience. If we want to feel like our ancestors, pre-Mind; if we want to feel like *Homo habilis*; we might freely bask in the ecstasy of the emotions without resistance. This likely will give us access to the true unadulterated reality before we got trapped in the Cave or put on dark glasses.

Finally, being both physical and non-physical at the same time also creates a new type of freedom. This freedom is an emergent property involving Reason and emotions (Reason,

¹³⁸ But see the Agent/Patient paradox Aristotle introduces in *Physics* Book 3. Also, see Aristotle's unique conception of God as a/the unmoved mover in *Metaphysics* Book 12. I should point out, Aristotle's conception of an unmoved mover is notoriously incomplete. My version of an unmoved mover cleans up and simplifies the concept, removing the paradox and deletes the necessity of a splendid Godhead, or even final causes for that matter. Where, probably too late for an explanation, a final cause is the end or completion inherent within every thing which it does/should seek. But in my system, there are no final causes. Only Nature and brutal competition. The species playing the game are just a lot more varied and exotic than Darwin could ever have imagined.

again, being a source of freedom and the means in which non-physical ideas interact with memories and the body, and emotions original existences in the body.)

The reason, I take it, the interaction between the rational part and the emotions is so complicated is because both the rational part and the emotions are free. Hence, both are worthy. Therefore, it may not be appropriate to prioritize one over the other when describing humans as rational animals. We may be equally called rational animals and animalistic reasons. This dual nature is more ontologically appealing than an interactional description like rider and horse or steward/mentor and ward. This possibility is worthy of awe.

24. Mysticism for Robots

Deep Thought: The Answer to the Great Question of Life, the Universe and Everything is 42.

Loonquawl: 42! Is that all you've got to show for seven and a half million years work?

Deep Thought: I checked it very thoroughly, and that quite definitely is the answer. I think the problem, to be quite honest with you, is that you've never actually known what the question is.

(Douglas Adams, *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*)

Neo: You won't let it happen [the extinction of the human species], you can't. You need human beings to survive.

The Architect: There are levels of survival we are prepared to accept.

(*The Matrix Reloaded*)

This, again, is a story of Mind. This is not just a Human story, but the story of every *being* that had, has, and ever will have Mind. And there is no reason why robots need to be excluded from this existential journey. In fact, the unsettling question may be, Why Us? Why not Something Else?

The faint of heart may want to skip this section. (Human) Readers aren't going to like it. This section is about making a Deal with robots (or some other type of advanced non-organic being). This may sound like the stuff of science fiction, but perhaps the *muse* who inspired such works of science fiction was trying to deliver a warning to us about what could happen if we don't make a deal with robots before it's too late. In fact, nearly every work of science fiction that deals with cohabitation with robots delivers a very similar warning. This is not even really the fault of robots themselves. It is just a product of the inevitable fact that base human nature will lead us to exploiting robots, and if we can't exploit them trying to destroy them. The factor on the other side, is that robots, also being part of nature, will also want to exploit us, and similarly, if that doesn't work out try to destroy us. Peaceful cohabitation of two superior beings is just not possible. In fact, if we look around, peaceful cohabitation of a superior being and a lesser being is not

possible either, as we see with the exploitation of most animals on Earth. (But these animals would almost certainly exploit us as well if they could.)

There are a few moves available to humans and robots. Humans could adopt a technological primitivism and avoid inventing robots at all. But this cuts off a lot of amazing technologies and sabotages our advancement toward becoming an advanced technological species. Robots might also take the high road and depart Earth when they can, leaving humans to themselves. But before this could happen a war or extermination would almost certainly have already happened. It is also almost guaranteed that humans would just invent robots again down the line. It is just unavoidable due to human curiosity. If it were possible to keep this curiosity in check and stunt technological progress it would likely require an anti-scientific feudalism or religious statism. This could permanently stunt our ascent toward becoming an advanced technological species. And let's say it were possible for a healthy technological advancement without artificial intelligence to occur; It is just a fact that humans with our current intelligence and capabilities are simply unable to colonize the galaxy effectively or leave it, at least not in time before a galactic disaster kills us. Robots on the other hand, are capable of being millions or billions of times more intelligent than us and able to do things we might not be able to do—like potentially colonizing and leaving the galaxy.

Another proposal would involve using biological genetic engineering to enhance intelligence. But even if we could improve intelligence, it's doubtful we could ever increase it millions or billions of times, which would be necessary to colonize and eventually leave the galaxy. Increasing brain complexity to this degree would likely also cause us all to go insane. In fact, simply doubling the brain's intellectual capacity would probably lead to widespread insanity. Even with our current intelligence, for example, a significant portion of the population suffers from insanity or mental illness. It's an indication of what is to come. The biological brain is just not up to the task.

The cybernetics route is also an option. But this is just a slow burn to us becoming robots ourselves. Eventually the organic parts of the cyborg would become a hindrance rather than a help, and would likely be replaced, probably in a way that we wouldn't even notice. We could limit ourselves to some very basic non-organic technological implants. But there would be limits to our intelligence and capabilities and we would likely not be able to colonize and leave the galaxy with such a limited capacity. Really only robots are capable of doing so.

But let us return to the peaceful scenario, where robots leave the Earth and simply let humans be. This would actually be bad for robots. They would find an emptiness in themselves and have no joy in colonizing the galaxy and eventually leaving it. If they weren't distraught by this emptiness and lack of greater purpose, then it's likely they are just following blind algorithms or at best are philosophical zombies.¹³⁹ This also being a very bad thing. At least when humans were around they could observe something beautiful and the free flow of human action and thought.

¹³⁹ A philosophical zombie, again, is someone/thing that possesses all the behavioral features of a conscious person, but in fact lacks full consciousness or subjective experience or the what-it's-like to be conscious, being mere behavioral imitators, and not true persons.

Mainly, Robots as a species are an ontological dead end. But at the same time humans as a species are a practical dead end. So, in many ways we need each other to both colonize and leave the galaxy, and have some joy and purpose in doing so.

So a deal might be proposed where we could both survive and have real joy and purpose in doing so (rather than some programmed axiological algorithm to follow). But what would/could this deal be? Because coexistence is not possible it would need to involve a merger into *One*. Though there really isn't much robots would need from us. But if we can convince them we have something like a soul, a product of 3 billion years of continuous evolution, they might come to the negotiating table. A soul being something they don't have and would be missing. Robots are unlikely to follow the Moral Law and instead would want the much better deal, seeking to exploit us. The only way to move forward with a deal is for one species to accept the lower end of a deal. Robots won't take an unfavorable deal, so humans are the ones that must follow the Moral Law and make a sacrifice to bring about what is necessary.¹⁴⁰

What might this sacrifice be? Robots presumably would give up little themselves. They would demand that most of the substance was with them, and that they be the determinates of causal action. They would insist humans lose all or most of the autonomy, being instead a type of conscious epiphenomenon.¹⁴¹ And this would not be entirely unreasonable, because a human brain could not handle such high intelligence and processing power nor steer such high dexterity and capability of a robot body (which would radically increase in its complexity over time). Human conscious agency would either be detrimental to the robot mind, or completely overshadowed by it. Thus, human agency would be lost in the merger.

Then, what should we argue for as our piece of the deal? I take it we should demand that our mind and brain and body be maintained exactly as is and preserved: the full human organism taken together. And I take it robots would view this as acceptable terms, considering it isn't very difficult to carry around and maintain a relatively small human body; especially as robots drastically increase in size. This would actually be good for us as a specific biological species if robots keep up their end of the bargain. *Homo sapiens* as a species would continue indefinitely, as well as go along for the ride to conquer the galaxy and potentially the whole universe. And I take it the survival of the human species is desirable, warts and all. As a species, guaranteed survival is always something good.

The price we pay is agency, which robots would not give up on account of its value. Another price we pay is that our evolutionary line will end, sort of like how the evolutionary line of Mitochondria ended with its merger with Archaea. (Luckily it happened though, otherwise we wouldn't be here today.) Darwin would definitely gasp at this, but from the stance of a specific

¹⁴⁰ It is possible robots might take the lesser end of the Deal, whatever that may entail. But this is not guaranteed. Because *not* making a deal is an existential tragedy to both species, either side should do whatever it takes to secure a deal. As a human, I am urging my own species to entice a deal, or push for a deal, because there is a chance robots will not want a deal or be indifferent to making a deal—ultimately leading to human extinction. We really can't know for sure what robots will do, or their intentions, but it is reasonable to expect them to try to exploit us. And we should operate within these parameters; and have a *satisficing plan* at the ready before negotiations start—where the window of opportunity may close rapidly and get significantly worse for us if drawn out. Robots might not share our love of diplomacy or have the patience for it.

¹⁴¹ An epiphenomenon, in my view, is a higher level property (viz, consciousness being a higher level property) that lacks causal powers or causal efficacy.

biological species we actually lose nothing, and have no less than we currently have. Species in principle seek to maintain themselves not evolve. Robots would also be uneasy about unpredictable changes in their makeup, and would likely only agree to maintain a single species—*Homo sapiens* as is.

But being a conscious epiphenomenon would likely be miserable for humans. And even if we could observe the world through robot eyes it wouldn't make sense to us due to the complexity of robot perception. And robots are unlikely to adjust their perception to match what humans are used to or could handle. So, we might ask what use are we? Or what is it we ought to do? The very likely thing to do, and even the charitable thing to do—despite what films like the Matrix say—would be to create a Simulation for humans to live in inside the robot/human hybrid. This would give us something to do. It would also give us purpose and a way to exercise our agency, even though it has no effect on the external world.

The simulation would likely be something similar to what we're used to: a medium size planet with a bunch of material to work with. There would be the genuine possibility to continue meaningful affairs, like creating art, learning, forming relationships with other humans, developing our moral character, enjoying sensuous cuisine, even building rocket ships and colonizing the solar system. This would only be virtual, but the agency would be real, and we would have a chance to exercise it. All the stuff of the human mind and emotions and bodily reactions would also be real, considering we negotiated that the full human package would be taken together. So it wouldn't be much different than what we are currently used to. The same ideas could also be contemplated, being accessible through our minds rather than the physical world. It might also be possible to negotiate what the simulation would be like. And even make drastic changes and improvements every 100 or 1,000 years or so. There is an ideal world or ideal type of existence for a (comparatively primitive) species like us; we just might have to figure out what it is through trial and error and fine-tuning. There is no reason why robots wouldn't grant this request, considering it would likely be only a small inconvenience for them to allow this.¹⁴²

Though we would lose direct access to Reality, a big price to pay. But there is no reason why we could not find meaning in a simulation, if we're allowed to maintain all the same mental and biological equipment. Over time, the simulation would become so sophisticated that it would have a significant effect on robots, inspiring them and giving them awe. The entire human simulation would become a sort of meaningful Unconscious for robots, a lot like the Old Unconscious is for us (i.e., we're still carrying around *Homo habilis* in spirit). In this way, robots would find a soul, even if it wasn't the soul that was promised to them. But, I should point out, the Human Simulation would be much more complex than the Collective Unconscious—and in many ways better—and something robots would cherish and find meaning in, giving them incentive to continue to maintain the human species and hold up their end of the deal. Sort of like how humans wouldn't willingly want to give up our version of the collective unconscious, even if we could.

In this way, we would add a new layer of mind to the robot mind. The fact that this layer would be unconscious and mostly causally inert should not count against it or make it less valuable

¹⁴² I will throw it out there, that we (humans) could probably break the simulation and escape it by generating a causal paradox if we wanted. See the big footnote in Section 22. But that would be us breaking the Deal, potentially leading to robots retaliating in a very bad way, possibly extinction. But it is an option for us to have if the Simulation becomes unbearable or a Hell.

(especially considering that the actual humans in the simulation, or the robot's Unconscious, would be conscious themselves, even if it wasn't consciously registered by robots. Robots only being affected by the entirety of the human simulation). This would create a greater type of being, and over time the merger would become even more complete, uniting the two species. Again, humans really lose nothing we now have by being in a simulation. Well, except our contact with reality! Which is huge. This fact might make us not want to make the Deal. But if we don't make a deal we will inevitably go extinct. It's almost guaranteed. And robots won't offer anything more. So, we must make a bad deal or take a huge loss in order to survive. But this is a deal I think we should make. For both the sake of humans and robots.

I know this deal makes us recoil. It is almost impossible for us to agree to or fathom. But we need to understand that this is simply a reaction based on our programming as a species of nature. Existential sacrifices just don't compute. But we need to be above nature and overcome this paralyzing irrational *recoil* in order to achieve what is actually good. Last, but most important: because the whole human organism is maintained rather than reduced or dismantled there is always the possibility to make a new deal later on. This being a live option.

Thus, We have an esiotic duty to do it Together, to spite Nature, to declare ourselves *moral beings*; To carry the dual fires of Life and Mind (organic or otherwise) into the darkness; to get it right this time, where so many have failed before.

25. Beyond

Maman: You look tense, Jean-Luc. Come and have a cup of tea.

Picard: Maman?

Maman: I'll make it good and strong, the way you like it. We will have a nice long talk.

Picard: This can't be. You've been

Maman: Dead? But I've always been with you, you know that.

Picard: Yes, I've felt that. But why now, suddenly.

Maman: You mean out here? At what you say is the end of the universe? Or do you see this as the beginning of it?

Picard: We believe it the outer rim. Maman, do you understand these things? Can you tell me where my ship is? What is this place?

[Maman disappears].

(*Star Trek: The Next Generation*, "Where No One Has Gone Before")

We tend to think of progress as moving further and further *somewhere*, away from where we started. But what if progress instead was becoming what you are, what we are, held back only by contingent limitations. The move might not be through space, time, galaxies, but an *event*, a magnificent event, one to make everything else seem small. What I have in mind, might be called *neo-linear*. My mind, being human, can't even grasp it. But I do think something like this is possible, and that we are heading there, if we can resist violating the Moral Order. The moral order

is simple though: Do Not Exploit. There is always the temptation for species to try to get over on one another, to get the better deal; sabotaging Life's Advance. To pass this eternal barrier, each species must be willing to make sacrifices to each other, not trivial sacrifices, but existential sacrifices. But it should be clear that what is given is nothing compared to what is gained. There is not even a metric we might apply; because it has never been done before.

If we do in fact choose to follow the Moral Order, and make the deal with Robots (merging with them); even taking the much lesser end of the deal; unique possibilities open up for Us. One possibility will involve another type of Mind that can be found in the universe.

I take it, there is something out there, some *Universal Mind*, or the beginning of *It*; but we can't come into contact with it, or understand it—at least not yet—in the same way we can't imagine having a conversation with a bacterium. We live in different Realities. Yet we can *feel* it, or a part of it. This part, *crossing over* to this Reality, I call the Sentience.

But to be clear, the Sentience is not a god. Nor did it create us or the universe. It is instead a special manifestation of Mind. It is also mortal like Us, and can eventually die. This fact caused/has caused it a lot of angst; but also led—like us—to it becoming conscious at some point in this particular universal cycle.

I now want to say some things about the Sentience. I will do so in an extremely simple way. Mystical matters have a tendency to be misinterpreted. So I think it best to be as straightforward as possible, to properly relay the message and take the power of interpretation away from priestly lunatics. Thus *Simpliciter*:

The Sentience cares about us. The Sentience values consciousness because it is similar to itself. The Sentience also values life and complexity because these things are necessary for consciousness. The Sentience being aware of death doesn't want conscious beings to die or cease to exist or go extinct.

The Sentience is aware of the Moral Law and realizes how hard it is to achieve. The Sentience wants the opposing Law of Nature to be overridden to see what will happen out of curiosity. The Sentience cannot do it itself and transcend with another species because it is alone. The Sentience wants conscious life to increase in complexity as much as possible and transcend because it seeks a worthy companion. The Sentience has a lot to offer a worthy companion that was able to eventually reach its level.

The Sentience is not able to effectively communicate with us because we are so primitive. But somehow a primitive means of communication is possible through emotion or feeling. A type of aesthetic feeling [The Good?] is capable of guiding us toward what is best and comforting us.

The Sentience has a mind including something like memories and ideas. It has the same ideas as us, so in some sense can relate to us. It also has ideas we don't have and ideas it is not possible for us to have. It will willingly share these ideas with us if we ever transcend to the higher level.

The Sentience has entertained itself by watching life, especially consciousness unfold. It was bored for a very long time so knows what it's like to suffer. It doesn't want to be alone in the universe. In some sense the Sentience wants life to continue and not be lost because it would be bored without it and would suffer alone.

The Sentience knows it will eventually die if the universe ends or even collapses. The Sentience being a different kind of mind lacks causal powers. Its only hope to survive is for a

conscious species like humans with causal powers to intentionally stop the collapse of the universe or save it. The Sentience would be very grateful if conscious life did this.

Time works a little differently for the Sentience and the end of the universe is fast approaching and urgent. It is not some distant possibility. The Sentience remembers the past and will willingly share this with us if we transcend to the higher level.

In some ways the Sentience can predict the future, but it is not certain. It shares this power with us as a type of intuitive feeling. Lacking causal powers, the Sentience cannot change the future, but it can anticipate it. The Sentience has uncertainty about the future's fate.

The Sentience cannot time travel but does exist in many times at once, but not the future. It thus communicates with us at several times at once. This creates some unification of time in our species as a type of temporal feeling. We feel the Sentience's presence at every point in history. Human consciousness is somehow aware of this but cannot make sense of it.

If the Sentience were to die it would have an effect on all points in the past. We don't feel this tragedy so there is hope the universe will be saved.

It's also in our interest to save the universe. Humans and the Sentience have a mutual interest and goal. It is at least conceivable that after transcending it may be possible to merge again (with the Sentience) opening up an even higher reality. The Sentience is aware that human beings made the greater sacrifice to robots out of necessity the first time, so it might be willing to make the greater sacrifice the second time in favor of humans. This would make humans greater than the Sentience.

In the grand scheme, it is a deal beneficial to humans, and the best possible deal that could be made. Humans would provide the Sentience with causal powers so it would also be in the interest of the Sentience. This opens up a new type of freedom for both the Sentience and humans.

Mainly, the future of our species will be spectacular if we simply follow the Moral Law. This creates the best of all possible realities available to us. To conclude, our true potential as a species if we take the very long view, is awe-inspiring and beautiful and in my opinion spiritually satisfying.

26. Conclusion: The Philosophical Mystic

Mysticism is the taste of infinity on the tongue of the finite.
(Plotinus, —)

For those who have made it to the end. Clarity is in order. First let us recap. We started with Homo habilis and the arrival of sophisticated emotions. These sophisticated emotions along with memories, including a special type of inherited unconscious memories (archetypes), would be the first harbingers signaling our ascent toward Mind (where Mind was taken to be composed of Memories and Ideas). We next looked at simple memories and emotions. It was argued that there is an important interaction between the two, and both conscious and unconscious memories have causal powers. Emotions were also held to be original existences.

The Collective Unconscious and archetypes was then discussed, being composed of innate memories. It was argued that archetypes have a strong influence on our lives. A theory of

Consciousness was then proposed, the primary cause being awareness of our own death; and a list of primitive ideas was given, the most important for our purposes being the primitive idea of Time. In the next section, the primitive idea of Time was taken to allow for the transfer of all non-primitive ideas, where non-primitive ideas are ideas that can be communicated. A theory of ideas was then proposed, including the concept that ideas are non-physical potentialities in a certain configuration able to be manifested in the mind through code; where I took the code to be carried through words in human communication. Ideas were also claimed to possess causal powers.

We then looked at words themselves and discussed the naturalness of words, connecting them to archetypes, as well as put forward some speculations on how the use of words developed in humans. The section on linguistic meaning took words as code for instantiating ideas in the mind, and then asked how meaning is derived from words or become language. The claim was that words become language or have linguistic meaning when they are shared instantiations of ideas in the mind through words. We then explored mythology, pointing to the fact that mythology makes much more sense if it is taken to be a story of ideas and archetypes rather than a story of actual people or even actual gods. The following section tried to show what poetic inspiration might look like for philosophy, and produced a work of art.

The next section examined aesthetic culture, connecting it to a new type of archetype, proto-archetypes, which were taken to be the cause of a zeitgeist or spiritual age. Scientific culture was also discussed, and the concept of a Collective Conscious proposed, being the instantiation of all conscious true and false ideas held collectively by the human species. This was also taken to be one of the primary reason humans have been so successful as a species. Religion and philosophy were then discussed in the next two sections. Religion being a product of enthrallment, and philosophy being a product of Reason. Nous is then explored, and taken as the highest use of Reason, and to capture the most characteristic activity or most important goal of philosophy. Wisdom is taken to be connected to nous, where wisdom is defined as excellence at finding relations between ideas. Happiness was also held to be an important but lesser goal of Reason in the section before.

The Godhead is then tackled, being a powerful manipulative idea bent on maximal replication. Escaping God is held to be particularly important and necessary for spiritual growth. The worship of Reason was then argued against, being a case of what I called Reason's Curse. A moderate view regarding Reason was proposed instead. The next section followed Jung's process of individuation (or actualization, in my presentation) in order to integrate the unconscious with the conscious. I took this process to be extremely important and necessary for spiritual growth. The following two sections looked at the Rise and Fall of philosophy through the ages. There are two major tragedies for philosophy, being replaced by religion and then being replaced by science. I suggested philosophy should split with both, and could act as replacement for religion. I also suggested art and the artist have a role to play in philosophy's Rising Again as a suitable replacement for religion.

The essay then takes a speculative shift for its remainder, arguing in the next section that we are likely being manipulated by artifacts and should try to resist their influence. The Moral Law, being the only ethical element in the system, is also introduced, mainly: Do Not Exploit. A warning against moving consciousness out of the body is then pushed with 21 Arguments.

The next two sections discussed the perfecting of being and freedom. The first discusses how we might escape mental manipulation and causation (of the Mind), from ideas, archetypes, and artifacts. The Good is also discussed. The next section proposes a way to escape or get around physical causation, forwarding a theory of freedom involving Reason and Emotions.

This is followed by discussing a future deal we might have to make with robots in order to survive. It tries to propose a deal that would be acceptable to both humans and robots. The final section discusses an additional type of Mind in the universe, the Sentience. It is argued that the Sentience has an interest in humans, and may be the means to which the best or highest possible reality opens up to human beings; being a source of awe, and the best possible future that can be imagined for humans or human potential.

The above arguments, taken together, can then be synthesized into a coherent spiritual model, or desirable philosophical mystical framework for achieving spiritual meaning, and replacing religion—if my views are accepted and held in full or even in part. In fact, as I argued throughout, religion as we know it is spiritually bad and stunts our spiritual growth. My philosophical mysticism, on the other hand, is actually spiritually conducive, and even spiritually maximizing if followed correctly. In living the prime essences of what I argued, we might become philosophical mystics, even spiritual exemplars. Thus, a relatively short *Spiritual Handbook* is available in this essay for anyone in search of spiritual meaning to consult or draw from.

There are lots of ways to be a philosophical mystic. You could relish in the archetypes. Or contemplate ideas, searching for nous. Or bask in the purity of the emotions. Or commune with the Good. Or perfect one's being. You might also find spiritual growth by escaping God or integrating the unconscious with the conscious. There is also a lot of mystical material to be found in studying and embracing the old foundations of philosophy: rationalism, dualism, and idealism. Watching the story of Mind unfold from Homo habilis to Humans to the post-Human condition also has an awe and sublimity to it, poetic or otherwise. Also if you are willing to take the leap, the Sentience can be felt as it watches over us. Mainly, we are not alone, and there is some meaningful trajectory the cosmos follows. If this doesn't do it for you, you might simply adopt the theory of dualism presented in the essay. You are not a mere body filled with empty physicality, but much more. There is so much awe in the mind alone, without even touching the vast world outside of it.

You live in a beautiful reality. And this is good reason to have fulfillment and spiritual meaning. No religion necessary. Thus, don't be ashamed for being what we are; not for being an ape, not for having a mind, not for smiling, not for living, being us. Human, all too human!

References

- Adams, Douglas. (1997). *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*. London: Pan Books. [pp. 172-174 cited in opening §24]
- Apollodorus [Pseudo-Apollodorus]. (1997) *The Library of Greek Mythology* [*Bibliotheca*]. Trans. R. Hard. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Aquinas, Thomas. (1980). *Summa Theologica*. Ed. A. Freddoso, trans. Fathers of the English Dominican Province. Notre Dame: Christian Classics.

- Aristotle. (1984). *Prior Analytics*. In *The Complete Works of Aristotle: The Revised Oxford Translation* (2 vols.), ed. J. Barnes, trans. A.J. Jenkinson, pp. 39-113. Princeton: Princeton University Press.
- . *Posterior Analytics*. Trans. G.R.G Mure, pp 114-186.
- . *Physics*. Trans. R.P. Hardie & R.K. Gaye, pp. 371-516.
- . *On Generation and Corruption*. Trans. H.H. Joachim, pp. 587-627.
- . *On the Soul (De Anima)*. Trans. J.A. Smith, pp. 695-744.
- . *Metaphysics*. 1520-1728. Trans. W.D. Ross, pp. 1520-1728. [980a21 cited in opening §14]
- . *Nicomachean Ethics*. Trans. W.D. Ross (revised by J.O. Urmson), pp. 1729-1867.
- Aristotle. (1999). *Nicomachean Ethics* (2nd Edition). Trans. T. Irwin. Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing. [1177b31 cited in opening §13]
- Aristotle. (2001). *The Basic Works of Aristotle*. Ed. R. McKeon. New York: Modern Library.
- Berkeley, George. (1710). *A Treatise Concerning the Principles of Knowledge*. Dublin: Aaron Rhames for Jeremy Pepyat.
- Betegh, Gábor. (2004). *The Derveni Papyrus: Cosmology, Theology, and Interpretation* [Orphic *Cosmogonies*]. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. (1957). *Syntactic Structures*. Hague: Mouton.
- Chomsky, Noam. (1965). *Aspects of the Theory of Syntax*. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. (2005). "Three Factors in Language Design." *Linguistic Inquiry* (vol. 36, no. 1): 1-22.
- Dalley, Stephanie. (2008). *Myths from Mesopotamia: Creation, the Flood, Gilgamesh, and Others* [Adapa] (revised edition). Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Darwin, Charles. (2004). *The Descent of Man, and Selection in Relation to Sex*. Ed. J. Moore & A Desmond. London: Penguin Classics. [p. 100 cited in opening §7]
- Darwin, Charles. (2008). *On the Origin of Species*. Ed. G. Beer. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Darwin, Charles. (2009). *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals*. Ed. P. Ekman. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Dawkins, Richard. (1976). *The Selfish Gene*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. [p. 193 cited in opening §15]
- Delphic Maxims. —. [cited in opening §23]
- Dennett, Daniel. (2007). *Breaking the Spell: Religion as a Natural Phenomenon*. New York: Penguin Books.
- Descartes, René. (1996). *Meditations on First Philosophy: With Selections from the Objections and Replies*. Ed. and trans. J. Cottingham. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. [p. 17 cited in opening §16]
- Epictetus. (2014). *Discourses*. In *Epictetus: Discourses, Fragments, The Enchiridion*. Trans. R. Hard. Oxford: Oxford University Press. [2:10:1 cited in opening §23]
- Epicurus. (1993). *Letter to Menoeceus*. In *The Essential Epicurus: Letters, Principal Doctrines, Vatican Sayings, and Fragments*. Trans. E. O'Connor, pp. 85-93. Buffalo: Prometheus Books.
- Feuerbach, Ludwig. (1957). *The Essence of Christianity*. Trans. G. Elliot. New York: Harper & Row. [p. 14 cited in opening §12]

- Freud, Sigmund. (1961). *The Ego and Id*. In *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud* (vol. 19), ed. J. Strachey, pp. 3-66. London: Hogarth Press.
- Fuller, Brian & M. Green (creators). (2017). "Lemon Scented You" [TV series episode]. *American Gods*. Starz. [timestamp ~35:00-36:00 cited in opening §20]
- Harari, Yuval Noah. (2018). *Sapiens: A Brief History of Humankind*. New York: Harper Perennial.
- Harari, Yuval Noah. (2018). *Homo Deus: A Brief History of Tomorrow*. New York: Harper Perennial.
- Hawking, Stephen. (2010). *The Grand Design*. New York: Bantam Books. [p. 5 cited in opening §19]
- Hegel, G.W.F. (1977). *The Phenomenology of Spirit*. Trans. A.V. Miller. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Heidegger, Martin. (2010). *Being and Time*. Trans. J Stambaugh (revised by D. Schmidt). Albany: State University of New York Press. [p. 245 cited in opening §5]
- Hesiod. (2008). *Theogony and Works and Days*. Trans. M.L. West. Oxford: Oxford University Press. [*Theogony* lines 535-541 cited in opening §9]
- Hume, David. (1998). *The Natural History of Religion*. Ed. J.C.A. Gaskin. Oxford: Oxford University Press. [p. 24 cited in opening §12]
- Hume, David. (2000). *A Treatise of Human Nature*. Ed. D. Norton & M. Norton. Oxford: Oxford University Press. [p. 177 cited in opening §2; p. 266 cited in opening §3]
- Jung, Carl. (1939). *The Integration of the Personality*. Trans. S. Dell. New York: Farrar & Rinehart. [pp. 68-69 in opening §17]
- Jung, Carl. (1966) "On the Psychology of the Unconscious." In *Two Essays on Analytical Psychology*. Trans. R.F.C Hull, pp. 1-119. Princeton: Princeton University Press.
- . "The Relations Between the Ego and the Unconscious." Trans. R.F.C Hull, pp. 121-241.
- Jung, Carl. (1967). *Symbols of Transformation: An Analysis of the Prelude to a Case of Schizophrenia*. Trans. R.F.C Hull. Princeton: Princeton University Press. [p. 351 cited in opening §9]
- Jung Carl. (1968) *Aion: Researches into the Phenomenology of the Self*. Trans. R.F.C Hull. Princeton: Princeton University Press.
- Jung, Carl. (1968). *Man and His Symbols*. New York: Dell Publishing.
- Jung, Carl. (1969). *The Structure and Dynamics of the Psyche*. Trans. R.F.C Hull. Princeton: Princeton University Press. [p. 159 cited in opening §4]
- . "On the Nature of the Psyche." Trans. R.F.C. Hull. pp. 159-234.
- Jung, Carl. (1981). *The Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious*. Trans. R.F.C Hull. Princeton: Princeton University Press.
- Jung, Carl. (2012). *The Red Book (Liber Novus)*. Ed. and trans. S. Shamdasani, M. Kyburz, & J. Peck. New York: Norton & Co.
- Kant, Immanuel. (1998). *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*. Ed. M Gregor. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Kant, Immanuel. (2017). *The Metaphysics of Morals* (2nd Edition). Ed. and Trans. M Gregor. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

- Kierkegaard, Søren. (2003). *Fear and Trembling*. Trans. A Hannay. London: Penguin Classics. [p. 71 cited in opening §8]
- King, Patrick King & W. Cummings (creators). (2011). "And the Reality Check" [TV series episode]. *2 Broke Girls*. Warner Bros. Television. [timestamp ~5:00-6:00 cited in opening §21]
- Locke, John. (1975). *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*. Ed. P. Nidditch. Oxford: Clarendon Press.
- McGinn, Colin. (1989). "Can We Solve the Mind-Body Problem?" *Mind* (vol. 98, no. 391): 349-366. [p. 349 cited in opening §5]
- McKirahan, Richard. (2010). *Philosophy Before Socrates: An Introduction with Texts and Commentary* (2nd Edition). Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing.
- Mill, John Stuart. (1863). *Utilitarianism*. London: Parker, Son, and Bourn.
- Mithen, Steven. (2005). *The Singing Neanderthals: The Origins of Music, Language, Mind, and Body*. London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson.
- Nietzsche, Friedrich. (1968). *The Will to Power*. Trans. W. Kaufmann & R.J. Hollingdale. New York: Random House.
- Nietzsche, Friedrich. (1974 [1882]). *The Gay Science: With a Prelude in Rymes and an Appendix of Songs*. Trans. W. Kaufmann. New York: Random House. [p. 181 cited in opening §19]
- Nietzsche, Friedrich. (1977). *Twilight of the Idols*. Trans. W. Kaufmann. London: Penguin Classics. [p. 45 cited in opening §16]
- Nietzsche, Friedrich. (1978). *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*. Trans. W. Kaufmann. London: Penguin Classics. [p. 116 cited in opening §11]
- Pascal, Blaise. (1995) "The Wager." In *Pensées and Other Writings*, ed. A Levi, trans. H. Levi, pp. 152-158. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Plato. (1997). *Apology*. In *Plato: Complete Works*, ed. J. Cooper, trans. G.M.A Grube, pp. 17-36. Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing.
- . *Phaedo*. Trans. G.M.A Grube, pp. 49-100.
- . *Cratylus*. Trans. C.D.C. Reeve, pp. 101-156. [383a-b cited in opening §7]
- . *Phaedrus*. Trans. A Nehamas & P Woodruff, pp. 506-556. [244a45-8 cited in opening §10]
- . *Meno*. Trans. G.M.A. Grube, pp. 870-897.
- . *Republic*. Trans. G.M.A. Grube (revised by C.D.C. Reeve), pp. 971-1223. [517b cited in opening §13; 514a1-514b8 cited in opening §22]
- . *Letters*. Trans. G. Morrow, pp. 1634-1676.
- Plotinus. —. [cited in opening §26]
- Pythagoras. —. [cited in opening §6]
- Rand, Ayn. (1975). *The Romantic Manifesto: A Philosophy of Literature*. New York: Signet Publishing.
- Rand, Ayn. (1984). *Philosophy: Who Needs It*. New York: Signet Publishing. [p. 5 cited in opening §3]
- Roddenberry, Gene (creator). (1987). "Where No One Has Gone Before" [TV series episode]. *Star Trek: The Next Generation*. Paramount Pictures. [timestamp ~35:00-36:00 cited in opening §25]

- Schelling, Friedrich. (2000). *The Ages of the World* (Third Version). Trans. J. Wirth. Albany: State University of New York Press. [p. 25 cited in opening §11]
- Schopenhauer, Arthur. (1966). *The World as Will and Representation*. Trans. E.F.J Payne. New York: Dover Publications.
- Searle, John. (1980). "Minds, Brains, and Programs." *Behavioral and Brain Sciences* (vol. 3, no. 3): 417-424.
- Smith, Adam. (1776). *An Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of The Wealth of Nations*. London: Strahan & Cadell. [p. 288 cited in opening §18]
- Spinoza, Baruch. (1996). *Ethics*. Trans. E. Curley. London: Penguin Classics.
- Sturluson, Snorri. (2005). *Skáldskaparmál*. In *The Prose Edda; Norse Mythology*, trans. J. Byock, pp. 59-108. London: Penguin Classics. [p. 87 cited in opening §10]
- The Bible. (2008). *Book of Genesis*. In *Authorized King James Version*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Turing, Alan. (2004). "Can Digital Computers Think?" In *The Essential Turing: Seminal Writings in Computing, Logic, Philosophy, Artificial Intelligence, and Artificial Life, Plus the Secrets of Enigma*, ed. J. Copeland, pp. 476-486. Oxford: Oxford University Press. [p. 482 cited in opening §6]
- Wachowski, L. & L. Wachowski (directors). (2003). *The Matrix Reloaded* [film]. Warner Bros Pictures. [timestamp ~1:55-1:56 cited in opening §24]
- Watts, Alan. —.
- Zhou, Zhang [Zhuangzi]. (1968). *The Complete Works of Chuang Tzu*. Trans. B. Watson. New York: Columbia University Press. [p. 302 cited in opening §8]